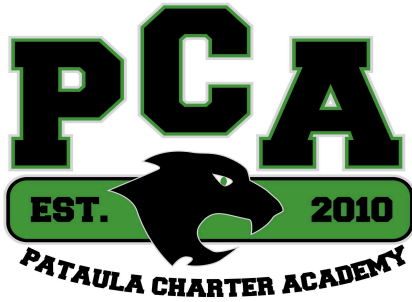




2026-2027

STUDENT/PARENT HANDBOOK

Superintendent: Kylie Holley

Pataula Charter Academy

Principal: Christina Boyd
Assistant Principal: Fallyn Riles
Assistant Principal: Brian Barnhill
Assistant Principal: Casey Cleveland

Spring Creek Charter Academy

Principal: Heather Worsley
Assistant Principal: Samantha Leverette
Assistant Principal: Becca Sawyer
Assistant Principal/Counselor: Julie Bellflower

THIS BOOK BELONGS TO:

Name _____

Grade _____ Crew Teacher _____

This is your Parent/Student Handbook for the 2026-2027 school year. You will receive an acknowledgment of receiving this handbook. Students and parent(s) or guardians are asked to sign the acknowledgement after reading the handbook and return it to your Crew teacher.

Pataula Charter Academy
18637 Hartford St., PO Box 332
Edison, GA 39846
229-354-4001 (Phone)
229-835-2233 (Fax)

Spring Creek Charter Academy
2501 Vada Road
Bainbridge, GA 39817
229-792-8957 (Phone)
229-207-7274 (Fax)

DISCLAIMER

The staff and administration of PCA/SCCA have carefully prepared the information contained in this handbook. The administration acknowledges that not every situation can be covered in a handbook; therefore, we reserve the right to handle each situation as we deem appropriate.

Mission Statement

The **mission** of PCA/SCCA is to prepare students for life-long success by partnering with families and communities to create a safe, nurturing learning environment that engages and challenges students, fosters creativity, and instills integrity and leadership skills that inspire students to reach their full potential.

Core Belief Statements

Families and Community

- Family engagement is vital to the success of our students and our school and will be promoted through open and honest communication.
- Families and the school must work together to cultivate a strong sense of responsibility to family and community.
- Staff, students, and parents are FAMILY at PCA/SCCA.

Safe and Nurturing/Integrity and Leadership

- A child's potential is more fully realized in a positive environment that fosters a sense of responsibility and self-worth and rewards successes.
- Diversity is important and valued.
- The classroom should be a warm and nurturing environment where students are safe to question concepts and express opinions without fear of ridicule or repercussions.
- Respect for fellow students and authority figures should be taught, expected, and consistently enforced through integrity and social, academic, and behavioral responsibility to create a safe and nurturing learning environment for all.
- Leadership skills should be modeled and taught through a variety of methods, and students will be given ample opportunity to exhibit those skills.

Engaging and Challenging to Meet Full Potential/Creativity

- Every child has the potential to learn. Our teachers will facilitate and promote growth in all learners to help them reach their full potential.
- All students do not learn the same way, so instructional strategies should be varied to meet the specific learning styles of all students.
- Effective classrooms engage students by offering meaningful, hands-on, cross-curricular learning opportunities that foster creativity, encourage critical thinking, and communicate relevance to the student.
- Students learn best when they take ownership of their own learning. Therefore, the teacher will act as facilitator while students interact with and guide one another through the learning process.

Life Long Success

- Students will be taught a variety of life skills that will help them be productive citizens.
- Students will be exposed to a variety of experiences that help them determine college and/or career goals.

Curriculum and Assessment

The Georgia Standards of Excellence are the focus of our schools' curriculum. The rationale for this is: 1) As a Georgia public school, our schools are required to participate in all state mandated testing; 2) State mandated tests are aligned to the Georgia Standards of Excellence (GSE). However, teachers are encouraged to dig deeper into the content and skills required by GSE, as many standards only skim the surface of topics and do not give students a full understanding of the topics. We seek to make "experts" of the standards, especially in our Expeditions.

We use a hands-on, student-centered approach to learning. We recognize that the nature of education does require that some concepts and skills be taught through direct-instruction, but most of those same concepts and skills can be practiced and applied through hands-on, authentic projects. Therefore, we use a combination of direct instruction and project-based learning. Teachers integrate all areas of the curriculum as much as possible to make connections, which deepens learning. **Due to our approach, our schools use very few textbooks.**

Our schools focus on teaching the whole child. We offer special programs and opportunities to help each student experience success in a variety of activities. Our schools also offer special needs programs such as gifted, remedial education, and special education classes. The instructional program provides opportunities for the teacher, the parent, and the child to cooperatively share the responsibility for academic growth.

Crew

"Crew" is a vital part of our school model. Crew is a 30-minute block/class each day where students and teachers/advisors develop relationships and bonds, build character, and reflect on classroom/community issues. In high school, this is also a time for college/career advisement. Because all of these things are an integral part of our schools' mission and core beliefs, it is expected that ALL students in our school participate in Crew every day. A grade will be given in Crew for high school students, which will be part of the student's overall GPA.

Field Work

Teachers may take students on walking or bus trips to conduct field work for educational purposes. All field work will be tied directly to state standards. Parental permission will be required for such trips. **Students must ride the bus on these trips.** Students who do not ride the bus will not be allowed to participate with the class if they show up at the venue of the field trip. The student will also have an unexcused absence for the day if this happens. Parents may sign their child out for the day at the conclusion of the trip. The teacher will have a sign-out sheet. Once signed out of school for the day, the student does not have to ride the bus back to the campus. However, the student may not return to school. Although field work is a vital part of the learning experience, students may be denied participation in field work if there is a discipline history that poses a safety concern. **The Principal will make final decisions on this.**

Since Field Work is a vital part of the learning process at PCA/SCCA, we strongly encourage ALL students to attend. If a student does not attend (whether due to administration decision or **parent/student choice**), the student will be required to complete an alternate assignment that demonstrates the learning he/she would have obtained on the field work trip.

Parents who are able are encouraged to help chaperone with their child's class. **Parents may not bring siblings or other children to Field Work.** Other responsible adults over the age of 21 may be approved as chaperones in lieu of a parent chaperone, on a case-by-case basis. Chaperones will be required to sign a contract stating they have read and understand our Field Trip Chaperone Policy and complete Mandated Reporter Training. Chaperones may also have to attend Field Work Training for each field work trip to be better able to assist with the learning targets for the trip. Chaperones for overnight field work will be required to get a background check. **If these guidelines and the Chaperone Policy are not followed, parents may be prohibited from attending/chaperoning further trips.**

Homework

Homework assignments are an important part of a student's learning and may be used to reinforce and practice skills taught at school. Each teacher establishes the homework policy for his/her class. Daily homework is a built-in component of some of our instructional programs. Students are required to write homework down each day. If a student forgets to write down the assignment, they should call a classmate, not the teacher. Please check your child's daily homework assignments. Not turning in homework could be considered a violation of our code of conduct.

Habits of Work (HOWs)

We believe that quality habits of work are an essential part of student success both in learning and life. Teachers strive to help students learn that there is a distinct correlation between habits of work, academic achievement, and learning.

Grades K-8 teachers will track habits of work for each student and will communicate progress on them to parents. Schools will also create a plan for celebrating and awarding the accomplishments of demonstrating good Habits of Work.

The habits of work (HOWs) at PCA/SCCA are based on the school-wide design principles and are grouped into three categories.

HOW #1: How I participate in class

Design Principles:

- Responsibility for Learning
- Collaboration and Competition

Learning Targets:

1. I can complete homework and other assignments on time.
2. I can arrive for each class on time and be prepared with all materials.
3. I can stay on task by listening and following directions in class while working independently and in a group

HOW #2: How I approach learning challenges

Design Principles:

- Self Discovery
- The Having of Wonderful Ideas
- Success and Failure
- Solitude and Reflection

Learning Targets:

1. I can improve my learning by seeking help when needed, asking questions, and accepting feedback from others.
2. I can persevere to create high quality work.
3. I can use goal setting, self-assessments, and reflection to improve my learning.

HOW #3: How I interact with others

Design Principles:

- Empathy and Caring
- Diversity and Inclusion
- The Natural World
- Service and Compassion

Learning Targets:

1. I can express myself with kind words and actions.
2. I can use all materials with proper care and leave no trace when finished.
3. I can demonstrate self-control with my words and actions.

Standards-Based Assessment

The goal of assessment at PCA/SCCA is to ensure that teachers throughout the school, both across content areas and grade levels, consistently implement a system of grading and procedures that informs parents and students about student learning on the required standards with detailed, accurate, and meaningful feedback for the purpose of maximizing student learning. Therefore, our schools use Standards-Based Assessment which meets our goals of having accurate, consistent, meaningful feedback that supports the progression of learning.

Late Work/Make Up Work Policy

Work Assigned And Not Turned In (LATE WORK): Assignments are due by the teacher specified deadline. In an effort to encourage students to turn in assignments in a timely manner, points will be deducted for assignments turned in late. **Assignments never turned in will be recorded as a zero in the gradebook with a comment to show the work is missing.**

If Absent From School (MAKE UP WORK): Arrangements for make-up work missed during an absence must be made within three (3) school days after the student returns to school. The student is responsible for making the arrangements with each subject teacher for make-up work. If arrangements are not made or work is not completed, grades will then be closed on missed work, and incomplete work will be recorded as zeroes. Assignments that have been assigned over a period of three or more days prior to the student's absence are due according to the teacher's specifications to the class. Students who miss class due to an extracurricular activity/athletics are responsible for work missed upon returning to class unless prior arrangements have been made with the teachers. Students are advised and encouraged to make contact with the teacher before such absences. Long-term assignments such as research papers, special projects, etc. are due on or before the due date even if the student is absent on the date the assignment is due. In unusual cases, extenuating circumstances will be considered.

ISS/OSS Missed Work: Classwork, including quizzes and tests, should be completed in ISS and turned into the teacher. Work not turned in at the completion of ISS will be treated in the same manner as Late Work above. Students who have OSS are responsible for obtaining all assignments from teachers during the suspension period. All work will be due upon the day the student returns to school, any unsubmitted work will result in a zero. Quizzes or tests given on OSS days will be given immediately upon return to class.

Calculating the Final Grade for a Class

Grades are given on a 100 point scale. Grades in the "gradebook" will be weighted depending on the type of assessment.

Grading Categories and Weights

Category	Description	Elem Weight	Middle/ High Weight
Major	Assignment/assessment cumulative in nature that measures learning targets	15%	40%

	from multiple standards/skills <i>Examples: unit assessments, projects, presentations, papers, etc.</i>		
Minor	Assignment/assessment that measures an individual learning target <i>Examples: quiz, cooperative activities, labs, etc.</i>	50%	35%
Daily	Daily assignment, observations, engagement activities used to build pre-requisite skills, measure progress towards mastery of a learning target, enrich/remediate skills <i>Examples: fluency checks, spiral reviews, question sets, etc.</i>	35%	25%

Final Grades K-8: Each nine week grade will be averaged to create a final grade for the course at the end of the school year..

Final High School: Courses in high school receive final grades and are awarded credit by the semester rather than the year. **Final grades will be calculated and ½ course credits are earned at the end of each semester.** The final semester grades will be calculated by weighting the two 9-weeks grades and the EOC or final exam as follows:

- 1st 9-weeks of semester grade = 40%
- 2nd 9-weeks of semester grade = 40%
- EOC or Final Exam = 20%

Reporting of Grades

- Parents will be provided with Infinite Campus account login information at the beginning of the school year. **Parents/students can access the Infinite Campus account online anytime to stay up-to-date on their child's progress.**
- Assessments will be labeled by name and will include a description of the skill/content assessed, so parents can identify areas of strengths and weaknesses on each learning goal.
- Report cards will be printed from Infinite Campus and sent home each nine weeks. **Reports cards should be signed by a parent and returned to the Crew teacher for all grades, K-12.**

Grading Scale:

A = 90-100 B = 80-89 C = 70-79 F = below 70 I = Incomplete NC = No Credit

Promotion and Retention

The following criteria must be met in order to be promoted to the next grade. For any student not meeting the criteria, a committee will be formed consisting of no less than a parent, teacher, and administrator, to make the final determination for promotion/retention.

Elementary

- Must pass the Reading/English Language Arts state assessment (if one is given)
- Must pass the Math state assessment (if one is given)
- Must pass Reading/ELA for the year (must have a final grade of at least 70%)
- Must pass Math for the year (must have a final grade of at least 70%)

Middle

- Must pass the Reading/English Language Arts state assessment (if one is given)

- Must pass the Math state assessment (if one is given)
- Must pass Reading/ELA for the year (must have a final grade of at least 70%)
- Must pass Math for the year (must have a final grade of at least 70%)
- Must pass Science OR Social Studies for the year (must have a final grade of at least 70%)

High

- To enter 10th Grade: 5 Carnegie Units
- To enter 11th Grade: 11 Carnegie Units
- To enter 12th Grade: 17 Carnegie Units
- To Graduate: 23 Carnegie Units

*Note - High School students do not have to retake earned credit even if they are not “promoted” to the next grade; they may be assigned to Credit Recovery the following year or any year of high school after, for any failed courses. For GPA calculations the new grade will be averaged in with all other grades; it will not replace a failed grade for the same course.

Method of Computing GPA:

Numerical Unweighted GPA:

All numerical grades in all courses taken in grades 9-12 are averaged together for the numerical GPA. We do not add any weighting to numerical grades on the transcript.

Cumulative Weighted GPA:

The Cumulative Weighted GPA includes all courses taken in grades 9 – 12. For this GPA, .5 points are added to the 4.0 scale for Dual Enrollment courses taken in academic areas and 1.0 points will be added for Advanced Placement Courses. To determine the GPA, all course credit is added together and divided by the number of credits taken.

High School Credits

A = 4.0
B = 3.0
C = 2.0
F = 0.0

Dual Enrollment Credits

A = 4.5
B = 3.5
C = 2.5
F = 0.0

Advanced Placement Credits

A = 5.0
B = 4.0
C = 3.0
F = 0.0

****From the 20/21 through 22/23 school year, weight to Dual Enrollment courses above a 4.0 was not awarded. Transcripts of DE courses taken in those years will show a 4.0 for an A. Beginning the 23/24 SY and beyond, an A will be awarded a 4.5. This is for school GPA only, GaFutures does not calculate grades above a 4.0 for HOPE scholarship calculations.**

Final Exams, Benchmarks, and Standardized Tests

1. Teachers will administer Benchmarks as follows:
 - a. **ALL Grade levels K-12** - MAP Growth benchmark tests will be given 3 times per year for benchmarking and progress monitoring/intervention purposes.
 - i. Grades K-2 - Reading and Math
 - ii. Grades 3-5 - Reading, Language, and Math
 - iii. Grades 6-12 - Reading, Language, and Math (Students in a corresponding Dual Enrollment class do not take that MAP Growth benchmark.)
2. State Mandated Assessments and Final Exams:

- a. **Grades K:** GKIDS Kindergarten Readiness Check and GKIDS will be given according to guidelines.
- b. **Grades K-3:** Universal Reading and Dyslexia Screener (3x per year)
- c. **Grades 3 - 8:**
 - i. 3rd, 4th, 6th, 7th grades - ELA and Math Milestones EOG
 - ii. 5th - ELA, Math, and Science Milestones EOG
 - iii. 8th - ELA, Math, Science, and Social Studies Milestones EOG
- d. **High School:** Each course will also have an end of semester Final Exam or End Of Course state assessment which will count for 20% of the student's final First Semester grade. ****See exemption guidelines below.**
 - i. Required EOCs, regardless if the course is a high school level course or Dual Enrollment course - Lit and Comp II, Algebra Concepts and Connections, and Biology
 - ii. Required EOC if taking the high school level course, but exempt if taking for Dual Enrollment - US History
 - iii. Advanced Placement Exam - must be taken at the completion of an AP Course
 - iv. End of Pathway Exam (EOPA) - Student completing the 3rd course in a pathway will take the corresponding EOPA
- e. **English Learners** - GaDOE ACCESS test will be given to all eligible students.
- f. **GAA** - Some students with disabilities qualify for the GAA, an alternative to Milestones testing. The IEP team will determine which state assessments are appropriate for the student based on the state criteria.

*All students will take state mandated standardized tests as required by the GA DOE. These are listed above, but subject to change.

End of the Year Awards and Recognition

1. Panther Pride Award/Stallion Pride Award-These students exemplify the "PCA/SCCA Way" by showing good character and Habits of Work. Two students will be chosen from each Crew or grade level for this award each year. This is a prestigious award and should be treated as such when choosing recipients and acknowledging the award. Students who have had chronic and/or major discipline infractions and who do not consistently exemplify our core beliefs and design principles should not be chosen.
2. Academic honors:
 - a. **A/B Honor Roll:** Final Grade of **80** or higher in EACH subject/course
 - b. **A Honor Roll:** Final Grade of **90** or higher in EACH subject/course
 - c. **Principal Scholar:** Final Grade of **95** or higher in EACH subject/course
3. **Principals will give a cut off date for the Final Grade to be used for Awards. This does not mean grades cannot be taken after the award cut-off date, but will allow us to prepare for awards programs.**

Graduation Awards and Recognition

Graduation Honors: Honor Graduates, Valedictorian, Salutatorian, Senior Superlatives, and Junior Marshal Criteria is based on the weighted core academic GPA cumulative from 9th grade through Quarter 3 of 12th grade year. The detailed criteria for these are explained as follows:

1. **Senior Superlative and Junior Marshal Criteria:**
 Senior Superlatives and Junior Marshals are students who embody the PCA/SCCA Way in alignment with the schools' Mission Statement and Core Beliefs. The mission of PCA/SCCA is to prepare students for life-long success by partnering with families and communities to create a safe, nurturing learning environment that engages and challenges students, fosters creativity, and instills integrity and leadership

skills that inspire students to reach their full potential. Therefore, Senior Superlatives and Junior Marshals demonstrate the following:

- A positive attitude
- A desire for quality education
- A strive for excellence
- School spirit and school involvement
- Respect towards fellow classmates and authority figures
- Reliability
- A responsibility to their school and community
- Leadership skills
- Productive citizenship skills

Eligibility Requirements:

- To be eligible, students will submit a resume detailing the above criteria to use for voting purposes.
- The resume will be cumulative from grade 9 through Q3 of grade 12 for Senior Superlatives and grade 11 for Junior Marshals.
- All high school teachers and the High School student body will vote: Teacher vote will count 70 % and student body vote will count 30%.
- Top **15%** of the class will be selected based on the total number of students in the class.
- Students must have a minimum GPA of 3.0 to qualify and be in good standing. *NOTE - GPAs are not rounded.

2. Honor Graduate (Academic) Criteria:

- Based on Cumulative Weighted GPA from grade 9 through Q3 of grade 12.
- Val - #1 based on rank – Must have been enrolled at PCA/SCCA for their final 4 semesters of high school.
- Sal - #2 based on rank - Must have been enrolled at PCA/SCCA for their final 4 semesters of high school.
- In the event of a tie, the numerical GPA will be used to break the tie.
- Cum Laude – Cumulative Weighted GPA of 3.6 or above (from grade 9 through Q3 of grade 12)
- Magna Cum Laude – Cumulative Weighted GPA of 3.8 or above (from grade 9 through Q3 of grade 12)
- Summa Cum Laude – Cumulative Weighted GPA of 4.0 or above (from grade 9 through Q3 of grade 12)

3. Graduation Bibs, Stoles, Cords, and Tassel Criteria:

Caps/Tassels – You may not decorate or alter your cap in any way. Only the school issued tassels should be worn; no special tassels other than STAR Student tassels are allowed.

- **STAR Student** - Gold Tassel

Medallions, Bibs, and Stoles – No bibs, stoles, or medallions other than the following school approved stoles and cords are allowed:

- **Valedictorian** - Medallion with Gold Ribbon
- **Salutatorian** - Medallion with Green Ribbon
- **Senior Superlatives** - Green PCA Bib/Garnet SCCA Bib
- **Summa Cum Laude** - Gold Stole
- **Magna Cum Laude** - Silver Stole
- **Cum Laude** - White Stole

*Stoles may be embroidered to signify an Associate's Degree of Certification program. The student will wear the appropriate color with a black embroidery for this honor. The stoles must be verified and pre-approved. No other embroidery or decoration may be added.

Cords - No cords other than the following school approved cords are allowed:

- **Member of Beta Club** - Gold Cord
- **Intent to Enroll in Military** - Red/White/Blue Cord
- **Dual Enrollment (at least 4 DE courses passed)** - Charcoal Cord
- **AG Pathway Completer (taken 3 courses in a Pathway AND beginning w/ % 2026 also passed EOPA in that Pathway)** - Green Cord
- **Business Pathway Completer (taken 3 courses in a Pathway AND beginning w/ % 2026 also passed EOPA in that Pathway)** - Blue Cord
- **FFA State Degree** - Blue/Gold Cord
- **4H (issued by local 4H program)** – Green/White Cord
- **ACES Diploma** - White Cord
- **PCA Lifetime Panther (attending K-12 with no withdrawals)** - Black/Green/Silver Cord (this replaced Original Panther beginning with the Class of 2024)
- **SCCA Original Stallion (attended since the school opened with no withdrawals)** - Gold/Garnet Cord (this will change to Lifetime Stallion after the Class of 2033)

*Medallions from the school year Honor's Day are not to be worn at Graduation - those honors are for the current year only and the above honors are for the entire high school career.

High School Graduation Requirements

The following credits are required for graduation:

English Language Arts

4 credits

One English class in each year of high school, including Literature/Composition I and Literature/Composition II (or their equivalents) and, and 2 additional units of ELA

Mathematics

4 credits

Algebra Concepts and Connections, Geometry Concepts and Connections, Advanced Algebra Concepts and Connections, (or their equivalents) and a 4th Math Unit

Science

4 credits

Biology; Physical Science or Physics; Chemistry, Environmental Science, or Earth Systems; (or their equivalents) and a 4th Science Unit

Social Studies

3 credits

World History, United States History, United States Government/Civics - 1 semester, and Economics - 1 semester

Career, Technical and Agricultural Education, Fine Arts, Modern Language

3 credits

Students must earn 3 credits, in any combination, from these three curriculum areas. *Students planning to attend a 4-year college or university immediately after high school must earn a minimum of 2 credits in a modern language.

Health and Physical Education

1 credit

½ credit per course. Each course is one semester in length. Typically taken in the 9th grade.

Electives

4 credits

Electives can be taken in any curriculum area. *Students planning to attend a 4-year college or university must take 2 credits of Foreign Language and are encouraged to take at least 2 electives from academic curriculum areas.

Total Credits Required to Graduate

23 credits

Types of Graduation Credentials

- a) **High School Diploma (a/k/a Regular Education Diploma)-** the document awarded to students certifying that they have satisfied attendance requirements, unit requirements and the state assessment requirements as referenced in Rule 160-3-1-.07 Testing Programs - Student Assessment.
Types of High School Diplomas Seals at PCA/SCCA:
 - i) *Dual Enrollment Seal – Completed all regular graduation requirements AND completed at least 4 Dual Enrollment credits.*
 - ii) *CTAE Pathway Seal - Completed all regular graduation requirements AND meets requirements for CTAE Pathway Completer*
 - iii) **Students may earn both seals.*
- b) **High School Certificate (a/k/a Certificate of Attendance)-** the document awarded to pupils who do not complete all of the criteria for a high school diploma or who have not passed the state assessment requirements as referenced in Rule 160-3-1-.07 Testing Programs – Student Assessment, but who have earned 23 units.
- c) **ACES Diploma –** the document awarded to students with the most significant cognitive disabilities who were assessed using the alternate assessment aligned to alternate academic achievement standards.

***See Graduation Policy for more detailed information.**

High School (1st & 2nd) Semester Exemption Criteria

***Students exempting exams will receive their semester course average as the grade in the course.**

High school students may exempt all final exams for **NON-EOC** courses at the end of Semester 1. Students are not allowed to exempt Semester 1 finals for a course in which there is an EOC at the end of the course/year. High school students may exempt all final exams for **NON-EOC** courses at the end of the 2nd Semester. Students are not allowed to exempt required EOC assessments. These courses are as follows: ***Lit/Comp II, U.S. History, Biology, and Algebra Concepts and Connections. Students taking US History through Dual Enrollment are exempt from the EOC. No other EOCs may be exempted.***

The criteria for exemption eligibility are as follows:

****Students assigned in-school suspension or out of school suspension during that semester are not eligible for exemption.**

Class Average	Absences (By class period)	MAP Growth
C	0	Must Meet Growth Goal OR meet Achievement Norms (61% or higher) at the end of each semester for that course in the corresponding benchmark (Reading and ELA for an ELA course)
B	3 or fewer	
A	5 or fewer	

*Absences that are excused by Co-Curricular, Military, Non-Instructional days or Administrative days do not count against the student for exemption purposes. All other absences count for exemption purposes (Excused &

Unexcused). For the purpose of exemptions only, two unexcused tardies and/or early class dismissals equals one absence.

Absences from semester exams may only be excused in the case of personal illness covered by a doctor's verification or a death in the family. The student has 3 days upon returning from an excused absence to make up the final exam. Approval to take exams at an alternate time due to extenuating circumstances may only be granted by the Principal. Students requesting an alternate exam time must petition the Principal in writing. Teachers may require students to complete alternate forms of exams such as portfolios, projects, or performances. Alternate forms of exams may not be required to be completed during the exam period.

PCA Advanced Placement Courses

***AP will not be offered if less than 5 students enroll in the class.**

***SCCA has not yet added AP courses, but plans to in the future.**

BENEFITS OF AP COURSES:

- The course will add additional weight for the student's GPA. The weight will be 1 extra GPA point. So, an A will earn a 5.0 rather than a 4.0, a B will earn a 4.0, and so on. *Dual Enrollment courses will continue to be weighted .5 extra GPA points. *Students are required to take the AP Exam at the end of AP courses in order to receive the extra 1 GPA point.
- The course can potentially earn college credit. This is based on the student's score on the AP Exam and colleges' criteria. Most colleges require a 3 out of 5 on the exam, but you should check with your chosen college for more information.
- Some colleges prefer to see that a student has taken some AP courses, so it could be beneficial for college acceptance.
- The courses will better prepare students for the rigor of college classes, specifically in writing papers for these particular courses being offered.

CRITERIA FOR AP ELIGIBILITY:

AP Seminar:

- Overall GPA of 3.5 or higher
- Must have earned an A in the most recent High School ELA course
- Must be on track to graduate on time with NO credit recovery courses
- ELA teacher recommendation

AP Research

- Must have taken and passed AP Seminar

COURSES OFFERED:

AP Seminar - 2024-2025 School Year and beyond

Develop and practice the skills in research, collaboration, and communication that you'll need in any academic discipline. You'll investigate topics in a variety of subject areas, write research-based essays, and design and give presentations both individually and as part of a team.

Skills you will learn:

- Reading and analyzing articles, studies, and other texts
- Gathering and combining information from sources

- Viewing an issue from multiple perspectives
- Crafting arguments based on evidence

AP Research - 2026-2027 School Year and beyond

Build on what you learned in AP Seminar to deeply explore an academic topic, problem, or issue of individual interest. Through this exploration, you will design, plan, and conduct a year-long research based investigation to address a research question.

Skills you will learn:

- Conducting independent research
- Analyzing sources and evidence
- Applying context and perspective
- Writing a college-level academic paper
- Presenting research findings to an audience

COLLEGE COURSE EQUIVALENTS:

AP Seminar and AP Research are interdisciplinary courses that encourage students to demonstrate critical thinking, collaboration, and academic research skills on topics of the student's choosing. To accommodate the wide range of student topics, typical college course equivalents include interdisciplinary or general elective courses. Colleges make the decision for the equivalent credit. You should check with the college you intend to attend for more information.

PCA/SCCA Dual Enrollment Guidelines

The Dual Enrollment (DE) Program is for high school students. The program allows students to pursue postsecondary study while receiving dual high school and college credit for courses successfully completed at the college. Courses taken in this program must come from the approved DE Course Directory - refer to www.gafutures.org. Each postsecondary institution has different testing and admission requirements for participating in DE. Students may take courses from any approved post secondary institution. Students who wish to participate in DE are required to adhere to the following guidelines:

- Criteria for Dual Enrollment Eligibility:
 - Students in grades 11 and 12
 - For colleges/universities, GPA of 3.0 or higher and on-track to graduate (no pending credit-recovery)
 - For technical programs of study, GPA of 2.5 or higher or the requirement of the tech school (whichever is higher) and on-track to graduate (no pending credit-recovery).
- If a DE course is offered on campus, students may not take that particular course away from the PCA/SCCA campus (at the college, another college, and/or on-line). This is to ensure we maintain enrollment numbers to continue on-campus courses.
- Students pursuing the DE Core Course Plan of Study must take the on-campus courses available each semester in the sequence offered, IF on-campus courses are available.
- Each semester students earn one unit of high school credit for 3 to 5 hour courses passed at the college level. For a one hour or two-hour college course, students would earn .5 units of high school credit. Grades for courses taken at college will be placed on the high school transcript and will count in your high school HOPE GPA. If the college reports a number grade, that grade will be used. Some colleges only give letter grades. These will be converted to numerical grades and placed on the high school

transcript as follows: A = 95, B = 85, C = 75, D = 70, F = 65. Students may request that the professor send the numerical grade (if available) to the PCA/SCCA Dual Enrollment Coordinator if the student wishes to use that numerical grade rather than these conversions.

- PCA/SCCA adds .5 point honor weight to DE courses.
- The HOPE Scholarship adds a .5 point honor weight to DE courses taken in academic core areas, not to exceed a 4.0. For example, a “B” (which is a 3.0 on the 4.0 GPA scale) in English 1101 would convert to a 3.5 for HOPE purposes. So, an “A” would remain a 4.0 for HOPE purposes. However, PCA/SCCA will continue to give the .5 honor weight for an “A” for high school GPA.
- **Grades earned at the college can negatively affect the student’s GPA.** This could affect eligibility for the HOPE Scholarship after high school graduation. **Failing a DE course could prevent the student from graduating on time.** A student who fails a DE course may not be allowed to participate in the DE program the following semester, at the discretion of school administrator(s).
- Students must be enrolled in a combination (PCA/SCCA and postsecondary institution) of at least six classes - Study Hall **DOES NOT** count as one of the six classes.
- Students who participate in DE are required to report to their assigned Crew and Advisement daily.
- DE students who take DE course equivalents of the following courses are required to take the Milestone Assessment: Biology (unless Biology was already taken in high school). The Milestone Assessment will count 20% of the final grade in the course for high school transcript purposes only, with the letter grade counting 80%. College transcripts will report the final letter grade earned in the course. **It is the student’s responsibility** to get dates and times for the Milestone Assessment.
- College credit obtained at one postsecondary institution may or may not be transferred for credit to another institution. It is the student’s responsibility to make sure that any college courses taken will transfer to the institution they plan to attend. The student is responsible for obtaining and sending the college transcript.
- Students may not begin participating in DE for the first time in the spring semester, with the exception of seniors who receive administrative approval.
- Withdrawing from a DE course after the drop/add deadline will result in a grade of “F” on the high school transcript for that course.
- Students may not contact colleges about dropping a course without approval from the principal.

Parent Communication and Involvement

Our schools will provide timely, clear, and effective communication to the staff, students, parents, and other stakeholders. As children advance through the grade levels, the needs and methods for teacher/parent communication change. Your child’s teacher will communicate the specific requirements for communication (signing agenda, behavior notes, grades etc.).

As a school, we primarily rely on electronic communication. Therefore, it is important that you provide your email address and cell phone number on the request form you will receive at Open House. We also post information on the schools’ websites and Facebook pages. Our schools use **Parent Square**, a communication platform for parents, to send school-wide notifications. Teachers and coaches will also use Parent Square for important parent communications. Instructions for joining *Parent Square* will be sent home at Open House and can be found in the front office. ***Infinite Campus Parent Portal*** is also available for each parent to be able to check their child’s grades, attendance, and lunch balance online. PTO, Board Meetings, and other informational meetings serve as another forum to obtain information regarding curriculum, school procedures, policies, or celebrations of learning achievements.

Staff members will also be available to parents via phone, email, or in person by appointment from the hours of 7:40-3:40 each weekday. We ask that all messages for teachers be left at the office, on their school voicemail, or emailed. Messages are checked by the teachers at least once a day and will be returned within one business day. Teachers will return phone messages during their planning time (which varies for each teacher) or before/after school. We will **not** interrupt classroom instruction to call a teacher to the phone, except in cases of emergencies.

Parent/Teacher/Student Conferences

1. Parent-Teacher conferences will be offered two times during the school year.
2. These conferences will be offered during the midpoint of each semester.
3. Parents and/or teachers may request more conferences when necessary.

Parental Involvement and Volunteering Opportunities

We strive to offer a variety of ways and opportunities for parents to participate in their child's education. Parents are asked to devote at least 20 hours per year volunteering or participating in school events. Opportunities to be involved include serving on the PCA Inc. Board, PTO, or Booster Club, chaperoning field trips, reading to students, volunteering in the classroom, attending Community Circle, Gallery Nights, and parent workshops, etc.

Visitors and Volunteers

We encourage parents to be involved. However, for the safety of our students and to protect instructional time, we must have guidelines on visits and volunteering.

- All visitors are required to check in at the front office and obtain a visitor tag.
- All volunteers are required to complete Child Abuse and FERPA training. Information on this will be sent home at Open House and can be obtained in the front office.
- Volunteers who are not properly fingerprinted and cleared by administration are not allowed to have direct supervision (unattended by a staff member) with children or attend overnight field trips.
- Visitors are discouraged from using student restrooms. They are encouraged to use the restroom in the front office.
- All visits to the classroom should have a meaningful purpose such as volunteering, pre-scheduled conferencing, acting as a guest speaker, etc. Drop-in visits will not be allowed so we can protect instructional time. Please understand that Parent Classroom Observations are welcomed, but should be arranged in advance per the Parent Observation Protocol. The Parent Observation Forms must be requested and completed by parents and approved by Principals.
- Conferences will be scheduled by appointment only.
- Students are not allowed to bring visitors or guests to school to visit classes without prior approval from the classroom teacher and administration.
- Classroom volunteers/visitors are expected to refrain from cell phone use while in the classroom.
- Volunteers or visitors should not bring young children (or children not in the designated classroom) into classrooms, so that the learning environment remains conducive to learning.
- Parents may not "check out" siblings or other students to attend Community Circle or other events that are not specifically for that child.
- Teachers and staff are in charge during school hours. Please do not contradict their rules or allow your child to break those rules.
- If you see any behavior problems or potentially unsafe situations while visiting or volunteering, please alert a staff member immediately.
- Please dress appropriately. The school dress code for students concerning length of shorts, body parts that should be covered, etc., are good guidelines for adult dress as well.

- There is NO smoking, vaping, or use of any tobacco products allowed on school campuses or at school-related activities.
- Remember kids see and hear everything, so be sure to show a positive attitude and use kind words.
- Also see PCA Inc.'s School Visitor Policy and Chaperone Policy for specific guidelines and consequences. Schools reserve the right to remove and/or deny access to school grounds in certain situations.

Respectful and Responsible Social Media

At PCA/SCCA, we consider ourselves a family. This includes staff, students, parents, and other family members. Two key elements of our mission are partnerships with our families and instilling integrity in our students. One way that we do that is by directly communicating with parents when we have issues that need resolving. For example, when a student is having trouble behaving or performing grade level work, we understand that the problem is most likely going to be resolved by directly contacting the parent for help with that issue. The school and staff members would not address these types of issues in the general public or on social media because that would not resolve the issue. Since our ultimate goal is to help our students become successful, we want to address issues in the way that best ensures a resolution. We certainly understand that there will be times that decisions are made at the school that you do not agree with or mistakes may be made. When you are dealing with as many stakeholders as we have involved in our school, there are bound to be disagreements and mistakes made. However, we ask that you remember we are all here for the same purpose: to see your child succeed. Please help us resolve issues by coming directly to the school and people involved for help with the issue. Problems are usually exasperated rather than resolved when the issue is aired on social media. We respect our PCA/SCCA family members too much to air dirty laundry in that way. Please show us the same respect we show you, and be good examples for your children on how to resolve conflict.

Student Health and Safety

Immunization Rules

All students entering or attending our schools are required to have a complete Georgia Certificate of Immunization (Form 3231) in accordance with Georgia Law, OCGA 20-2-771. All students must be immunized against vaccine preventable diseases as specified by the Georgia Department of Human Resources, or have a medical or religious exemption on file at school.

Clinic and Accident Reports

Our schools have a School Nurse on staff. We have nursing policies and procedures that we will follow accordingly. In her absence, the front office will serve as our "clinic" and is managed by our Secretary. The "clinic" is designed to meet the medical needs of minor cuts, aches, and accidents. We are not allowed to apply any topical ointments or administer medication without written permission. It is important to complete the Medical Information form in Infinite Campus and make changes throughout the year IF your child's medical status has changed. Students with a diagnosis of Asthma, Diabetes, Severe Allergy, or a Seizure Disorder must have a more complete Medical Plan completed and on file in the Nursing Office. You may contact the Nurse to obtain the form or one will be sent home with your student to be completed and returned.

If a student is seen in the Nurse's Office, you will be notified if:

- Your child has a temperature of 99.5 degrees or higher
- Your child has a severe cut/abrasion or head injury
- The problem is persistent or recurrent
- Your child requires immediate medical attention

If a child has the following symptoms, they will be sent home immediately and may not return until the symptoms are gone:

- A temperature over 100.0 degrees
- A rash or unknown skin problem
- Vomiting or diarrhea
- Green discharge from his/her nose
- Suspected Pink Eye
- Severe pain

If your child needs to be dismissed due to illness, we will make every effort to contact the parent/guardian listed as the main contact. If they cannot be reached, we will begin calling the emergency contacts listed. All students need to be picked up within one hour of notification so that we can safeguard the health of other students and our staff. If your child is sent home due to illness (vomiting, diarrhea, fever), he/she must be symptom free (unaided by medication) for 24 hours before returning to school.

Medication

1. To ensure all students' health and safety, we require all medication (prescription and nonprescription) to be housed and administered through the Nurse's office. The only exceptions are Epi Pens, which teachers may keep in their classrooms in a secure location and asthma inhalers, which students may keep in possession and self-administer if an Asthma Plan is in place for the child and signed by a licensed provider.
2. In order to administer non-prescription medication, the office must have a current copy of the Medical Information Form. In order to administer prescription medication, the Nurse's office must have a Medicine Authorization Form signed by parent/guardian.
3. All medications (prescription and non-prescription) must be taken directly to the clinic for safe keeping. The medication must be brought in by a parent or responsible party only. **DO NOT SEND MEDICINE ON THE SCHOOL BUS!**
4. ALL medications must be in the ORIGINAL CHILD-PROOF CONTAINER. Prescription medication must be in a labeled PRESCRIPTION BOTTLE with correct dosing information. **MEDICATIONS STORED IN ENVELOPES, BAGGIES, ETC. WILL NOT BE GIVEN.**
5. Medication must be picked up at the end of the year by a parent (guardian) or it will be disposed of by the school.

Physical Impairments or Conditions

Many students today may have some physical impairment or condition that the school personnel may need to know about. It is the parent's obligation to inform the classroom teacher in writing concerning a student's impairment or condition at Open House or on the first day of school.

Physical Education

Physical Education (P.E.) is required of all students in Georgia schools unless excused by a written statement from a physician. The nature of the disability and the duration of the excuse must be stated on the note from the physician. To prevent possible accidents, **tennis shoes only are required at all times in physical education (K-12).**

Elementary: Shorts must be worn under dresses or skirts on physical education days.

Middle School &/or High School: Dress out requirements will be set by the Physical Education teachers.

General School-Wide Procedures

Student Attendance, Tardies, Checkouts

Attendance is an essential part of the learning process. It is the responsibility of the parents to encourage participation in school; it is the school's responsibility to provide an environment for each student to obtain a quality educational opportunity. It is difficult to replace the classroom experience and learning opportunities when they are missed, particularly with our focus on hands-on learning. Please see our Pataula Charter Academy, Inc. Attendance Policy, which is a part of this handbook for more specific information on student attendance.

Students have three days upon return to school from an absence to bring in a parent note, medical documentation, or legal documentation to receive an excused absence. The student is responsible for bringing the parent note or documentation to their teacher or to the front office upon their return to school. Parents also have the option to take a picture of the documentation and email it to the school Data Clerk. **Excuses will not be accepted after 3 days.**

*****If a student is absent from school, serving ISS, or serving OSS that day, the student may not participate in ANY extracurricular activities, practices and competitions, or be on campus or at school sponsored events from the time ISS/OSS is assigned until they return to their regular class schedule.**

If a student reports to school after 7:55, he/she must report to the main office to sign in and receive an admittance slip before being admitted to class. **Parents are required to come in with the student to sign the student in if they are late.** An electronic sign-in system will be used for you to sign your student in. Students who drive to school or ride with siblings should also come to the front office to sign-in when late. **An excuse must be submitted within 3 days of the tardy to be marked excused.**

Parents who come to school to check out their child should do so in the main office. Parents will sign their student out using the electronic system. **Georgia Law permits school authorities to release students only to their parents, legal guardians, or to persons properly identified by parents/guardians to school authorities in writing. This will be done by identifying parents/guardians and emergency contacts in the Infinite Campus Online Registration system.** A photo ID may be required at the front desk when checking a student out for school early. Please understand that this is for your child's safety. **An excuse must be submitted within 3 days of the early dismissal to be marked excused.**

High school students needing to check out early, who drive to school, are required to bring a note to the office first thing in the morning. The note should include the following:

- reason for early check-out/copy of medical/dental appointment card
- parent and student's name
- parent signature with a contact number.
- The student is required to sign-out in the office prior to leaving.

****The checkout must be verified by phone that day by the school secretary/school administrator before the student is allowed to check-out. Parents who call during the day to check a child out, who drives to school, are required to fax or email the above information to the school secretary.*

All students who leave early must sign-out in the office at all times. The time and reason for leaving must be documented by the student/parent/guardian. Students failing to sign-out properly will be given an unexcused absence and will be subject to disciplinary action. Student drivers/siblings must also sign out in the front office once the school has contacted the parent/guardian and approved for the student driver/siblings to check out.

****STUDENTS ARE NOT PERMITTED TO SIGN OUT TO GO EAT LUNCH OR PURCHASE FOOD AND THEN COME BACK TO SCHOOL. HIGH SCHOOL DUAL ENROLLMENT STUDENTS ARE NOT ALLOWED TO BRING OUTSIDE FOOD INTO THE BUILDING UPON ARRIVAL OR LEAVE CAMPUS TO**

GO PICK-UP FOOD AT ANYTIME. STUDENTS FAILING TO COMPLY WILL BE SUBJECT TO DISCIPLINARY ACTION.

THERE WILL BE NO CHECKOUTS AFTER 2:45 PM (Appointment card or administrative approval required).

Checking a student out after 2:45 requires either an appointment card or administrative approval. Checking out early to avoid the car pickup line will not be approved unless a verifiable medical/dental scheduled appointment card, etc..is provided at check-out or ahead of time. We understand that some medical appointments are unavoidable; thus, in these cases, we ask that the appointment be verified by an appointment card/notice with date and time of appointment. If an appointment card is not available at check-out, then you may bring the doctor/dentist excuse (with-in 3 days) when your student returns to school. Failure to supply documentation will be a reason to deny further early release requests after 2:45. Any other exceptions to this must be approved by an administrator before being allowed to sign the student out after 2:45.

Discipline Procedures for Tardies to School and to Class (High School)

Tardies: By the time the tardy bell has finished sounding, all students should be in their classes. All cases of unexcused tardiness should be considered discipline problems. The classroom teacher will take appropriate disciplinary action for each tardy per the following procedures.

Students not in class by the tardy bell for the first period must report to the Front Office to sign-in and get a Tardy Pass (excused or unexcused) Teachers are not to allow students into class without a Late Pass. Tardies should be marked for ALL classes.

Consequences for unexcused tardies (High School):

1st Offense: Warning (teacher)

2nd Offense: Warning (teacher)

3rd Offense : Office Referral (parent-contact/counsel student)

4th Offense: Office Referral (Lunch Detention)

5th Offense: Office Referral (After-School Detention)

6th Offense and subsequent: Office Referral (Loss of Driving Privileges for remainder of semester or other consequence at admin discretion)

High School Seniors Early Release - No 7th period

All eligible seniors in good standing have been scheduled for “Early Release” (ER), meaning they will not take a 7th period class during their senior year. Seniors who fail to maintain passing grades, have discipline referrals, excessive unexcused absences, or excessive tardy issues during each 9 week grading period may be required to attend Mandatory Study Hall during 7th period for the 9 week grading period following the occurrence. Seniors with ER who have chronic issues with failure, discipline, attendance, tardies, or seniors who do not vacate the building immediately after 6th period, may lose their ER privilege and be placed in a 7th period class. Students who are required to stay due to lost privileges will be assigned to a study hall for a 9 week period and must remain in the assigned classroom the full class period. Other students who remain on campus during the 7th period will be assigned a 7th period class for the year. Students not following procedures will be subject to disciplinary action.

**Athletes who choose to remain on campus will be assigned to a study hall class during the term of their sport.*

****Students on early release must be out of the school building and in the process of leaving campus before the tardy bell rings for the next period or may be subject to disciplinary action or Early Release privileges may be lost.**

College Visits (Juniors and Seniors)

Each year Juniors are allowed one day and Seniors are allowed two days for college visits. These days will not count against the student's attendance as long as the proper documentation of the college visit is submitted within 3 days of the absence.

Withdrawal from School

Parents wishing to withdraw their child from school must complete a withdrawal form from the Data Clerk's office. All outstanding fees must be paid and school-issued books and technology returned at the time of withdrawal. Truancy laws require the school to notify officials if a student is not enrolled in school. Therefore, we must receive a record's request from a new school or a letter of intent to homeschool when a student withdraws.

Weather Days

In the event of inclement weather, the superintendent will make all decisions on school closings and/or delays. Please tune into your local television stations or check the website/FB page for information concerning inclement weather. We will also send a message via Parent Square..

Transportation

Please be sure that your child's teacher knows the transportation method for your child. **All transportation changes must be in writing.** In order to change the way a child gets home, the office must have a written note, email, or fax from the parent.

Please plan ahead and send a note with your child. For safety reasons, we cannot make changes over the phone without further verification. We will only accept changes by phone in extreme emergencies. These rare occasions should go through the office. After an emergency change has been approved by phone, parents must verify in writing through email or fax.

****In case of an emergency, please call the front office; do not email or text transportation changes to teachers, as e-mail could be down and messages are not always checked before the end of the day.***

Car Drop Off:

- Car drop off begins at 7:30, **no students should be dropped off prior to 7:30**
- The student drop-off/pick-up area for a child transported by automobile is clearly posted. For safety reasons, please do not drop students off or pick up at any area except in the designated area, including the parking lot.
- Please have your student(s) ready to exit the right side of the vehicle when you reach the drop off point (book bag and everything needed in hand, ready to exit when you stop).
- Pull forward to the farthest spot (indicated by staff or orange cone)
- At the 7:55 bell, you need to walk in with your child at the front office and sign them in. At this point students are considered "tardy" for school.
- If you are needing to enter the school before school begins at 7:55 to assist your child with carrying a project/large item/etc, you must park and enter through the front entrance of the school so you can sign-in and receive your visitor's pass.

Car Pick Up:

- Car pick up begins at 3:10 and all students should be picked up by 3:30. Any student who is not picked up by 3:30 will be sent to the front office.
- Be careful and watch for students, parents, and staff in the crosswalk.

- No one is allowed to pick up their child/children in the parking lot. Students may not walk out without a parent or student driver.
- Watch for staff and pull as far forward when prompted to pick up your student – Stopping to pick up students before pulling forward causes delay for the other parents in line.
- If you need to pick a student up early, please sign them out in the office before 2:45.
- If you need to enter the building, please park in the parking lot and enter the main office.
- Please post your pick-up student information in the front window with your child's name and grade in large print. If this information is not posted, you will be asked to circle back around so the pick-up line will not be held up.

****First Day of School Pickup and Drop-off:** Parents of Pre-K, Kindergarten, or new students may park in the designated parking lot outside the gym and walk their child in on the first morning of school. However, all parents need to be in the car pick-up line after school the first day to pick up their child. This will be the only morning that we allow parents to walk their child in. Thank you for your help with this matter.

Bus registration forms must be completed on a child before he/she is allowed to ride the bus. If there is more than one stop in your area, you may be assigned a certain location. **Students may not change buses or ride a bus without prior approval. Our buses are usually at full capacity, so you must seek permission from the school administrator in charge of transportation for all bus changes or if a guest will need to ride the bus with your child.**

Afternoon Dismissal Procedures:

Elementary students will be released to the bus pick-up area or to the car pick-up area each day prior to 3:10. High School Student drivers are not released until 3:10 so the siblings must wait in the cafeteria for their siblings to be escorted prior to exiting to the building. Please drive safely and follow all posted signs. Drivers failing to be cautious and/or not following signs will lose their driving privileges. **See Student Drivers and Parking section below.*

****Students are required to be off-campus by 3:30 (or as soon as car pick-up ends) unless they are directly under a coach's or teacher's supervision. Any student who is not picked up or remains on campus after 3:30 will be sent to the front office to call a parent. If this is not followed, disciplinary action will be taken.**

****Siblings/friends/carpoolers are not allowed to watch practices, sit in the gym, cafeteria, or roam around the school property after school hours. Any siblings or friends who ride home with any athlete or extracurricular activity participant from school are not allowed to roam the campus or be unsupervised. If this is not followed, disciplinary action will be taken.**

Student Drivers and Parking (High School)

All students must receive a notarized verification of attendance from the school to receive a driver's license. This form must be requested within 3 school days of needing it. The school reserves the right to deny this verification if the student has demonstrated a pattern of truancy.

Parking on the school campus is a privilege extended to high school students. However, we reserve the right to prohibit students from bringing a vehicle on campus if the student's doing so poses a safety risk. Parking rights may also be taken away as punishment for other violations of the Code of Conduct. Students must complete a parking application and pay a \$20 parking fee (fee will be used to maintain the parking area) before parking on campus. Students must display their appropriate parking decals at all times while on campus. **Middle schoolers are not allowed to drive/park on campus, even if they hold a valid drivers license.**

Parking Regulations:

- For safety purposes, all student vehicles permitted to park on-campus must be registered with the school. Students must complete a parking application, pay a **\$20 parking fee**, and receive a pass. The application includes providing a copy of the student's valid driver's license.
- Parking decals must be displayed on the designated area of the vehicle. Violations will result in the revocation of the parking privileges of both parties, fines, and/or disciplinary action.
- Students are not allowed in the student parking lot during school hours. **ONLY** an administrator may give approval for a student to go to the parking lot during the school day.
- Students are not allowed to leave campus without authorization.
- Students are not allowed to transport other students off campus without authorization.
- Students are not allowed to park in the front parking area or to use the front parking area as a drive-thru to access other areas of the campus or by-pass pick-up/drop-off lines.
- Parking on the school campus is a privilege extended to PCA/SCCA high school students; however, PCA/SCCA reserves the right to prohibit a student from bringing a vehicle on campus.
- Failure to follow parking regulations may result in revocation of parking pass and/or disciplinary action.
- If a student receives a serious driving offense, including at-fault accidents and hit/run accidents, the student's parking privileges will be revoked.
- Parking privileges may be revoked for any other offense deemed inappropriate by Administration.
- Any vehicle may be towed away at the owner's expense at any time for driving/parking violations. *Law enforcement may be notified as deemed necessary and traffic violations or other legal actions may be taken.

The administration and SRO reserve the right to issue traffic violations and collect fines for each of the following first offenses:

1. Reckless driving/speeding - \$25
2. Parking in Handicap parking spots - \$25
3. Parking in other unauthorized areas - \$10
4. Breaking in line/cutting across spaces/cutting through front parking lot - \$10
5. Failure to follow directions of parking attendants - \$10
6. No permit visible - \$5 (\$20 if no permit was purchased)
7. Excessive noise/music - \$5
8. Improper parking - \$5

*For any second offense, the **fine is doubled**. For any third offense, **parking privileges will be revoked for the remainder of the semester or 9 weeks, whichever is greater**. A student receiving a ticket should remit payment to the Front Office within 30 days. Failure to settle parking fines will result in revocation of parking privileges for the remainder of the semester or 9 weeks, whichever is greater.

Lunch and Breakfast

Breakfast and Lunch are FREE OF CHARGE TO ALL STUDENTS. Menus are sent home with students and/or are posted on our school website, **Breakfast is available daily between 7:30 to 7:50a.m. Breakfast will not be served to anyone arriving to the breakfast line at 7:50 or later. **Late buses will be the only exception to breakfast being served after 7:50**

- Students are responsible for disposing of their trash properly and cleaning up their area after meals.
- Students are not allowed to leave campus for lunch.
- **Students may bring a lunch from home, but students may not send out for lunch, accept delivery of food from off campus, or enter classrooms after checking in with a bag of food.** No food can be brought to school in an original wrapper and/or container of any fast food or other restaurant type business. If you have left-overs from a fast-food or other restaurant, please make sure you package

appropriately. Soft drinks and energy drinks are not allowed. Students not following procedures will be disciplined accordingly. ***These are federal regulations related to the SNP/USDA program.**

FOOD & DRINKS IN THE CLASSROOM/BUILDING:

Elementary: Your child's teacher will notify you as to what type of snacks and/or drinks they allow for recess/break.

High School/Middle School:

No Snacks and Drinks are allowed in the classroom with the exception of water. No glass containers are allowed.

Toys, Bluetooth Devices, and other devices

Toys, radios, headphones, bluetooth devices, CD players, beepers, game/collector cards and items, personal articles of value, or other personal entertainment items are not allowed at school, unless permission is granted for a special purpose by the teacher. The school will keep these items until picked up by the parent. Repeated offenses will be subject to disciplinary action. Any items not claimed by the parent will be discarded. The school is not responsible for any personal item brought to school.

Forms of Payment

Throughout the year, the schools will sponsor various activities, field trips, clubs, etc. that may require a fee or donation. In order to help us correctly credit our students for payment and keep accurate accounting records, we ask that you observe the following procedures:

- **The preferred method of payment is online through the automated online payment system by logging into your child's portal on Infinite Campus. *Note IC does charge a service fee.**
- **When sending money to school, please make sure it is in a sealed envelope and properly labeled with your child's name, homeroom teacher, amount enclosed, and what the money is for.**
- **When paying by cash, please send the exact amount.** The office and teachers do not have cash on hand to make change.
- **When paying by check, please be sure to note the student name and purpose in the memo line of the check.** (This is particularly important if the parent and student have different last names or someone other than the parent is making the payment.)
- **Some forms of payment need to go to the school, to PTO, or Athletic Boosters. We ask that these payments not be combined on one check.** You will need to write a check for each entity.
- **Combining payments for siblings (for example paying for school pictures for 3 kids on one check) is acceptable. Just be sure to mark everything in the memo line and on order forms.**
- **Please do not combine payments for different purposes** (for example, do not write one check for pictures and a lost media center book), as these payments go into separate accounts.

Returned Check Fees

We will do our best to efficiently process checks so that you can properly budget. In the event a check is returned for insufficient funds, you will be responsible for any fees charged to the school by the bank. We will also add an additional charge of \$20.00. After the second returned check, we will only accept cash or money orders as a form of payment.

Certificate of Enrollment and Driver's License:

Driver's License/ Certificate of Enrollment Signed into law on April 16, 2015, SB100 changed the Teenage and Adult Driver Responsibility Act (TAADRA) requirement for schools to certify that a minor's attendance pattern and discipline record permits the student to obtain a Georgia learner's permit or driver's license. Schools are simply required to certify that a student is enrolled in and not expelled from a public or private school. Requests for Certificates of Enrollment should be made in the front office. You must make the request at least 3 days prior

to the day you need it. We cannot guarantee these will be available the same day of your child's driving test. The Certificate of Enrollment is only valid for 30 days.

Graduation Fee:

All graduating Seniors are required to pay a \$30 graduation fee. A student must pay the graduation fee in order to participate in the graduation ceremony. This fee goes toward graduation expenses, such as rentals, programs, flowers, etc.

Hall Passes

Students should remain in class for the total class period. Students will not be allowed to leave class except in an emergency. The teacher has the authority to determine if an emergency exists. When an emergency arises, the student will be issued a hall pass provided by the teacher. In all cases when a student is in the hall during class, he/she must have a hall pass. Students who are found without hall passes are to be taken to the main office and are subject to disciplinary action.

Hall Traffic

Keep halls open to traffic by walking to the right. Do not block traffic by standing in groups. Be considerate of others in the halls and classrooms by moving through the halls quickly and quietly. Elementary students should always walk in a silent line when traveling in hallways. Middle and High school students should use a conversational tone of voice and not make excessive noise or engage in horseplay during class changes. Students should keep their hands to themselves, walk directly to their class in an orderly manner, and enter their classroom upon arrival.

Class Parties and Celebrations

Parties of a non-instructional nature will be limited to twice yearly – one before the Christmas holidays, and one at the end of the school year. Please be sure to discuss special plans and activities with your child's teacher before the event. Other celebrations/seasonal activities are allowed, but should include instructional activities and/or take place during non-instructional times of the day (recess/Specials/Crew). Since High School and Middle School change classes, these two parties/celebrations will only be allowed to happen during CREW.

We enjoy celebrating birthdays with our children, but we will not allow birthday "parties." However, snacks may be distributed at recess/break to celebrate. Please contact the teacher before sending in snacks for these special occasions, as some students have food allergies. Please make sure the snack is prepared so that individual servings can be quickly distributed. Whole cakes and cookies require a lot of time to distribute, and we often do not have the proper materials to cut or distribute the cake.

Flowers and balloons cannot be sent to students at school for any occasion. No party invitations may be given out at school unless you are inviting the entire class or all boys/girls in the class.

Lost and Found

Any article found at school is taken to the school office. Students' names should be placed on each jacket for identification. Any clothing left unclaimed for an extended period will be donated to charity. The school is not responsible for lost or stolen items.

Moment of Reflection/Pledge of Allegiance

During our morning announcements, students will participate in a brief period of quiet reflection for not more than 60 seconds as required by Georgia law (O.C.G.A.20-2-1050), followed by the Pledge of Allegiance. Students are not required to recite the Pledge if it conflicts with their beliefs. However, they must remain silent during that time.

Nondiscrimination Statement

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy does not discriminate in employment or educational programs, services, or activities based on race, color, religion, national origin, sex (including pregnancy, sexual orientation or gender identity), age, disability, or genetic information. Schools will provide reasonable accommodations to applicants and employees who need them for medical or religious reasons, as required by law. *See the Notice of Non-Discrimination Policy for more details.

DRESS CODE

Grades K - 12

Cleanliness and appropriate apparel is expected as a matter of health and aesthetics. The dress of students must be in good taste, appropriate for school activities, in accordance with the school rules, and not be disruptive to the learning environment. PCA/SCCA's dress code is designed to reduce the likelihood of distraction or disruption and to maintain an academic focus in the classroom and on campus.

Administrators have the final authority in all judgments related to dress and hygiene.

******Dress Code applies to ALL school sponsored events such as any Academic Award Programs, Athletic Award Programs, Induction Ceremonies, other special events, etc. Dress Code also applies to Personal Fitness, Weight Training, and Field Work/Trips.**

There will no longer be any uniform-type requirements for dress code. Students may wear any appropriate clothing that does not violate the dress code regulations below.

Dress Code Regulations:

1. T-shirts with sleeves ripped, cut off, or muscle shirts may not be worn.
2. Shirts should cover the midriff, chest, back, and majority of the shoulder. The midriff must be covered at all times including standing and sitting. No spaghetti straps, halter tops, crop tops, tube tops, or backless blouses may be worn. Cleavage must not show.
3. Sleeveless tops may be worn as long as the majority of the shoulder is covered and no undergarments are visible.
4. Proper undergarments must be worn at all times and should not be visible. See-through material that exposes undergarments or flesh is inappropriate.
5. Pants, athletic pants (sweat pants, joggers, windbreaker pants, etc.), shorts, and skirts are to be worn properly at the waist and cannot be oversized.
6. Shorts, dresses, and skirts should be an acceptable length in order to avoid any disruption of a normal school day. To accommodate students of different ages and with different body proportions, garments should at least be longer than mid-thigh. Skirts and dresses should still be at least mid-thigh length even if leggings or tights are worn underneath.
7. **Form fitting leggings, yoga pants, and shorts etc. are NOT allowed as stand-alone bottoms. This includes any spandex type bottoms worn without a skirt, dress, or shorts over them that are at least mid-thigh length.**
8. No pants or shorts with writing/words across the seat or crotch area.
9. Factory frays in jeans are acceptable as long as the fray is not excessive and skin does not show above mid-thigh. Clothing with rips, holes, or see-through material that exposes undergarments or flesh is inappropriate.
10. Sleep attire including flannel sleep pants, nylon pajamas, and bedroom shoes/slippers are not allowed except on designated theme days. Pillows and blankets are not appropriate for a classroom setting. Do not bring these items.
11. Body piercings that pose a safety concern or distraction are prohibited.
12. Hats and other head coverings (including hoodies, bandanas, sleep/shower caps, etc.) are not allowed inside buildings or during the school day; this includes the cafeteria, PE/Weight Training, Ag shop, or any class/activity within the normal school day. Hat Day Fundraisers will be approved by administration.
13. Proper shoes must be worn at all times. Rubber sole shoes are required for all PE/Weight Training classes.
14. Sunglasses, wallet chains, dog collars, and other distracting accessories are prohibited.
15. Clothing or personal belongings displaying alcohol, drugs, tobacco, illegal substances, or gangs, including symbols, logos, or trademarks is prohibited.
16. Clothing or personal belongings displaying obscene, vulgar, inflammatory, derogatory, or suggestive language, gestures, or pictures are prohibited.
17. Any item that is a safety concern or disruptive to the learning environment will be handled appropriately.
18. Any other clothing or accessory item may be deemed as unacceptable by the administration if the item is being used to show disrespect or creates a distraction.

IF IN DOUBT, DON'T WEAR IT!

THE ADMINISTRATION WILL MAKE THE FINAL DETERMINATION OF WHAT IS APPROPRIATE FOR SCHOOL WEAR.

RELIGIOUS EXEMPTIONS: We understand that some religious attire may not meet all of the guidelines set forth in the dress code regulations. Therefore, some guidelines may be waived on a case-by-case basis. Please notify the Principal if you need to apply for a religious exemption to the dress code.

PATAULA CHARTER ACADEMY/SPRING CREEK CHARTER ACADEMY STUDENT CODE OF CONDUCT AND BEHAVIOR CONTRACT

Purpose

The purpose of the Student Code of Conduct and Behavior Contract is as follows:

1. To create a risk free and safe environment
2. To maximize learning time
3. To provide information to students and parents concerning the rules and regulations of the school and the plan for consequences for infraction of these rules and regulations
4. To provide uniform administrative and disciplinary procedures

Statement of Student Conduct

Our goal is to teach students the value and importance of following established rules and procedures in order to maintain a safe, orderly, and respectful environment both in the educational setting, as well as within our communities. To that end, we will positively reinforce honorable conduct and good behavior as often as possible, and will balance this with appropriate consequences for misconduct. We will continually provide encouragement and support to students in self-management of behavior and control of actions.

Parents and students will be required to sign the Code of Conduct upon enrollment and at the beginning of each school year. Students may not enroll in our schools unless consequences at a prior school or system have been served. This includes expulsion and alternative school determinations. Students who have been expelled from another school or assigned to an alternative school will not be allowed to enroll until those consequences expire or are reversed.

These rules are designed to notify students and parents about the types and range of behaviors prohibited by our schools. Every specific variation of conduct may not have been included. Consequently, students should expect to be disciplined for misconduct that is obviously inappropriate and contrary to the schools' mission and core beliefs.

General Conduct Guidelines/Restrictions

EXTRA-CURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

Extra-Curricular Activities: Candidates for, or students elected to leadership positions in all extracurricular and/or student government organizations are recognized as leaders and role models. Therefore, exemplary conduct on and off school campus is expected by the school administration, staff, and fellow students, as well as the community. Illegal or inappropriate behavior will be subject to administrative action, which may include suspension or removal from elected office or denial of privilege to run for elected positions.

Competitive Interscholastic Activities and Contests: High School students participating in competitive interscholastic activities by the Georgia High School Association must comply with all eligibility requirements. Students must be counted present at school to be eligible for any extracurricular activities (at least ½ day attendance required). *See the Athletic Handbook for more information regarding rules for participation in athletic practices and contests when under discipline sanctions.

Leaving School Grounds

Students are required to stay on the school grounds at all times during school hours. Any student who leaves our campus without permission will be subject to disciplinary action. Law enforcement may be contacted as a necessary step should this occur.

Cheating

Students are expected to do their own work in an honest and forthright manner. Cheating and plagiarism will not be tolerated or condoned by PCA/SCCA. Students who compromise their integrity by cheating or plagiarizing someone else's work will receive an office referral and be given a zero for the assignment. The student will also be required to complete the assessment again or complete an alternate assessment: the teacher decides the appropriate course of action. Students will be required to complete make-up assessments outside of regular class time, and may be required to stay after school to complete the assignment. *See Violations of Code of Conduct for more information on consequences of cheating.

Cell Phone/Personal Electronic Devices

- From 7:50 AM - 3:10 PM (Bell-to-Bell), NO ELECTRONIC DEVICES are allowed to be used on campus. Cell phones should be stored in purses/backpacks/teacher "parking spots" during this time; not on your person (including in your pockets). Noncompliance will result in an office referral.
- Personal electronic devices means any portable electronic device capable of transmitting, receiving, or accessing communications, data, or media. Such term includes, but is not limited to smart phones, smartwatches, tablets, e-readers, headphones, and other devices with functionalities such as wireless communication, internet access, messaging, video recording, gaming, social media access, or data transmission.
- The school provides all students with a Chromebook for educational purposes. Personal laptops are NOT allowed EXCEPT for Dual Enrollment courses.
- There is a phone available for students to use in the front office if they need to call a parent for any reason. Parents may call the front office in the event of an emergency. Parents, please DO NOT text or call your child on their cell phone for any reason from 7:50 AM - 3:10 PM.
- Students may bring electronic devices to school for use before or after school, at their own risk. The school will not be responsible for lost or stolen phones.
- Students may be required to turn their phones in to teachers each morning once arriving at school. Teachers will return the phones before dismissal.
- If a staff member sees a visible phone and asks a student to put the phone in his/her backpack/purse and the student refuses to do so, the phone will be confiscated and the student will have an office referral.
- If a student is caught using an electronic device during school hours or fails to turn in his/her phone when a teacher asks, the phone will be taken to an administrator and will only be returned to a parent. The student will also have an office referral for breaking that rule. See Cell Phone Violation Consequences below.
- At the driver's discretion, use of electronic devices may be allowed on the school bus under the following circumstances:
 - Students should keep electronic equipment packed away when preparing to board and when getting off the bus. They should never use an electronic device or wear earbuds when loading or unloading. They must be able to hear.
 - Students shall be prohibited from using any electronic devices during the operation of a school bus, including but not limited to cell phones; pagers; audible radios, tape or compact disc players without headphones; or any other electronic device in a manner that might interfere with the school bus communications equipment or the school bus driver's operation of the school bus.
- Any use of an electronic device in a disruptive or inappropriate manner in the school setting is prohibited. Examples of unacceptable usage can include but are not limited to: cheating, cyber bullying, sexting, taking pictures or videos, using phones in places of school business, media center, or restrooms, etc.
- No student shall use an Electronic Device to violate any Student Code of Conduct, including Computer usage agreements, and/or Bullying Policies.

- Cell phones and other electronic devices are subject to searching with reasonable suspicion of a technology or other Code of Conduct violation. Refusal to surrender or to allow searching or refusal to submit the electronic device to any school employee is grounds for disciplinary action.
- Parents may be contacted to claim the student's cell phone or other electronic devices from a school administrator.
- *See Cell Phone/Electronic Devices Policy for more information.*

Cell Phone Violation Consequences

*These consequences are for violations of using a cell phone at prohibited times. This is not for violations of using technology in an inappropriate or threatening manner. Those violations will be dealt with in the Violations of Code of Conduct section.

1. First Offense - Cell Phone taken up and parent must pick it up in the front office.
2. Second Offense - Cell Phone taken up and parent must pick it up in the front office AND 1 day ISS
3. Third and Subsequent Offenses - Cell Phone taken up and parent must pick it up in the front office AND 3 days ISS

*Refusal to comply with these consequences will result in other disciplinary consequences as described in the Code of Conduct.

Search and Seizure Policy

To maintain order and discipline in the schools and to protect the safety and welfare of students and school personnel, school authorities may search a student, lockers, or student automobiles under the circumstances outlined below and may seize any illegal, unauthorized, or contraband materials discovered in the search.

- **Personal Searches:** A student's person and/or personal effects (e.g. purse, book bag, etc.,) may be searched whenever a school administrator has reasonable suspicion to believe that the student may be in possession of illegal or unauthorized materials. If a search of a student's person is conducted, it will be conducted in private by a school administrator of the same sex and with an adult witness of the same sex present.
- **Locker Searches:** It is the responsibility of the student assigned to the locker to secure and be responsible for personal possessions contained within the locker. School authorities have the right to conduct a locker search whenever a school administrator has reasonable suspicion to believe that the locker may contain illegal or unauthorized materials. This includes if a narcotics K-9 indicates the locker(s) may contain illegal drugs during a random K9 drug inspection.
- **Automobile Searches:** Vehicles parked on campus during the school day are required to be registered with the school. The school retains authority to conduct routine patrols of student parking lots and inspections of the exterior of student automobiles on school property. The interiors of students' vehicles may be searched whenever a school authority has reasonable suspicion to believe that illegal or unauthorized materials are contained inside. Such patrols, inspections, and searches may be conducted without notice, without student consent, and without a search warrant.
- **Cell Phone Searches:** A student's cell phone/electronic device may be confiscated by a staff member at any time according to the Code of Conduct. The electronic device/cell phone may be searched when a school administrator has reasonable suspicion that a student has violated the school's student technology use agreement and/or code of conduct concerning cell phone use. Electronic devices/cell phones may also be searched if there is reasonable suspicion that the phone may contain evidence of other violations of the Code of Conduct and/or laws.
- **Seizure of Illegal Materials:** If a properly conducted search yields illegal or contraband materials, such findings shall be turned over to the legal authorities for ultimate disposition.
- **Refusal to Allow Search:** Any student who refuses to allow a search, after it has been explained the reasonable suspicion for the search, will be subject to disciplinary action. If the suspicion is related to possession of an illegal item or substance, law enforcement will be contacted to conduct the search.

Drug/ Weapon/ Tobacco Free School Policy

It is the policy of our schools that students not possess, sell, use, transmit, or be under the influence of regulated drugs, marijuana, tobacco products, or alcoholic beverages while at any school sponsored activities or while under the supervision of school personnel. The possession of weapons at school is unlawful. (Georgia Laws O.C.G.A. 16-11-127.1 and 15-11-37)

The administration, staff, and students demand a drug free/weapon free school environment in which to learn. Any student who is found in violation of the policy shall be subject to the strongest of legal actions. The Code of Conduct establishes the suspension and/or expulsion of students found in violation. Possession of any weapon or illicit drugs also requires legal action by local law enforcement officials and students found in violation of the law will be subject to prosecution.

Our school is a tobacco/drug free environment. The possession, use, or distribution of any tobacco products, drugs, or drug paraphernalia by students will not be permitted on campus at any time. Parents are respectfully asked to refrain from the use of alcohol, drug, and tobacco products while at school or at school events. Our campuses are smoke-free/tobacco free campuses.

Vaping

Vaping is the act of inhaling and exhaling the aerosol, often referred to as vapor, which is produced by an e-cigarette or similar device. The term is used because e-cigarettes do not produce tobacco smoke, but rather an aerosol, often mistaken for water vapor, that actually consists of fine particles.

Vaping requires the use of a purpose-made or homemade device that vaporizes oil that may contain flavoring, nicotine, Cannabidiol (CBD) oil of varying concentrations, tetrahydrocannabinol (THC) oil of varying concentrations, or other substances that may or may not be legal to possess. A vaping device is generally composed of a vaporizer, battery, reservoir for smoking oil, and a battery charger. By way of example and not as a limitation, vaping devices may be called vapes, Juuls, e-cigarettes, e-cigs, dab pens or other brand names.

It is a violation of the Code of Conduct to possess, use or transfer a vape of any type. The following consequences will apply to any student who is in intentional or unintentional possession of any vaping device or paraphernalia during any school sanctioned activity or on campus during or outside of normal school hours. In addition to the following consequences, any vaping device or vaping paraphernalia found in connection with the offense will be confiscated and **not returned**. In the event a student is found to be in possession of a vaping device which contains THC or other illegal drugs, such will be treated as a separate drug-related offense.

- First Offense: 1 Day Out of School Suspension (OSS) and a REQUIRED Parent Conference
- Second Offense: 3 Days Out of School Suspension (OSS) and a REQUIRED Parent Conference
- Third Offense: Escalates to Cat III Offense; Out of School Suspension (OSS) Pending a tribunal hearing

Weapons and Dangerous Instruments

A student shall not supply, possess, handle, use or transmit a dangerous instrument, weapon, or any object which can be reasonably considered a weapon on school property, on his/her way to and from school, or at any school function or activity, or at any school-related activity or event away from school.

"Weapon" means and includes any pistol, revolver, or any weapon designed or intended to propel a missile of any kind, or any dirk, bowie knife, switchblade knife, ballistic knife, any other knife having a blade of two or more inches, straight-edge razor, razor blade, spring stick, knuckles, whether made from metal, thermoplastic, wood, or other similar material, blackjack, any bat, club, or other bludgeon-type weapon, or any flailing instrument consisting of two or more rigid parts connected in such a manner as to allow them to swing freely, which may be known as a nunchaku, nunchuck, shuriken, or fighting chain, or any disc, of whatever configuration, having at

least two points or pointed blades which is designed to be thrown or propelled and which may be known as a throwing star or oriental dart, or any weapon of like kind, and any stun gun or taser as defined in subsection (a) of Code Section 16-11-106. Items not expressly a “weapon”, but used in the manner of a weapon, such as sharpened sticks and writing utensils, metal pipes, pieces of glass, etc., may also be considered a weapon violation.
GA Law: O.C.G.A § 16-11-127.1

Students who bring a weapon to school or school function shall be immediately suspended from school and referred to a Tribunal for recommended expulsion. The student may also be referred to law enforcement officials.

Physical Violence against a Teacher or School Employee

Any student who commits an act of physical violence against a school employee will be subject to suspension from school and referred to the disciplinary tribunal who will impose punishment in accordance with the law as referenced in O.C.G.A. 20-2-751.6. The definition as defined by law for physical violence is:

- (1) Intentionally making physical contact of an insulting or provoking nature with the person of another; or
- (2) Intentionally making physical contact, which *causes physical harm to another* unless such physical contacts or physical harms were in self-defense as provided for in Code Section 16-3-21.

Technology:

As new technologies continue to change the world in which we live, they also provide many new and positive educational benefits for classroom instruction. Our schools provide a variety of technology for student use, such as desktop computers, Chromebooks, laptops, Ipads, assistive technology devices, etc. Students are responsible for using these devices appropriately and with care. The Technology Acceptable Use Policy gives specific guidelines for acceptable use of school technology, including the use of the school’s internet network. Students must adhere to the guidelines of the Technology Acceptable Use Policy and other guidelines related to technology/internet use in this Code of Conduct.

Bullying

We believe that all students have a right to a safe and healthy school environment. The school has an obligation to promote mutual respect, tolerance, and acceptance among students, staff, and volunteers. Behavior that infringes on the safety of any student will not be tolerated. A student shall not bully, harass, or intimidate another student through words or actions.

***See the school’s Bullying Policy for more information.**

Truancy:

State law requires compulsory school attendance for all students between the ages of 6 and 16 years with penalties including fines and/or prison for non-compliance. Truancy is defined as more than 5 unexcused absences in a school calendar year for a student subject to compulsory school attendance. (pursuant to SBOE 160-5-1-.10) More than 5 Unexcused Absences during the school calendar year will result in the student being classified as Truant.

*For more detailed information See the PCA Inc Attendance Policy.

Violations of the student Code of Conduct are grouped into three classes (Category I, II, or III)

Violations of the Code of Student Conduct are grouped into three classes (Class I, Class II and Class III). Before determining the classification of a violation, the principal and/or assistant principal will consult with the involved student(s) and school personnel. Once the classification of the violation is determined, the principal and/or assistant principal will implement the disciplinary procedure.

The classroom teacher may deal with classroom disruption by taking in-class disciplinary action, by making a personal call to the parent(s) or guardian when feasible, and/or by scheduling conferences with the parent(s) or guardian and other school staff. When the action taken by the teacher is ineffective, or the disruption is severe, the student should be referred to the principal or his/her designated person(s).

CATEGORY I OFFENSES:

First Offense: In-school conference and/or parental contact when warranted. First Offense circumstances may also warrant disciplinary action as outlined under subsequent offenses, including but not limited to those listed in the next paragraph.

Subsequent Offenses: The disciplinary action for such offenses can be a combination of the following: In-school disciplinary action such as loss of privileges, probation, temporary removal from class or activity, notification of parents, parent conference, corporal punishment, detention which can be a combination of the following: (morning/lunch/after-school) and/or extended work assignments before or after school, Time Out in Office/Opportunity Room, or in-school suspension. Other reasonable disciplinary actions as deemed appropriate by the principal/assistant principal.

- Distraction of other students: Any conduct and/or behavior which is disruptive to the orderly educational process in the classroom or any other instructional setting including talking excessively, making noises, provoking or bothering other students, distracting other students, interrupting class functions, throwing objects, etc. (Any student who is a chronic class disruption and distraction will move to a Category II offense on the 3rd offense).
- Failure to comply: Failure to comply with directions given by a school employee
- Participation in games of chance for money and/or other things of value
- Attendance Related: Repeated or excessive unexcused absences or tardiness; including failure to report to class, skipping class, leaving school without authorization, unauthorized absence from school, or failure to comply with disciplinary actions
- Intentional and/or non-direct use of profane, offensive or obscene language
- Comments that perpetuate gender stereotypes or suggestive jokes that are not directed towards specific individuals
- Non-conformity to dress code * See Dress Code
- Inappropriate public display of affection
- Continual refusal and/or failure to complete homework or classwork or refusal to participate in classroom activities
- Chronic teasing or arguing with other students (3 referrals for teasing may result in a Category III: bullying/harassment referral)
- Chronically unprepared for class by not bringing necessary materials; including not bringing signed papers or agenda
- Failure to carry correspondence home
- Failure to obey directions in hallways, assemblies, etc.
- Unauthorized or inappropriate use of school property
- Littering on school property
- Inappropriate sexually-based behavior including but not limited to suggestive jokes or lewd gestures that are directed towards specific individuals or group of individuals (sexual physical contact will result in Cat 2 or 3)
- Distribution or display of printed materials on school property or at a school activity without the approval of the principal or his/her designee

- Offensive touching of another that does not result in bodily injury (including but not limited to pushing, hitting, kicking, shoving, pinching, biting, slapping)
- Breaking lunch line
- Minor parking violations
- Leaving campus without signing out properly
- Electronic devices: Inappropriate/unauthorized use/possession of electronic devices/technology
- Unauthorized purchase and/or sale of merchandise.
- Soliciting, procuring, causing, encouraging, aiding, abetting, or assisting another to commit any of the foregoing offenses.
- Unintentional possession of prescribed or over the counter medication. Does not include the possession of narcotics, illegal drugs, or prescribed controlled substances. (Does not include auto-injectable epinephrine as properly administered pursuant to O.C.G.A. 20-2-776)
- Retaliation against another student who informed/testified against him/her - minor retaliation
- Any other violation which the administrator(s) may deem reasonable to fall within the category after consideration of extenuating circumstances.

CATEGORY II OFFENSES:

First Offense:: The disciplinary action for such offenses can be a combination of the following: Detention which can be a combination of the following (any combination of morning/lunch/after-school), and/or extended work assignments before or after school, corporal punishment, loss of privileges, and/or in-school suspension. Other reasonable disciplinary actions as deemed appropriate by the principal/assistant principal..

Subsequent Offenses: The disciplinary action for such offenses can be a combination of the following: probation, loss of privileges, detention (any combination of morning/lunch/after-school), extended work assignments before or after school, in-school or out-of-school suspension and/or tribunal with recommendation for expulsion by the principal/assistant principal.

Note: The Commission of Category II offenses may constitute a violation of criminal laws established by Local, State, and Federal government and may be reported to the appropriate authorities. Parents and guardians are encouraged to inform their children of the possible consequences.

- Chronic class disruption and distraction
- Disrespect: Disrespect toward employees, students, or school visitors
- Offensive touching of another that results in mild bodily harm (including but not limited to pushing, hitting, kicking, shoving, pinching, biting, slapping, and other intentional physical confrontations)
- Defiance of school employee's authority
- Any verbal or non-verbal refusal to comply with a lawful direction or order of a school employee. A refusal to comply suggests an oppositional intention on the part of the individual – willful noncompliance
- Possession and/or use of any tobacco products.
- Possession and/or use of any “vapor” device and/or paraphernalia. The smoking/possession of electronic, “vapor,” or other nicotine delivery devices, substitute forms of cigarettes, or any other “inhaling” innovation/paraphernalia. *See Vaping section for specific consequences.
- Any medication prescribed to a student or purchased over the counter and not brought to the office upon arrival to school. This does not include prescribed controlled substances that a student is abusing, which would result in a Category 3 offense. (Does not include auto-injectable epinephrine as properly administered pursuant to O.C.G.A. 20-2-776)
- Alcohol: Under the influence of alcohol without possession
- Possession of matches, lighters, or incendiary devices

- Unsafe and/or unlicensed driving on school property or other violations of the school parking and driving rules.
- Vandalism/Criminal Mischief: Intentional and deliberate action resulting in injury or damages of less than \$200 to public property or the real or personal property of another.
- Stealing/Larceny/Petty Theft: Taking and/or carrying away of property valued at less than \$50 belonging to or in lawful possession or custody of another.
- Robbery: The taking of something by threat of force (use of actual force is Cat III)
- Gambling/Possession of Gambling Device: The possession of any device or item which can be used to promote or facilitate gambling. The intentional, unlawful participation in gambling activities involving less than \$100.
- Possession of stolen property with the knowledge that it is stolen.
- Theft of lost property: Actively obtaining or exerting control over the property of another which is known to have been lost or mislaid, and failing to take reasonable measures to discover and notify the owner.
- Possession of obscene and/or offensive materials.
- Use of obscene and/or offensive manifestations (verbal, written, gesture) directed toward another person and/or offensive manifestations (verbal, written, gesture) which are deemed to create a hostile environment.
- Inappropriate sexually-based physical contact including but not limited to public groping, inappropriate bodily contact, sexting, lewd behavior, possession of pornographic/sexually explicit material/items, simulated sex act, or any other sexual contact not covered in Cat 3
- Bullying: Written, verbal, or physical acts that threaten, harass, humiliate, coerce, or otherwise intimidate that are so severe, persistent, or pervasive that they have an effect of substantially interfering with a student's education (3rd offense is Cat III and goes to tribunal)
- Truancy or unauthorized leaving class/campus. ("skipping")
- Unauthorized presence, entering or remaining on public school property or attending any school related activity while under any kind of OSS suspension.
- Possession of a pocket knife that is less than 2 inches (threatening to or using a pocket knife of any size is a Cat III offense)
- Weapons - Knife: Unintentional possession of a knife or knife-like item
- Use of matches, lighters, or incendiary devices
- Intentionally providing false information to any PCA/SCCA employees, including, but not limited to, student information data and the concealment of information directly related to school business. Examples: providing false information including, but not limited to forgery of parent/guardian name, changing grades, forging notes, passes or forms. etc.
- Honor Code Violations and/or Cheating: any act of academic deception or falsification. This includes cheating by receiving any unauthorized aid or assistance or the actual giving or receiving of unfair advantage and plagiarism, including the unauthorized use of AI.
- Inappropriate use of technology The misuse of technology that harms another person or involves inappropriate material being accessed. Use of technology resources to:
 - Send, display, or download any offensive messages or pictures.
 - Harass, insult or attack others.
 - Use obscene, profane, discriminatory, threatening, or inflammatory language.
 - Violate copyright laws.
 - Intentionally waste limited resources.
 - Participate in online chat rooms without permission/supervision of a school employee.
 - Possession of and/or use of laser light pointer or any device designed to emit a laser light.
 - Soliciting, procuring, causing, encouraging, aiding, abetting or assisting another to commit any of the foregoing offenses.

- Wearing or possessing gang related apparel; communicating either verbally or nonverbally to convey membership or affiliation with a gang. Gang related slogans, names, apparel, etc. are not permitted on any school campus or at any school related activity.
- Retaliation against another student who informed/testified against him/her - major retaliation
- Any other offense which the principal may deem reasonable to fall within this category after consideration.

CATEGORY III OFFENSES:

The disciplinary action for such offenses will be an assignment to out-of-school suspension, and/or referral to tribunal with recommendation for long-term suspension, alternative school, and/or expulsion.

***Students who are expelled will not be permitted to re-enroll at any time in the future.**

****Students who are expelled or in alternative school are NOT allowed on campus during or after school hours or participate in school extracurricular activities.**

Note: The Commission of Category III offenses may constitute a violation of criminal laws established by Local, State, and Federal government, and may be reported to the appropriate authorities. Parents and guardians are encouraged to inform their children of the consequences, including potential criminal acts and penalties for which a minor can be tried as an adult. Our schools employ School Resources Officers, who are sworn law enforcement officers. They are obligated to report any potential crime.

- Fighting: The initiation or provocation of a fight or physical altercation, or the participation in a fight or physical altercation absent mitigating circumstances.
- Provoking, agitating, and/or inciting a fight/confrontation.
- Drugs: Unlawful use, cultivation, manufacture, distribution, sale, purchase, possession, transportation, or importation of any controlled drug or narcotic substance, including prescription drugs that are considered a controlled substance, any vape, gummy, tablet, or other form of THC, or equipment or devices used for preparing or using drugs or narcotics; Includes being under the influence of drugs or substances represented as drugs
- Alcohol: Possession, use, distribution, sale, or purchase of alcohol on school grounds or school events
- Tobacco: Distribution and/or selling of tobacco products on school property or at school events
- Electronic smoking device: Distribution and/or selling of electronic smoking devices/products on school property OR 3rd offense for possession of vape
- Kidnapping: The unlawful and forceful abduction, transportation, and/or detention of a person against his/her will
- Homicide: Killing of a human being
- Arson: The willful and malicious burning of any part of school property, including the use of firecrackers and fireworks
- Possessing and/or igniting fireworks, firecrackers or smoke bombs, stink bombs or committing any act which could disrupt the educational environment or process.
- Assault upon School Board employee: The unlawful and intentional touching or striking or an attempt to touch or strike a School Board employee against his/her will or the intentional causing of bodily harm to a School Board employee.
- Violence Against a Teacher: Intentional physical attack against a teacher with the intent to cause bodily harm resulting in severe injuries or any physical attack against a teacher.
- Robbery: The taking of something by force, with or without a weapon
- Breaking & Entering: Unlawful or unauthorized forceful entry into a school building or vehicle (with or without intent to commit theft)

- Larceny/Theft: The participation in and/or the intentional, unlawful taking and/or carrying away of money or other property valued at \$50 or more belonging to or in lawful possession or custody of another.
- Gambling: The intentional, unlawful participation in gambling activities involving amounts of \$100 or more.
- Discharging of any pistol, rifle, shotgun, air gun or any other device.
- Possession of, Use of, or Intent to Use a Weapon: See the Handbook section on Weapons and Dangerous Instruments and GA Code: O.C.G.A. § 16-11-127.1 for definitions of weapons (Intent to use is not required for a weapons charge)
- Bomb Threats/False Reports: Any communication(s) or attempt to communicate concerning school property which has or could have the effect of interrupting the educational environment or process. Falsely reporting an incident with the knowledge that the information reported, conveyed or circulated is false. Initiating or circulating a false report or warning of an alleged occurrence or impending occurrence of a fire, bomb, explosion, crime, catastrophe, or any emergency under a circumstance in which it is likely to cause fear, evacuation of a building, place of assembly, or transportation facility, or to cause public inconvenience or alarm, or to interrupt the educational environment or process.
- Threats of Death or Serious Bodily Injury: The verbal or written communication of a threat to kill or do serious bodily injury to another person.
- Serious Bodily Injury: Infliction of “bodily harm” that dismembers, disfigures, causes permanent loss of a limb or function of an organ and causes substantial risk of death
- Sex Offenses: Engaging in sexual activities on school grounds or during school activities
- Sexual Battery: Acts of a sexual nature including, but not limited to, sexual battery, attempted rape, or rape when a person has not given or is unable to give consent.
- Sexual Harassment: Non-physical and unwelcome sexual advances, lewd gestures or verbal conduct or communication of a sexual nature; requests for sexual favors; gender-based harassment that creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive educational or work environment
- Battery/Assault: actual and intentional physical attack causing bodily harm, disability or permanent disfigurement by use of a weapon or without
- Unjustified activation or tampering with fire alarm system, fire extinguishers, security alarm system, or other safety equipment.
- Fleeing a school employee to elude contact or questioning.
- Defiance of school employee’s authority; such as refusal to turn over unauthorized items, refusal of a search (with reasonable suspicion), refusal to leave an unauthorized area, using an extremely disrespectful tone/demeanor in conjunction with refusal to comply.
- Use of obscene and/or offensive manifestations (verbal, written, gesture) directed toward a school employee or volunteer and/or use of offensive manifestations (verbal, written, gesture) which are deemed to create a hostile environment including racial comments.
- Trespassing: Willfully entering or remaining in or on any structure, conveyance or property without being authorized, licensed or invited, or having initially been authorized, licensed or invited, having been warned by an authorized person to depart and refusing to do so.
- Computer Trespass: Unauthorized use of a computer or computer network with the intention of deleting, obstructing, interrupting, altering, damaging, obtaining, confidential information or any way causing the malfunction or the computer, network, program(s) or data; includes disclosure of a number, code, password, or other means or access to school computers or the school system computer network without proper authorization. Includes but not limited to hacking; changing workstation or printer configuration; intentionally bypassing network filtering and security to visit inappropriate sites; forgery, alteration, or use of another user’s files, work, or password; or misuse of any school’s document, record, or instrument of identification.
- Gang-Related: The solicitation of others for gang membership, the defacing of school or personal property with gang related symbols or slogans threatening or intimidating on behalf of the gang, the requirement or

payment for protection or insurance through a gang. Gang related slogans, names, apparel, etc. are not permitted on any school campus or at any school related activity.

- Vandalism: Participation in the willful/malicious destruction, damage or defacement of school property or private property with damages in excess of \$200
- Bullying: Repeated written, verbal, or physical acts that threaten, harass, humiliate, coerce, or otherwise intimidate that are so severe, persistent, or pervasive that they have an effect of substantially interfering with a student's education
- Soliciting, inciting, procuring, causing, aiding, abetting or assisting another to commit any of the foregoing offenses.
- Falsely alleging inappropriate behavior by a teacher or other personnel.
- Inappropriate use of technology including but not limited to cell phones:
 - sending/displaying/downloading offensive messages or pictures
 - filming/ distributing/ possessing video of student disorder
 - sending information to others in a manner that constitutes Honor Code violations and/or cheating
- Honor Code Violations and/or Cheating: Inappropriate use of technology including but not limited to cell phones such as sending information to others in a manner that constitutes Honor Code violations and/or cheating, including the unauthorized use of AI
- Harassment: Stalking, teasing, taunting through the use of epithets or slurs involving race, ethnicity, national origin, religion, religious practices, gender, sexual orientation, age, or disability that disrupts the educational process.
- Threat/Intimidation: Physical, verbal, written, or electronic threat which creates fear or harm and/or conveys a serious expression of intent to harm without displaying a weapon or subjecting victims to physical attack.
- Retaliation against another student who informed/testified against him/her - major retaliation
- Disorderly Conduct - any act that substantially disrupts the orderly conduct of the school, school function, or the learning environment
- Violation of Behavior Contract, if a student has been placed on a Behavior Contract due to previous chronic or major infractions.
- Formally charged with violations of criminal laws and whose presence on the school campus may endanger the safety of other students or cause substantial disruption to school operations
- Any other offense which the principal/assistant principal may deem reasonable to fall within this category after consideration of extenuating circumstances.

*****Important Note: Urging others to disregard the Code of Conduct may result in a referral equal to the level of the actual offense invoked.**

The school administrators, teachers, and Governing Board have broad discretion to determine consequences for student misconduct. Because behavior is situational, professional judgment must be utilized. Every effort to make fair and impartial decisions will be made.

Repeated Violations. Students who continually refuse to follow rules and/or disrupt the learning environment may be charged with repeated violations of the Student Behavior Code and referred to the discipline tribunal. This rule applies after attempts have been made by the teachers and school administrators to correct such behavior.

Criminal Law Violation. A student who has been formally charged with violations of the criminal laws and whose presence on the school campus may endanger the safety of other students or cause substantial disruption to school operations will be subject to referral to a hearing tribunal. Off campus conduct may result in a referral to the tribunal.

Behavior Not Covered Above. In cases of disruptive, disorderly, or dangerous conduct not covered in this code, the principal may undertake corrective measures that she believes to be in the best interest of the student and the school, provided such action does not violate school board policy or procedures.

*Parents and Students will sign an acknowledgement page for this handbook and Code of Conduct - failure or refusal to sign does not absolve students/parents of any responsibility for information contained in this Code of Conduct.

Teacher Reporting Requirement

A teacher shall have the authority to manage his or her classroom, discipline students, and refer a student to the School Administration to maintain discipline in the classroom. Any teacher who has knowledge that a student has exhibited behavior which violates the student code of conduct and repeatedly or substantially interferes with the teacher's ability to communicate effectively with the students in his/her class or with the ability of such student's classmates to learn, shall file a report of such behavior with the principal or his/her designee. The school administrators and teacher shall thereafter follow the procedures set forth in Georgia law, specifically O.C.G.A § 20-2-737-738.

School Resource Officers (SRO)

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy employs School Resource Officers (SRO). An SRO is a **sworn law enforcement officer with specialized training for the school environment, serving as a liaison between the school, law enforcement, and the community**. SROs perform a variety of duties including law enforcement, counseling, and education, with the goal of creating a safe and positive learning environment. **SROs are trained law enforcement officers with the power and duty to make arrests and enforce laws.**

SAFE STUDENT BUS RIDING INSTRUCTIONS

Safety Rules at the Bus Stop

- Be at the designated bus stop five minutes before time for the bus to arrive.
- Wait a safe distance of 12 feet from the road and be prepared to quickly board the bus.
- Refrain from pushing, horseplay, or any other unsafe activity while at the bus stop.
- Wait for the bus to come to a complete stop, wait for the red stop sign to come out, the red flashing lights to activate, and for the door to completely open before approaching the bus.
- Wait until the bus stops; then walk to the door and board the bus in an orderly manner.
- When having to cross the road, wait on your side of the road for the bus to arrive.
- Wait for the driver to give a hand signal that it is ok to cross the road (Stop, look, listen).
- Be sure all traffic has stopped both ways before crossing the road.
- If you miss the bus, do not chase after the bus; go back home and tell your parents.

Safety Rules for Entering and Exiting the Bus at the Stop and at the School

- Walk in front of the bus to stay in the driver's view when crossing the road; never cross the road behind a school bus.
- Load the bus in single file without making contact with the one in front of you.
- No pushing, shoving, or horseplay while loading the bus.
- Use the handrail when entering or exiting the bus.
- Board the bus quickly and safely and get seated as promptly as possible
- Do not linger around the bus after exiting the bus; clear the roadway as far as possible.

- While unloading at the school, unload from the front to the back of the bus.
- When stepping off the bus onto the bus ramp, keep moving and go straight to the sidewalk.
- Never stop to get mail from the mailbox until the bus has moved and traffic is flowing again.
- Never return to the bus without first getting the driver's attention first.
- Never retrieve a dropped item around the bus unless you get the driver's attention first.
- At any time, if the bus horn sounds, this is a signal for danger and you should react quickly to the bus driver's directions to avoid injury.
- Remove ear buds and/or headphones when loading/unloading the bus.

Safety Rules While on the Bus

- Follow your bus driver's instructions at all times.
- Remain in your seat until the bus reaches your school/home and has come to a complete stop.
- Keep your voice at a normal speaking level while speaking to other students.
- Keep conversation to the driver to a minimum while the bus is moving.
- Never speak to the driver while loading and unloading at another student's stop.
- Be completely silent at all railroad crossings until the bus has completely cleared the tracks.

Bus Evacuation Guidelines

- When any type of evacuation occurs, you must follow the instructions of the driver to safely unload and to relocate when possible, at least
100 feet in the direction away from the hazard and the roadway.
- Evacuation will be practiced on your bus..
- All buses are designed with several "emergency exits" these locations are, but not limited to, the entrance/exit door, rear door, emergency exit windows and roof hatches.
- Always use the front entrance/exit door during an evacuation when possible.
- All other exits should be used only when the front entrance/exit door and the rear exit door are not available to use.
- When loading door is not available and the rear door is the chosen exit, selected older/mature student are instructed to assist you to the ground by sitting and sliding out feet first.
- Leave all personal belongings on the bus and to exit from the front to the back of the selected exit location.

Additional Guidelines:

- Conversation with the driver or behavior distracting the driver during loading and unloading of the bus should be avoided; during this critical time, complete concentration by the driver is required.
- Any type of behavior which is distracting to the driver during loading and unloading of buses should be avoided; during this critical time complete concentration by the driver is required.
- Parents should avoid conversation with the driver during loading and unloading; during this critical time, complete concentration by the driver is required.

BUS DISCIPLINE: PCA/SCCA is vitally concerned about the safety and welfare of the students riding buses. In an effort to inform students and parents or guardians of acts that can threaten safety and welfare, bus rules and regulations have been adopted. The driver, together with the transportation supervisor and the school principal, shall have full responsibility for discipline on buses.

Bus Regulations:

1. Students shall obey the driver willingly and promptly. The driver is in full charge of the bus and students.

2. The driver has the right to assign seats as he/she deems necessary.
3. Students are to help keep their bus clean by not throwing trash on the floor. Students shall not throw any object out the windows.
4. No student shall at any time extend his head, hands, arms or any part of his body out the window.
5. Damages done to buses or equipment must be paid by that individual.
6. No bottles or cans, knives, sharp objects, or any object that might endanger another student cannot be brought onto the bus at any time.
7. Students must ride the bus on which they have been assigned.
8. Students should remain seated and should face the front of the bus at all times.
9. Students shall behave in an appropriate and orderly manner.
10. Students will be totally silent at all railroad crossings.
11. At the driver's discretion, food and drink may be allowed on the school bus. Plastic water bottles are allowed.
12. Students shall be prohibited from using mirrors, lasers, flash cameras, or any other lights or reflective devices in a manner that might interfere with the school bus manager's/driver's operation of the school bus.
13. At the driver's discretion, the use of electronic devices may be allowed on the school bus under the following circumstances:
 - **Students should keep electronic equipment packed away when preparing to board and when getting off the bus. They should never use an electronic device or wear earbuds when loading or unloading. They must be able to hear.**
 - Bus drivers have the right to ban or confiscate electronic devices if used in a manner that might interfere with the school bus communications equipment or the school bus driver's operation of the school bus.

Bus Discipline Referrals:

When a referral is sent to the office for a student for breaking a minor bus rule, the consequence may include but not limited to:

1st offense – warning by the administrator and possible reassignment of seat and/or up to 2 days bus suspension.

2nd offense – three day loss of bus riding privileges

3rd offense - five day loss of bus riding privileges

4th offense - ten day loss of bus riding privileges

5th offense – fifteen day loss of bus riding privileges

6th offense - permanent bus suspension

Major infractions that fall under the Code of Conduct will be treated as regular referral and fall under the Violations of the Code of Conduct Guidelines and/or may result in permanent bus suspension. *Out of school suspension and loss of bus privileges will run concurrently.

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy 2026-2027 Assessment Calendar

ASSESSMENT	DATES
Fall MAP Growth	August 10-21
Dibels (Literacy Screener/Benchmark AND Dyslexia Screener)	August 10-21
Beacon Early Years Assessment	August 10-21
GKIDS Readiness Check	First 30 days of school
WIDA Screener	First 30 days of school
PSAT (10 th grade)	October (TBD)
Winter MAP Growth	Nov. 30 - Dec. 11
Beacon Early Years Assessment	Nov. 30 - Dec. 11
Dibels (Literacy Screener/Benchmark)	Dec. 7-17
ACCESS	January 6 - February 26
Gifted Testing	January 5 - February 11
Spring MAP Growth	March 16-26
GAA	March 22 – April 30
End of Pathway Assessment	April 22
Dibels (Literacy Screener/Benchmark)	April 26-May 7
Milestones EOG	April 26 – May 7
Milestones EOC	May 3 – May 14
Advanced Placement Exams	May 10 (Alt. May 18)
GKIDS Closes	May 17
Milestones EOG and EOC Retests	June 21-24

Detailed Milestones Calendar

April/May 2027						
	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	
	26	27 3 rd -8 th ELA	28 3 rd -8 th ELA	29 3 rd -8 th Math	30 Makeups	
	3 Makeups	4 5 & 8 Science Lit/Comp II	5 8 Social Studies Lit/Comp II	6 Biology US History	7 Makeups	
	10 Algebra 1	11 Makeups	12 Makeups	13 Makeups	14	

Milestones Retests Dates:

June 21 -24

INFORMATION FOR PARENTS ON HOMELESSNESS

If your family lacks a fixed, regular and adequate nighttime residence and is forced to live in any of the following situations:

- Sharing the housing of other persons due to loss of housing, economic hardship, or a similar reason (example: evicted from home, etc.)
- In a motel, hotel, campground or similar setting due to lack of alternative adequate accommodations.
- In an emergency or transitional shelter.
- Have a primary nighttime residence that is not designed for or ordinarily used as a regular sleeping accommodation for humans.
- In a car, park, public space, abandoned building, substandard housing, bus or train station, or similar setting.

Then your children have the right to:

- Enroll in school without proof of residency, immunization, school records, or other documents.
- Attend school and participate in school programs with children who are not homeless. Children cannot be separated from the regular school programs because they are homeless.
- Receive all the school services available to other students.

Local Contact:

Kathy Martin, Homeless Liaison Email: kmartin@pataula.net

18637 Hartford Street

Edison, Georgia 39846

Phone: 229-354-4001 Fax: 229-835-2233

Right to Know Notification

Right to Know Professional Qualifications of Teachers and Paraprofessionals

Date: **July 1, 2026**

Dear Parents,

In compliance with the requirements of the Every Students Succeeds Act, **Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy** would like to inform you that you may request information about the professional qualifications of your student's teacher(s) and/ or paraprofessional(s). The following information may be requested:

- Whether the student's teacher—
 - has met State qualification and licensing criteria for the grade levels and subject areas in which the teacher provides instruction;
 - is teaching under emergency or other provisional status through which State qualification or licensing criteria have been waived; and
 - is teaching in the field of discipline of the certification of the teacher.
- Whether the child is provided services by paraprofessionals and, if so, their qualifications.

If you wish to request information concerning your child's teacher's and/or paraprofessional's qualifications, please contact the **Principal**.

Sincerely,

Christina Boyd, Principal
Pataula Charter Academy
229-354-4001
christinaboyd@pataula.net

Heather Worsley, Principal
Spring Creek Charter Academy
229-792-8957
hworsley@sccak12.net

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Child Abuse or Neglect Reporting Policy**

Mandated Reporting

Any school employee or volunteer who suspects child abuse or maltreatment is mandated to report and is authorized to report to DFCS and/or Law Enforcement as required by law pursuant to Code Section 19-7-5 of the Official Code of Georgia Annotated (O.C.G.A.).

Mandated reporters include teachers, administrators, counselors, visiting teachers, school social workers, psychologists, and volunteers.

As mandated by Georgia law O.C.G.A 19-7-5, any employee or volunteer of Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy having cause to believe that a child under the age of eighteen (18) has been subjected to child abuse as defined below shall immediately report their belief to the School Counselor, or in her absence the Principal.

Child Abuse means:

- Physical injury or death inflicted upon a child by a parent, guardian, legal custodian, or other person responsible for the care of such child by other than accidental means; provided, however, that physical forms of discipline may be used as long as there is no physical injury to the child;
- Neglect of a child by a parent, guardian, legal custodian, or other person responsible for the care of such child;
- Emotional abuse of a child;
- Sexual abuse or sexual exploitation of a child;
- Prenatal abuse of a child by a parent;
- An act or failure to act that presents an imminent risk of serious harm to the child's physical, mental, or emotional health; or
- Trafficking a child for labor servitude.

The Counselor, Principal, or designee shall make a report of child abuse and neglect to the appropriate Department of Family and Children Services (“DFCS”) as soon as reasonably possible, but no later than twenty-four (24) hours from the time there is reasonable cause to believe that suspected child abuse has occurred.

The Counselor and/or Principal will provide training annually for professional staff in the identification of children suspected of being neglected or abused. The training will include procedures for reporting such cases. Initial training may be provided through Pro Solutions Training online service.

Mandated Reporter Requirements

1. If any employee has reasonable cause to suspect child abuse, sexual abuse, molestation, neglect or exploitation has occurred, the employee must report it or face criminal penalties and employment penalties, including but not limited to termination. When in doubt, the

employee shall report the suspicion to protect the interest of the child and to fulfill their legal duty to report.

2. If any employee is aware of an allegation of child abuse of a student by a parent or caregiver (including an employee), the allegation shall be reported immediately and in accordance with this policy and as soon as possible. Employees should not wait until the end of the day or the following day to make a report under any circumstances. If you are unable to reach an administrator after several reasonable attempts, the employee should make the report themselves by calling the Child Abuse hotline (1-855-GACHILD). If an employee is made aware of allegations after-hours and feels the child is in immediate danger, the employee should call the hotline as well.

3. If any employee reports to the Counselor or Principal that the employee has reasonable cause to suspect the student is subject to child abuse, sexual abuse, molestation, neglect or exploitation, or that the employee has received an allegation of child abuse by a parent or caregiver (including employees), the Counselor, Principal, or their designee shall submit a complete report to the Department of Family and Children Services as soon as possible, but no later than the 24 hour requirement.

4. If any employee is alleged to have committed child abuse or neglect, in addition to submitting a report to DFCS as required under Paragraph (3) above, the Principal shall conduct a prompt investigation to determine whether any inappropriate or unprofessional conduct was taken by the employee. The Principal should:

- solicit the assistance of involved school employees to assist in their investigation; and,
- contact DFCS and request all documents pertaining to the employees' case, as allowed by law, and should interview the employee, if possible. If an employee refuses to cooperate in the school system's investigation, the employee may be charged with insubordination.

At a minimum, the findings of the investigation shall be submitted to the Superintendent and Board of Directors, if necessary, and should include:

- the steps taken to investigate the allegation;
- the findings as to whether the employee engaged in unprofessional or inappropriate conduct;
- the recommendation of what action should be taken, if any, as a result of the investigation; and,
- the rationale for recommended action, if any, or rationale for lack of action, if any.

5. The legal requirement to report suspected child abuse or neglect is applicable to any adult school volunteer. Therefore, mandated reporter training will be required of all school volunteers. School volunteers will be notified of such reporting requirement and required training through the parent handbook and on the school website.

6. Mandated reporters are legally required to report suspected child abuse regardless of whether it is based on a privileged/confidential communication.

Student Reporting of Alleged Sexually Inappropriate Behavior

Reporting

Any student (*or parent or friend of a student*) who has been the victim of an act of sexual abuse or sexual misconduct by a teacher, administrator, other school system employee, or volunteer affiliated with the school should make an oral report of the act to any teacher, counselor, school nurse, or administrator at his/her school.

Any teacher, counselor or administrator receiving a report of sexual abuse or sexual misconduct of a student by a teacher, administrator, other employee, or volunteer affiliated with the school shall make an oral report of the incident immediately by telephone or otherwise to the school principal or principal's designee, and shall submit a written report of the incident to the school principal or principal's designee within 24 hours. *If the principal is the person accused of the sexual abuse or sexual misconduct, the oral and written reports should be made to the superintendent or the superintendent's designee.*

Sexual Abuse

Any school principal or principal's designee receiving a report of sexual abuse as defined in O.C.G.A. § 19-7-5 shall make an oral report to a DHS child welfare agency providing protective services, appropriate law enforcement, or district attorney immediately, but in no case later than 24 hours from the time there is reasonable cause to believe a child has been abused. The report should be made by telephone and followed by a written report in writing, if requested, to a child welfare agency providing protective services, as designated by the Department of Human Resources, or, in the absence of such agency, to an appropriate police authority or district attorney.

Sexual Misconduct

Reports of acts of sexual misconduct against a student by a teacher, administrator, other employee, or volunteer not covered by O.C.G.A. §§ 19-7-5 or 20-2-1184 shall be investigated immediately by school personnel. If the investigation of the allegation of sexual misconduct indicates a reasonable cause to believe that the report of sexual misconduct is valid, the school principal or principal's designee shall make an immediate written report to the superintendent and the Professional Standards Commission Ethics Division (if applicable).

**Adopted on January 11, 2016

Amended: 2-24-2020

Amended 8-24-2020

Amended 6/21/2021

Amended 1/22/2024

Amended 9/16/2024

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy

TITLE IX SEXUAL HARASSMENT POLICY

Purpose

Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 ("Title IX") prohibits sex discrimination in educational programs or activities receiving Federal financial assistance. This policy and the administrative procedures that implement it have been adopted in accordance with the new federal Title IX regulations, which are in effect as of August 14, 2020.[1]

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy ("School") does not discriminate and does not permit discrimination on the basis of sex in its employment practices, educational programs, or other activities that it operates.

The purpose of this policy and the administrative procedures that implement it is to secure

prompt and equitable resolutions of complaints based on sex discrimination, including complaints of sexual harassment, in violation of Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, and violation of School policies that prohibit this type of discrimination. This policy and administrative procedures only apply to complaints alleging discrimination on the basis of sex as prohibited by Title IX as defined herein. This policy and the administrative procedures shall be available in the School administrative office, posted on the School website, and included in student and employee handbooks. Annually, the School will provide notice of its grievance procedures and grievance process, to applicants for admission and employment; students; parents or legal guardians of students; employees, and all unions or professional organizations with whom it holds collective bargaining or professional agreements, if any. This notice shall include, at a minimum, the name and contact information for the School's Title IX Coordinator, and information on how to report or file a complaint of sexual discrimination or sexual harassment, how to report or file a formal complaint of sexual harassment, and how the School will respond.

The School has appointed the following individual as its **TITLE IX COORDINATOR**, who shall be responsible for coordinating the School's response to all allegations involving possible sexual harassment. The Title IX Coordinator can be reached at:

NAME: Kylie Holley

ADDRESS: 18909 Hartford St, PO Box 332, Edison, GA 39846

PHONE: 229-354-4001

EMAIL ADDRESS: kholley@pataula.net

Sexual Harassment is defined as conduct on the basis of sex that satisfies one or more of the following:

- (1) An employee of the School conditioning the provision of an aid, benefit, or service of the School on an individual's participation in unwelcome sexual conduct (quid-pro-quo); or
- (2) Unwelcome conduct determined by a reasonable person to be so severe, pervasive, and objectively offensive that it effectively denies a person equal access to the School's education program or activity; or
- (3) "Sexual assault" as defined in 20 U.S.C. 1092(f)(6)(A)(v), "dating violence" as defined in 34 U.S.C. 12291(a)(10), "domestic violence" as defined in 34 U.S.C. 12291(a)(8), or "stalking" as defined in 34 U.S.C. 12291(a)(30).

Reporting

Any School employee with actual knowledge of sex discrimination, including sexual harassment in an education program or activity as defined in the Policy, must report the sex discrimination to the Title IX Coordinator. Failure to report may result in disciplinary action against the employee, up to and including termination.

Any person may report sex discrimination, including sexual harassment as defined by this Policy, (whether or not the person reporting is the person alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sex discrimination or sexual harassment), to the Title IX Coordinator in person, by mail, by telephone, by electronic mail, or through other means specified by the School. Reports may be made at any time, including during non-business hours.

The School shall not require waiver of the right to an investigation and adjudication of formal complaints of sexual harassment as a condition of enrollment or continuing enrollment, or employment or continuing employment, or enjoyment of any other right.

Definitions

Actual Notice means notice of sexual harassment or allegations of sexual harassment to a School's Title IX Coordinator or any official of the School who has authority to institute corrective measures on behalf of the School, or to any employee of an elementary and secondary school. Imputation of knowledge based solely on vicarious liability or constructive notice is insufficient to constitute actual knowledge. This standard is not met when the only official of the School with actual knowledge is the Respondent. The mere ability or obligation to report sexual harassment or to inform a student about how to report sexual harassment, or having been trained to do so, does not qualify an individual as one who has authority to institute corrective measures on behalf of the School. "Notice" as used in this paragraph includes, but is not limited to, a report of sexual harassment to the Title IX Coordinator.

Appeal Officer means a trained individual appointed by the School who will review and make a decision on a properly filed appeal. The Appeal Officer must be free from bias or conflict of interest and must not be the Title IX Coordinator, the Investigator, or the Decision Maker(s).

Complainant is an individual, a student or employee, who is alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment. The Complainant must be participating in or attempting to participate in an education program of the School. Where the Title IX Coordinator signs a formal complaint, the Title IX Coordinator is not a Complainant or otherwise a party under this Policy, unless the Title IX Coordinator is alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment.

Decision Maker means the trained person(s) responsible for making a determination regarding responsibility. The Decision Maker cannot be the same person(s) as the Title IX Coordinator, the Investigator, or the Appeal Officer.

Education Program or Activity means locations, events, or circumstances over which the School exercised substantial control over both the Respondent and the context in which the sexual harassment occurs.

Formal complaint means a document filed by a Complainant or signed by the Title IX Coordinator alleging sexual harassment against a Respondent and requesting that the School investigate the allegation of sexual harassment. At the time of filing a formal complaint, a Complainant must be participating in or attempting to participate in the education program or activity of the School with which the formal complaint is filed. A formal complaint may be filed with the Title IX Coordinator in person, by mail, or by electronic mail, by using the contact information listed for the Title IX Coordinator, or by any other method specified by the School. As used in this paragraph, the phrase "document filed by a Complainant" means a document or electronic submission (such as by

electronic mail or through an online portal provided for this purpose by the School) that contains the Complainant's physical or digital signature, or otherwise indicates that the Complainant is the person filing the formal complaint.

Grievance Process means the provisions, rules, or practices included within this Policy and the administrative procedures for processing formal complaints of sexual harassment. The Grievance Process shall be applied equally to both the Complainant and the Respondent.

Investigator means a trained person(s) appointed by the School who is tasked with conducting the investigation into allegations of sexual harassment addressed in a formal complaint. The Investigator does not need to be an employee of the School and may be outside counsel or any other person designated by the School. The Investigator shall not be the Decision Maker or the Appeal Officer; When possible, the Investigator should not be the Title IX Coordinate.

Remedial Actions or Remedial Remedies means those actions intended to restore or preserve a Complainant's equal access to the educational programs and activities of the School.

Respondent is any individual who has been reported to be the perpetrator of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment.

Standard of Evidence means the *preponderance of evidence* standard that is to be used during the investigation and final determination of a formal complaint. Preponderance of evidence means that the evidence shows that the action alleged is more likely to have occurred than not to have occurred. This standard shall be applied for all formal complaints of sexual harassment against students and employees.

Supportive measures means non-disciplinary, non-punitive individualized services offered as appropriate, as reasonably available, and without fee or charge to the Complainant or the Respondent before or after the filing of a formal complaint or where no formal complaint has been filed. Such measures are designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity without unreasonably burdening the other party, including measures designed to protect the safety of all parties or the School's educational environment, or deter sexual harassment. Supportive measures may include counseling, extensions of deadlines or other course-related adjustments, modifications of work or class schedules, campus escort services, mutual restrictions on contact between the parties, changes in work or housing locations, leaves of absence, increased security and monitoring of certain areas of the campus, and other similar measures. The School must maintain as confidential any supportive measures provided to the Complainant or Respondent, to the extent that maintaining such confidentiality would not impair the ability of the School to provide the supportive measures. The Title IX Coordinator is responsible for coordinating the effective implementation of supportive measures.

Response

Upon receipt obtaining actual knowledge of sexual harassment in an education program or activity of the School against a person in the United States, the School must respond promptly in a manner that is not deliberately indifferent. A School is deliberately indifferent only if its response to sexual harassment is clearly unreasonable in light of the known circumstances.

Upon receipt of a report of alleged sexual harassment, the Title IX Coordinator will promptly contact the Complainant and discuss the following:

- a) The availability of supportive measures that are available to the Complainant to immediately restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity without unreasonably burdening the other party.

- b) The availability of supportive measures with or without the filing of a formal complaint; and
- c) The process for filing the formal complaint.

In each instance, the School must document the basis for its conclusion that its response was not deliberately indifferent, and document that it has taken measures designed to restore or preserve equal access to its education program or activity. If the School does not provide a Complainant with supportive measures, then the reasons why such a response was not clearly unreasonable in light of the known circumstances must be documented. The documentation of certain bases or measures does not limit the School in the future from providing additional explanations or detailing additional measures taken.

The filing of a formal complaint does not preclude the School from responding to the complaint by also applying other School policy violations, including but not limited to, Code of Conduct violations, violations of the Student or Employee Handbook, or allegations that are not related to sexual harassment. Non-sexual harassment allegations and/or findings shall be promptly reported to the Principal or the supervisor of the Respondent to process pursuant to the School's applicable policies, including its disciplinary policies.

If the Complainant refuses to initiate a formal complaint, the Title IX Coordinator may submit a signed, written formal complaint to initiate a formal investigation and complaint process, regardless of the Complainant/Complainant's parent's or guardian's consent, if based upon the allegations and information received there is the possible likelihood of sexual harassment. The Title IX Coordinator shall submit a signed, written formal complaint to initiate a formal investigation and complaint process, regardless of the Complainant/Complainant's parent's or guardian's consent, if the allegations and information received involve sexual harassment of a student by an employee.

Throughout the course of the investigation of the formal complaint and throughout the grievance process (collectively, "Formal Complaint Process"), the burden of proof and burden of gathering evidence sufficient to reach a determination regarding responsibility rests on the School and not on the parties.

Any individual designated by the School as a Title IX Coordinator, Investigator, Decision- Maker, or any person designated by the School to facilitate an informal resolution process, must not have a conflict of interest or bias for or against Complainants or Respondents generally or an individual Complainant or Respondent. If any party alleges a conflict of interest or bias, the Superintendent shall appoint another person to fulfill the role of the person alleged to have a conflict of interest.

The School will endeavor to complete investigations within sixty (60) days of the date on which the formal complaint was received; however, the School's primary objective is a thorough and equitable investigation and grievance process.

The School shall coordinate its investigation and grievance process with any other ongoing criminal investigation of the incident, if any. The School may determine whether to delay its investigation pending the conclusion of a criminal investigation or for criminal proceedings to begin. If the fact-finding portion of the investigation is suspended due to the existence of a criminal investigation, the School's investigation shall resume promptly once law enforcement officials have completed their evidence gathering state of the criminal investigation.

School employees and students are required to participate fully in an investigation, but in no event will a Complainant be subjected to any disciplinary sanctions or consequences for refusing or failing to participate.

An informal resolution process may be facilitated at any time after the Formal Complaint is filed and prior to the determination regarding responsibility, with the exception that an informal resolution is not permitted to resolve

allegations that an employee of the School sexually harassed a student.

Upon a finding of responsibility, disciplinary sanctions against an employee may include any available sanction available for the discipline of employees, up to and including termination. Disciplinary sanctions against a student may include any available discipline or sanction, up to and including expulsion, under the policies, rules and procedures established by the School.

If an employee subject to possible discipline for violations of this Policy retires or resigns prior to the completion of the investigation, or before a final disposition is made, or during the course of a disciplinary hearing, the Superintendent shall report the allegations to the Georgia Professional Standards Commission.

No person shall, for the purpose of interfering with any right or privilege secured by Title IX

or this Policy, intimidate, threaten, coerce, or discriminate against any individual who is the victim of or who reports alleged sexual harassment or testifies, assists, or participates in an investigation, final determination of any proceeding or hearing related to a sexual harassment complaint. Should retaliation occur, the victim shall promptly report the actions to the Principal or the Title IX Coordinator. Persons found guilty of retaliation shall be subject to discipline.

Training

Title IX Coordinators, Investigators, Decision Makers, and any person who facilitates an informal resolution process, must receive training on the following:

- definition of sexual harassment;
- the scope of the School's education program or activity;
- how to conduct an investigation and grievance process including hearings, appeals, and informal resolution processes, as applicable; and
- how to serve impartially, including by avoiding prejudgment of the facts at issue, conflicts of interest, and bias.

Decision Makers must also receive training on any technology to be used at a live hearing and on issues of relevance of questions and evidence, including when questions and evidence about the Complainant's sexual predisposition or prior sexual behavior are not relevant.

Investigators must receive training on issues of relevance to create an investigative report that fairly summarizes relevant evidence.

Any materials used to train Title IX Coordinators, Investigators, Decision Makers, and any person who facilitates an informal resolution process, must not rely on sex stereotypes and must promote impartial investigations and adjudications of formal complaints of sexual harassment.

Training Materials: <https://sites.ed.gov/titleix/policy/> and GAEL Hearing Officer Training

Recordkeeping

The School must maintain records for a period of seven years, including:

- 1) Each sexual harassment investigation including any determination regarding responsibility and any

required audio or audiovisual recording or transcript, any disciplinary sanctions imposed on the Respondent, and any remedies provided to the Complainant designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity;

- 2) Any appeal and result;
- 3) Any information resolution and result;
- 4) Records of the School's response upon obtaining actual knowledge of sexual harassment in an education program or activity under its control, including records of any actions, including any supportive measures, taken in response to a report or formal complaint of sexual harassment. In each instance, the School must document the basis for its conclusion that its response was not deliberately indifferent, and document that it has taken measures designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity. If a School does not provide a Complainant with supportive measures, then the School must document the reasons why such a response was not clearly unreasonable in light of the known circumstances. The documentation of certain bases or measures does not limit the School in the future from providing additional explanations or detailing additional measures taken.
- 5) All materials used to train Title IX Coordinators, Investigators, Decision Makers, and any person who facilitates an informal resolution process. A School must make these training materials publicly available on its website, or if the School does not maintain a website, the School must make these materials available upon request for inspection by members of the public.

TITLE IX FORMAL GRIEVANCE PROCESS

The purpose of this grievance process is to address formal complaints of sexual harassment. The process shall be triggered upon receipt of a formal complaint by the Title IX Coordinator.

Any School employee with actual knowledge of sex discrimination, including sexual harassment in an education program or activity as defined in the Policy, must report the sex discrimination to the Title IX Coordinator. Failure to report may result in disciplinary action against the employee, up to and including termination.

Any person may report sex discrimination, including sexual harassment as defined by this Policy, (whether or not the person reporting is the person alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sex discrimination or sexual harassment), to the Title IX Coordinator in person, by mail, by telephone, by electronic mail, or through other means specified by the School. Reports may be made at any time, including during non-business hours.

Complainants and Respondents shall be treated equitably throughout the process. All evidence, both inculpatory and exculpatory, shall be evaluated objectively. An individual's status as a Respondent will not be considered a negative factor during consideration of the grievance. Respondents are entitled to, and will receive the benefit of, a presumption that they are not responsible for the alleged conduct until the grievance process concludes and a determination regarding responsibility is issued. Similarly, credibility determinations will not be based on a person's status as a Complainant, Respondent, or witness.

The presumption shall be that the Respondent is not responsible for the alleged conduct until a determination regarding responsibility is made at the conclusion of the grievance process. No disciplinary sanctions or other actions that are not supportive measures shall be imposed against a Respondent prior to the completion of the grievance process. Upon determination of responsibility for sexual harassment by a Respondent, the Complainant shall be provided remedies designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity. Such remedies may include the same individualized services as "supportive measures"; however, remedies need not be non-disciplinary or non-punitive and need not avoid burdening the Respondent.

Retaliation against anyone for participation in this process is strictly prohibited.

Definitions

Actual Notice means notice of sexual harassment or allegations of sexual harassment to a School's Title IX Coordinator or any official of the School who has authority to institute corrective measures on behalf of the School, or to any employee of an elementary and secondary school. Imputation of knowledge based solely on vicarious liability or constructive notice is insufficient to constitute actual knowledge. This standard is not met when the only official of the School with actual knowledge is the Respondent. The mere ability or obligation to report sexual harassment or to inform a student about how to report sexual harassment, or having been trained to do so, does not qualify an individual as one who has authority to institute corrective measures on behalf of the School. "Notice" as used in this paragraph includes, but is not limited to, a report of sexual harassment to the Title IX Coordinator.

Appeal Officer means a trained individual appointed by the School who will review and make a decision on a properly filed appeal. The Appeal Officer must be free from bias or conflict of interest and must not be the Title IX Coordinator, the Investigator, or the Decision Maker(s).

Complainant is an individual, a student or employee, who is alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment. The Complainant must be participating in or attempting to participate in an education program of the School. Where the Title IX Coordinator signs a formal complaint, the Title IX Coordinator is not a Complainant or otherwise a party under this Policy, unless the Title IX Coordinator is alleged to be the victim of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment.

Decision Maker means the trained person(s) responsible for making a determination regarding responsibility. The Decision Maker cannot be the same person(s) as the Title IX Coordinator, the Investigator, or the Appeal Officer.

Education Program or Activity means locations, events, or circumstances over which the School exercised substantial control over both the Respondent and the context in which the sexual harassment occurs.

Formal complaint means a document filed by a Complainant or signed by the Title IX Coordinator alleging sexual harassment against a Respondent and requesting that the School investigate the allegation of sexual harassment. At the time of filing a formal complaint, a Complainant must be participating in or attempting to participate in the education program or activity of the School with which the formal complaint is filed. A formal complaint may be filed with the Title IX Coordinator in person, by mail, or by electronic mail, by using the contact information listed for the Title IX Coordinator, or by any other method specified by the School. As used in this paragraph, the phrase "document filed by a Complainant" means a document or electronic submission (such as by electronic mail or through an online portal provided for this purpose by the School) that contains the Complainant's physical or digital signature, or otherwise indicates that the Complainant is the person filing the formal complaint.

Grievance Process means the provisions, rules, or practices included within this Policy and the administrative procedures for processing formal complaints of sexual harassment. The Grievance Process shall be applied equally to both the Complainant and the Respondent.

Investigator means a trained person(s) appointed by the School who is tasked with conducting the investigation into allegations of sexual harassment addressed in a formal complaint. The Investigator does not need to be an employee of the School and may be outside counsel or any other person designated by the School. The Investigator shall not be the Title IX Coordinator, the Decision Maker, or the Appeal Officer.

Remedial Actions or Remedial Remedies means those actions intended to restore or preserve a Complainant's equal access to the educational programs and activities of the School.

Respondent is any individual who has been reported to be the perpetrator of conduct that could constitute sexual harassment.

Standard of Evidence means the *preponderance of evidence* standard that is to be used during the investigation and final determination of a formal complaint. Preponderance of evidence means that the evidence shows that the action alleged is more likely to have occurred than not to have occurred. This standard shall be applied for all formal complaints of sexual harassment against students and employees.

Supportive measures means non-disciplinary, non-punitive individualized services offered as appropriate, as reasonably available, and without fee or charge to the Complainant or the Respondent before or after the filing of a formal complaint or where no formal complaint has been filed. Such measures are designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity without unreasonably burdening the other party, including measures designed to protect the safety of all parties or the School's educational environment, or deter sexual harassment. Supportive measures may include counseling, extensions of deadlines or other course-related adjustments, modifications of work or class schedules, campus escort services, mutual restrictions on contact between the parties, changes in work or housing locations, leaves of absence, increased security and monitoring of certain areas of the campus, and other similar measures. The School must maintain as confidential any supportive measures provided to the Complainant or Respondent, to the extent that maintaining such confidentiality would not impair the ability of the School to provide the supportive measures. The Title IX Coordinator is responsible for coordinating the effective implementation of supportive measures.

Notice to Parties

Upon receipt of a formal complaint, the Title IX Coordinator must provide written notice to all known parties that includes the following:

- 1) Notice of the School's grievance process, including the informal resolution process.
- 2) Notice of the allegations of sexual harassment potentially constituting sexual harassment, including sufficient details known at the time and with sufficient time to prepare a response before any initial interview.
 - a. Sufficient details include the identities of the parties involved in the incident, if known, the conduct allegedly constituting sexual harassment, and the date and location of the alleged incident, if known.
- 3) A statement that the Respondent is presumed not responsible for the alleged conduct and that a determination regarding responsibility is made at the conclusion of the grievance process.
- 4) Notice to the parties that they may have an advisor of their choice, who may be, but is not required to be, an attorney, and may inspect and review evidence.
- 5) A statement that knowingly making false statements or knowingly submitting false information during the grievance process is prohibited and a violation of the School's code of conduct and may be subject to disciplinary action.

Written notice of the date, time, location, participants, and purpose of all hearings (if applicable), investigative interviews, or other meetings must be provided to a party whose participation is invited or expected, with sufficient time for the party to prepare to participate.

If, in the course of an investigation, the School decides to investigate allegations about the Complainant or

Respondent that are not included in the initial notice, then the School must provide subsequent notice of the additional allegations to the parties whose identities are known.

Consolidation of Complaints

The School may consolidate formal complaints as to allegations of sexual harassment against more than one Respondent, or by more than one Complainant against one or more Respondents, or by one party against the other party, where the allegations of sexual harassment arise out of the same facts or circumstances. Where a grievance process involves more than one Complainant or more than one Respondent, references in this section to the singular “party,” “Complainant,” or “Respondent” include the plural, as applicable.

Dismissal of a Formal Complaint

The School must investigate the allegations in a formal complaint. If the conduct alleged in the formal complaint would not constitute sexual harassment even if proved, did not occur in the School's education program or activity, or did not occur against a person in the United States, then the School must dismiss the formal complaint with regard to that conduct for purposes of sexual harassment under Title IX; such a dismissal does not preclude action under another provision of the School's code of conduct.

A formal complaint or any allegations therein may be dismissed, if at any time during the investigation or hearing: (1) A Complainant notifies the Title IX Coordinator in writing that the Complainant would like to withdraw the formal complaint or any allegations therein; (2) the Respondent is no longer enrolled or employed by the School; or (3) specific circumstances prevent the School from gathering evidence sufficient to reach a determination as to the formal complaint or allegations therein.

Upon a dismissal required or permitted by this policy section, the Title IX Coordinator must promptly send written notice of the dismissal and reason(s) therefore simultaneously to the parties.

INVESTIGATION

Investigator

The Title IX Coordinator will designate one or more trained individuals to investigate the formal complaint (i.e., the Investigator). The Investigator will begin an investigation as soon as practicable and generally not later than 10 business days after the written notice of the formal complaint was delivered to all parties. The Investigator, however, will ensure that the Respondent receives sufficient time to prepare prior to any initial interview.

Burden of Proof

The burden of proof and the burden of gathering evidence sufficient to reach a determination regarding responsibility rest on the School and not on the parties, provided that the School cannot access, consider, disclose, or otherwise use a party's records that are made or maintained by a physician, psychiatrist, psychologist, or other recognized professional or paraprofessional acting in the professional's or paraprofessional's capacity, or assisting in that capacity, and which are made and maintained in connection with the provision of treatment to the party, unless the School obtains that party's voluntary, written consent to do so for a grievance process under this policy (if a party is a student under the age of 18 then the School must obtain the voluntary, written consent of a his or her parent or legal guardian).

Timeline

The School will endeavor to complete investigations within sixty (60) days of the date on which the formal complaint was received; however, the School's primary objective is a thorough and equitable investigation and

grievance process.

The School shall coordinate its investigation and grievance process with any other ongoing criminal investigation of the incident, if any. The School may determine whether to delay its investigation pending the conclusion of a criminal investigation or for criminal proceedings to begin. If the fact-finding portion of the investigation is suspended due to the existence of a criminal investigation, the School's investigation shall resume promptly once law enforcement officials have completed their evidence gathering state of the criminal investigation.

In the event of a temporary delay of the process or the limited extension of time frames for good cause, the Title IX Coordinator shall provide written notice to both the Complainant and the Respondent notifying them of the delay or extension and providing the reason for the action.

Good cause for a delay of the process or extension of the time frames may include, but is not limited to, considerations such as: (a) The absence of a party; a party's advisor, or a witness; (b) Concurrent law enforcement activity; or (c) The need for language assistance or accommodation of disabilities.

Investigation Process

An investigation must include interviews with the Complainant, Respondent, and any witnesses. An investigation may include, but is not limited to, the following:

- review of any documentary or electronic evidence;
- a review of medical evidence if a waiver has been obtained by the party to which the medical records belong;
- a review of security data; and
- a review of any other material which the Investigator deems relevant to an assessment of the facts surrounding the formal complaint.

Neither party shall be restricted from discussing the allegations under investigation, nor shall they be restricted from gathering and presenting relevant evidence.

Advisors

Both parties shall have the same opportunity to have others present during any grievance proceeding, including the opportunity to be accompanied to any related meeting or proceeding by the advisor of their choice. An advisor may be, but is not required to be, an attorney. The School may not limit the choice or presence of advisor for either the Complainant or Respondent in any meeting or grievance proceeding; however, the School may establish restrictions regarding the extent to which the advisor may participate in the proceedings, as long as the restrictions apply equally to both parties.

Evidence

All parties shall have an equal opportunity to present witnesses, including fact and expert witnesses, and other inculpatory and exculpatory evidence. Credibility determinations may not be based on a person's status as a Complainant, Respondent, or witness.

Both parties shall have an equal opportunity to inspect and review any evidence obtained as part of the investigation that is directly related to the allegations raised in a formal complaint, including the evidence upon which the School does not intend to rely in reaching a determination regarding responsibility and inculpatory or exculpatory evidence whether obtained from a party or other source, so that each party can meaningfully respond

to the evidence prior to conclusion of the investigation.

Prior to completion of the investigative report, the School must send to each party and the party's advisor, if any, the evidence subject to inspection and review in an electronic format or a hard copy, and the parties must have at least 10 days to submit a written response, which the Investigator will consider prior to completion of the investigative report. If there will be a hearing, the School must make all such evidence subject to the parties' inspection and review available at any hearing to give each party equal opportunity to refer to such evidence during the hearing, including for purposes of cross-examination.

Investigative Report

Upon receipt of each party's review of the evidence or after 10 days, whichever occurs first, the Investigator must create an investigative report that fairly summarizes relevant evidence.

At least ten (10) days prior to submitting the investigative report to the Decision Maker, or prior to a hearing if one will be held, the preliminary report must be sent to each party and their advisor, if any, in an electronic format or a hard copy, for their review and written response. The Investigator shall consider the written responses prior to completion of the report and include the written responses as an exhibit to the report.

Cross-Examination

After sending the completed investigative report to both parties, elementary and secondary schools are not required to hold an in-person hearing prior to making a determination regarding responsibility. In the absence of a hearing, and prior to making a responsibility determination, the Decision Maker(s) will give each party an opportunity to submit written, relevant questions that a party wants asked of any party or witness; will provide each party with the answers; and will allow for additional, limited follow-up questions from each party. If the Decision Maker(s) determines that a proposed question is not relevant it will be excluded and an explanation must be provided to the proposing party regarding the relevancy determination. With or without a hearing, questions and evidence about the Complainant's sexual predisposition or prior sexual behavior are not relevant, unless such questions and evidence about the Complainant's prior sexual behavior are offered to prove that someone other than the Respondent committed the conduct alleged by the Complainant, or if the questions and evidence concern specific incidents of the Complainant's prior sexual behavior with respect to the Respondent and are offered to prove consent.

Determination of Responsibility

After all questions and answers have been received, the Decision Maker must issue a written determination of responsibility regarding the allegations based on a preponderance of evidence. The written determination must be provided to the parties simultaneously. The Decision Maker will strive to issue the written determination regarding responsibility within 14 days after the hearing (if one is held). The determination regarding responsibility becomes final either on the date that the School provides the parties with the written determination of the result of the appeal, if an appeal is filed, or if an appeal is not filed, the date on which an appeal would no longer be considered timely. The written determination must include the following:

- a) Identification of the allegations potentially constituting sexual harassment as defined in §106.30;
- b) A description of the procedural steps taken from the receipt of the formal complaint through the determination, including any notifications to the parties, interviews with parties and witnesses, site visits, methods used to gather other evidence, and hearings held;
- c) Findings of fact supporting the determination;

- d) Conclusions regarding the application of the School's code of conduct to the facts;
- e) A statement of, and rationale for, the result as to each allegation, including a determination regarding responsibility, any disciplinary sanctions the School imposes on the Respondent, and whether remedies designed to restore or preserve equal access to the School's education program or activity will be provided by the School to the Complainant; and
- f) The School's procedures and permissible bases for the Complainant and Respondent to appeal.

Sanctions and Remedies

The Title IX Coordinator will be responsible for the effective implementation of any resulting sanctions or remedies. The list of potential sanctions or remedies includes one or more of the following:

For Students

- Written warning;
- No-contact orders;
- Removal from specific courses or activities;
- Disciplinary probation;
- Suspension;
- Expulsion;
- Transcript notation; or
- Other sanctions as appropriate.

For Employees

- Written warning;
- Performance improvement plan;
- Required training or education;
- Loss of pay increase;
- Suspension with or without pay;
- Termination; or
- Other sanctions as appropriate.

Appeal

Either party may appeal a determination regarding responsibility or the dismissal of a formal complaint or any allegations on the following bases:

- a) Procedural irregularity that affected the outcome of the matter;
- b) New evidence that was not reasonably available at the time the determination regarding responsibility or dismissal was made, that could affect the outcome of the matter;
- c) The Title IX Coordinator, Investigator(s), or Decision Maker(s) had a conflict of interest or bias for or against Complainants or Respondents generally or the individual Complainant or Respondent that affected the outcome of the matter; or
- d) Any additional basis offered by the School.

The appeal must be submitted in writing to the Superintendent within ten (10) calendar days from receipt of the Decision Maker's final written determination. The notice of appeal must include the name of the Complainant, name of the Respondent, the decision or action being appealed, and an explanation of the grounds for appeal.

Upon receipt of an appeal, the School will provide written notice of the appeal to both parties and begin to implement appeal procedures equally for both parties. Each party will be given a ten (10) business days to provide a written statement supporting or challenging the appealed action

The Title IX Coordinator shall appoint an Appeal Officer who will review and make a decision on the appeal. The Appeal Officer must be free from bias or conflict of interest and must not be the Title IX Coordinator, the Investigator, or the Decision Maker(s).

As soon as is reasonably practicable, and generally within fourteen (14) business days after receipt of the parties' written statements, the Appeal Officer will issue a written decision regarding the appeal simultaneously to both parties. The decision will describe the result of the appeal and the rationale for the decision. The decision of the Appeal Officer is final.

INFORMAL RESOLUTION

At any time after a formal complaint is filed and before a determination regarding responsibility is made, the School may facilitate an informal resolution process, such as mediation, that does not involve a full investigation and adjudication.

Informal resolution may not be required as a condition of enrollment or employment or continued enrollment or employment, or enjoyment of any other right. Additionally, informal resolution may not be used to resolve allegations that an employee sexually harassed a student.

All parties must provide voluntary, written consent to move forward with the informal resolution process. However, at any time prior to agreeing to a resolution, any party has the right to withdraw from the informal resolution process and resume the grievance process with respect to the formal complaint.

Prior to beginning informal resolution, parties must be notified in writing of (1) the allegations; (2) the requirements of the informal resolution process including the circumstances under which it precludes the parties from resuming a formal complaint arising from the same allegations; and (3) any consequences resulting from participating in the informal resolution process, including the records that will be maintained or could be shared.

[1] 34 CFR §106.1 et al.

PATAULA CHARTER ACADEMY and SPRING CREEK CHARTER ACADEMY GENDER EQUITY IN SPORTS POLICY

The purpose of this policy is to notify the public of Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy's compliance with the following laws:

- **GENDER EQUITY IN SPORTS O.C.G.A. (20-02-0315)**
- **STATE BOARD OF EDUCATION RULE: GENDER EQUITY IN SPORTS (160-5-1-.20)**
- **TITLE IX OF THE EDUCATION AMENDMENTS OF 1972**

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy prohibits discrimination based on gender in its school athletic programs. In accordance with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act, it shall be the policy of the Governing Board to undertake all reasonable efforts to provide equal athletic opportunities for members of both genders. In accordance with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act, it shall also be the policy of the Governing Board not to participate in, sponsor, or provide coaching staff for interscholastic sports events which are conducted under the authority of, conducted under the rules of, or scheduled by any athletic association unless the charter, bylaws, or other governing documents of such athletic association comply with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act.

It shall be the policy of the Governing Board to conduct a periodic assessment of its athletic programs to determine whether there are equal athletic opportunities for members of both genders. If it is determined that there are not equal athletic opportunities for members of both genders, the School District will conduct an athletic interest survey to determine student interest in various sports.

It shall be the policy of the Governing Board to accept or deny donations from any source. It shall also be the policy of the Board to encourage donations from any legitimate sources, including booster clubs. However, in order to assist the school system in maintaining compliance with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act, any donations made to athletic programs of the school system and accepted by the school must be accompanied by either a valuation of such donation or an accounting of actual costs incurred by the donor regarding the donation. Donations shall include real or personal property donated, as well as donations of services. The school shall only consider receipts of donations that conform to state and federal laws and to policies of the Board, including but not limited to, any applicable safety standards. Any gift of donation to the schools, activities, or programs shall be the property of the school and are subject to the federal, state, and local laws, policies and regulations that govern the school.

The Superintendent shall designate an individual, known as the Sports Equity Coordinator, to coordinate compliance with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act. The Superintendent, at his or her discretion, may also designate school-level coordinators to assist the sports equity coordinator. The schools shall annually notify all its students of the name, office address, and office telephone number of the Sports Equity Coordinator. This notification shall be included in the student handbook. In addition, each school shall post in a conspicuous location a notice of nondiscrimination in sports based on gender.

The Sports Equity Coordinator shall investigate any complaint received by the local school system alleging noncompliance with the Georgia Equity in Sports Act. Such investigation shall be in accordance with the grievance procedures for Gender Equity in Sports for resolution of complaints regarding gender equity in sports.

Sports Equity Coordinator:

District Athletic Director: Linda Miller
18909 Hartford St. Edison, GA
Phone: (229) 792-8957
lmiller@sccak12.net

Grievance Procedures:

1. Prior to filing a complaint, individuals should attempt to resolve their concerns by contacting the school principal and/or Athletic Director.
2. The Parent/Guardian must submit a written complaint (Letter or email) to the Sports Equity Coordinator listed above.. The complaint should include the following information: Parent's Name, Address, Student's Name, Phone, Explanation of Complaint as well as a Proposed Action, along with your signature and date.
3. The sports equity coordinator will review and investigate the claim.
4. The sports equity coordinator will render a decision in writing within 10 business days of the receipt of the grievance.
5. If the complaint is not satisfied with the response/outcome of the Coordinator's investigation, he/she may appeal the decision to the Governing Board following the procedures outlined in the Formal Appeals, Complaints, or Petitions of the Pataula Charter Academy, Inc. Public Participation at Governing Board or Committee Meetings Policy.
6. If the complainant is not satisfied with the decision of the Governing Board, he/she may appeal a decision to the State Board of Education in accordance with the procedures specified in O.C.G.A 20-2-1160.

Amended: 8-21-2023

**PATAULA CHARTER ACADEMY and
SPRING CREEK CHARTER ACADEMY
NONDISCRIMINATION POLICY**

The purpose of this policy is to notify the public of Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy's compliance with all federal and state non-discrimination statutes and regulations.

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy does not discriminate in employment or educational programs, services, or activities based on race, color, religion, national origin, sex (including pregnancy, sexual orientation or gender identity), age, disability, or genetic information. Schools will provide reasonable accommodations to applicants and employees who need them for medical or religious reasons, as required by law.

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy also provides equal access to the Boy Scouts and other designated youth groups, in accordance with state and federal laws.

It is also the policy of Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy to ensure that curriculum content and instructional materials used by our schools reflect the cultural and racial diversity found in our country and to create an awareness of the rights, duties, and responsibilities of each individual as a member of a multicultural society.

Coordinator for inquiries or complaints regarding discrimination related to the above regulations:

Title VII, Title IX, Age Discrimination, Section 504 and ADA for Employees/Adult Stakeholders	Section 504 and ADA for Students - PCA	Section 504 and ADA for Students - SCCA
Superintendent, Kylie Holley 18909 Hartford St., Edison, GA Phone: (229) 354-4002 kholley@pataula.net	PCA Special Education Director, Jodi Collins 18637 Hartford St., Edison, GA Phone: (229) 354-4001 jcollins@pataula.net	SCCA Special Education Director, Brandi Adams 2501 Vada Rd, Bainbridge GA Phone: (229) 792-8957 brandiadams@sccak12.net

Grievance Procedures:

1. If you believe that you or your child's rights under one of the above categories has been violated, you should submit the grievance in writing (letter or email) to the Coordinator listed above.
2. The Coordinator will review and investigate the claim.
3. The Coordinator will respond to the claim in writing within 10 business days of receipt of the grievance.
4. If the complainant is not satisfied with the response/outcome of the Coordinator's investigation, he/she may appeal the decision to the Governing Board following the procedures outlined in section D2: Formal Appeals, Complaints, or Petitions of the Pataula Charter Academy, Inc. Public Participation at Governing Board or Committee Meetings Policy.
5. If the complainant is not satisfied with the decision of the Governing Board, he/she may contact the US Department of Education, Office of Civil Rights, at (800)421-3481 or ocr@ed.gov.

Retaliation against a person making a report of a violation to this policy or participating in an investigation is prohibited. Confidentiality of the person making the report or a person participating in an investigation will be protected to the greatest possible extent.

Referenced statutes:

- TITLE VII: CIVIL RIGHTS ACT OF 1974
- TITLE IX: CIVIL RIGHTS ACT OF 1972
- AGE DISCRIMINATION ACT OF 1975
- SECTION 504 OF THE REHABILITATION ACT OF 1973
- TITLE II: AMERICANS WITH DISABILITIES ACT (ADA) OF 1982
- TITLE II: GENETIC INFORMATION NONDISCRIMINATION ACT OF 2008 (GINA)

Amended: 6/22/2026

**Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy
FERPA - Student Data Privacy, Accessibility, and
Transparency Annual Notification Policy**

Purpose: To provide guidance to administration in fulfilling their responsibilities to ensure that Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy operate in full compliance with The Student Data Privacy, Accessibility, and Transparency Act of Georgia and the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) which requires local education agencies who receive federal funds to notify parents and eligible students of their rights under FERPA.

Definitions:

Parent – shall, for the purpose of this document, be defined as an individual who has legal authority to act on behalf of a student as a natural parent, adoptive parent, or as legal guardian.

Eligible Student – shall, for this document, be defined as a student who has reached 18 years of age or is attending an institution of postsecondary education.

Legal Custodian – shall for this document, be defined as an entity or individual other than a parent with legal authority to act on behalf of a student. Such term shall include the Department of Juvenile Justice, The Department of Human Services, and the Division of Family and Children Service.

Education records - The term means those records that are:

1. Directly related to a student; and
2. Maintained by an educational agency or institution or by a party acting for the agency or institution.
3. Includes but not limited to:
 - a) Enrollment and attendance records
 - b) Class schedules
 - c) Transcripts and grades
 - d) Discipline records
 - e) Financial information
 - f) Health records
 - g) Special Education Records
 - h) Psychological evaluations

Personally Identifiable Information (PPI) – the term includes, but is not limited to:

- 1) Student's name
- 2) Student's parents or family members names
- 3) Student's address
- 4) A personal identifier, such as student's social security number, student number, or biometric record
- 5) Other indirect identifiers, such as student's date of birth, place of birth, and mother's maiden name
- 6) Other information that, alone or in combination, is linked or linkable to a specific student that would allow a reasonable person in the community, who does not have a personal knowledge of the relevant circumstances, to identify the student with reasonable certainty; or
- 7) Information requested by a person who the educational agency or institution reasonably believes knows the identity of the student to whom the education record relates

Directory information - means information contained in an education record of a student that would not generally be considered harmful or an invasion of privacy if disclosed. Directory information includes, but is not limited to: the student's name; address; telephone listing; electronic mail address; photograph; date and place of birth; major field of study; grade level; enrollment status (e.g., undergraduate or graduate, full-time or part-time); dates of attendance; participation in officially recognized activities and sports; weight and height of members of athletic teams; degrees, honors, and awards received; and the most recent educational agency or institution attended.

School official - shall for this document, be defined as:

- 1) District or School Administrator
- 2) Teacher
- 3) Contractor/Consultant to whom the school has outsourced institutional services or functions provided the outside party:

- a) Performs an institutional service or function for which the school would otherwise use employees;
- b) Is under the direct control of the school with respect to the use and maintenance of educational records; and
- c) Is subject to the requirements of 99.33(a) governing the use and redisclosure of PPI information from educational records.

Legitimate Educational Interests - means a school official needs access to a student's education records to fulfill their professional responsibilities related to the student's education, discipline, or related services (like counseling or financial aid). The school official must have a valid reason connected to their specific job duties and the student's educational experience.

FERPA Parent Notification Requirements:

Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) shall, in compliance with FERPA CFR §99.7, annually notify parents of students currently in attendance and eligible students currently in attendance, of their rights under FERPA. As such, the notification must include the following:

1. The notice must inform parents or eligible students that they have the right to:
 - a) Inspect and review the student's education records,
 - b) Seek amendment of the student's education records that the parent or eligible student believes to be inaccurate, misleading, or otherwise in violation of the student's privacy rights,
 - c) Consent to disclosures of personally identifiable information contained in the student's education record, except to the extent the Act and 99.31 authorize disclosure without consent; and
 - d) File with the USDOE a complaint concerning alleged failures by the educational agency or institution to comply with the requirements of FERPA
2. The notice must include all of the following:
 - a) The procedure for exercising the right to inspect and review education records, and
 - b) The procedure for requesting amendment of records
 - c) If the educational agency or institution has a policy of disclosing education records under §99.31(a)(1), a specification of criteria for determining who constitutes a school official and what constitutes a legitimate educational interest.
3. PCA/SCCA administration may provide this notice by any means that are reasonably likely to inform the parents or eligible student of their rights. At a minimum, schools will post this policy in its Policy Manual on the school website and include it in the Student/Parent Handbook.
4. PCA/SCCA shall effectively notify parents or eligible students who are disabled.
5. PCA/SCCA shall effectively notify parents who have a primary or home language other than English.

FERPA and Student Data Privacy Guidelines:

1. Accessing Educational Records:
 - a) Only school officials with a legitimate educational interest, as defined in this policy, may access student educational records, whether in digital or paper form.
 - b) School officials with a legitimate educational interest should only access the parts of a student educational record necessary to satisfy their legitimate educational interest. A legitimate educational interest may not apply to the entire student educational record.
 - c) Employees who access student educational records without a legitimate educational interest will be subject to disciplinary action, up to termination, and may be reported to appropriate agencies.
2. Disclosure of Educational Records:
 - a) Student educational records should only be disclosed to other school officials with a legitimate educational concern, parents, legal guardians, or legal custodians, as defined in this policy.
 - b) The Superintendent must approve any non-consent disclosures subject to the Act and 99.31, after consulting with school legal counsel.
 - c) School administrators may disclose directory information, but must first check to ensure no students whose parents have not opted out of directory information has been included.

Revised 7/21/2025

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy
Notification of Rights under FERPA
for Elementary and Secondary Schools

The Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) affords parents and students over 18 years of age ("eligible students") certain rights with respect to the student's education records.

*NOTE: Educational records include any health records maintained by the school.

These rights are:

(1) The right to inspect and review the student's education records within 45 days of the day the School receives a request for access.

- Parents or eligible students should submit to the School Principal a written request to review their student's complete educational record or that identifies the record(s) they wish to inspect. The School will provide an electronic copy of the requested records by 5 PM on the 3rd business day following the date of the request.
- For new students enrolling the school must notify the parent in writing within 5 business days after receiving the records from prior school(s). Within 5 days after notice, the parent may request a copy of the records received.

(2) The right to request the amendment of the student's education records that the parent or eligible student believes are inaccurate, misleading, or otherwise in violation of the student's privacy rights under FERPA.

- Parents or eligible students who wish to ask the School to amend a record should write to the School principal, clearly identify the part of the record they want changed, and specify why it should be changed. If the School decides not to amend the record as requested by the parent or eligible student, the School will notify the parent or eligible student of the decision and advise them of their right to a hearing regarding the request for amendment. Additional information regarding the hearing procedures will be provided to the parent or eligible student when notified of the right to a hearing.
- For new enrolling students, the parent can request a meeting with the Principal with the new and/or old school for the purpose of correcting content in the records, within five days after receiving a copy of the records, or at a mutually agreed upon later date.

(3) The right to privacy of personally identifiable information in the student's education records, except to the extent that FERPA authorizes disclosure without consent. FERPA permits the disclosure of PII from students' education records, without consent of the parent or eligible student, if the disclosure meets certain conditions found in § 99.31 of the FERPA regulations. Except for disclosures to school officials, disclosures related to some judicial orders or lawfully issued subpoenas, disclosures of directory information, and disclosures to the parent or eligible student, § 99.32 of the FERPA regulations requires the school to record the disclosure. Parents and eligible students have a right to inspect and review the record of disclosures. A school may disclose PII from the education records of a student without obtaining prior written consent of the parents or the eligible student in the following situations:

- One exception, which permits disclosure without consent, is disclosure to school officials with legitimate educational interests.
 - A school official is a person employed by the School as an administrator, supervisor, instructor, or support staff member (including health or medical staff and law enforcement unit personnel); a person serving on the School Board; a person or company with whom the School has outsourced services or functions it would otherwise use its own employees to perform (such as an attorney, auditor, medical consultant, or therapist); a parent or student serving on an official committee, such as a disciplinary or grievance committee; or a parent, student, or other volunteer assisting another school official in performing his or her tasks.
 - A school official has a legitimate educational interest if the official needs to review an education record in order to fulfill his or her professional responsibility.
- Upon request, the School discloses education records without consent to officials of another school district in which a student seeks or intends to enroll, or is already enrolled if the disclosure is for purposes of the student's enrollment or transfer. [NOTE: The school will make a reasonable attempt to notify the parent or student of the records request.]
- Schools may disclose, without consent, "directory" information such as a student's name, address, telephone number, date and place of birth, honors and awards, and dates of attendance. However, parents and eligible students have the right to opt out of directory information. The opt-out form is included in the Enrollment Packet. Parents must complete this opt-out form within two weeks of enrollment.
- Student Directory information will NOT be disclosed to any candidate, campaign, political action committee, or

political organization or person working for those entities. Any non-school employee who is on school property to apprise students of their right to register to vote, obligation to register for Selective Service, or arranges for or assists students to do either, must sign a statement attesting that they will not share student director information with those prohibited persons or entities.

- To authorized representatives of the U. S. Comptroller General, the U. S. Attorney General, the U.S. Secretary of Education, or State and local educational authorities, such as the State educational agency (SEA) in the parent or eligible student's State. Disclosures under this provision may be made, subject to the requirements of § 99.35, in connection with an audit or evaluation of Federal- or State-supported education programs, or for the enforcement of or compliance with Federal legal requirements that relate to those programs. These entities may make further disclosures of PII to outside entities that are designated by them as their authorized representatives to conduct any audit, evaluation, or enforcement or compliance activity on their behalf, if applicable requirements are met. (§§ 99.31(a)(3) and 99.35)
- In connection with financial aid for which the student has applied or which the student has received, if the information is necessary for such purposes as to determine eligibility for the aid, determine the amount of the aid, determine the conditions of the aid, or enforce the terms and conditions of the aid. (§ 99.31(a)(4))
- To State and local officials or authorities to whom information is specifically allowed to be reported or disclosed by a State statute that concerns the juvenile justice system and the system's ability to effectively serve, prior to adjudication, the student whose records were released, subject to § 99.38. (§ 99.31(a)(5))
- To organizations conducting studies for, or on behalf of, the school, in order to: (a) develop, validate, or administer predictive tests; (b) administer student aid programs; or (c) improve instruction, if applicable requirements are met. (§ 99.31(a)(6))
- To accrediting organizations to carry out their accrediting functions. (§ 99.31(a)(7))
- To parents of an eligible student if the student is a dependent for IRS tax purposes. (§ 99.31(a)(8))
- To comply with a judicial order or lawfully issued subpoena if applicable requirements are met. (§ 99.31(a)(9))
- To appropriate officials in connection with a health or safety emergency, subject to § 99.36. (§ 99.31(a)(10))
- To an agency caseworker or other representative of a State or local child welfare agency or tribal organization who is authorized to access a student's case plan when such agency or organization is legally responsible, in accordance with State or tribal law, for the care and protection of the student in foster care placement. (20 U.S.C. § 1232g(b)(1)(L))
- To the Secretary of Agriculture or authorized representatives of the Food and Nutrition Service for purposes of conducting program monitoring, evaluations, and performance measurements of programs authorized under the Richard B. Russell National School Lunch Act or the Child Nutrition Act of 1966, under certain conditions. (20 U.S.C. § 1232g(b)(1)(K))

(4) The right to file a complaint with the U.S. Department of Education concerning alleged failures by the School to comply with the requirements of FERPA. The name and address of the Office that administers FERPA are:

Family Policy Compliance Office
U.S. Department of Education
400 Maryland Avenue, SW
Washington, DC 20202-8520

Revised: 7/21/2025

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment (PPRA) Policy**

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to comply with the Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment (PPRA) as fully outlined in Statute: 20 U.S.C. § 1232h. Regulations: 34 CFR Part 98.

Policy Statement: PPRA is a federal law that applies to the programs and activities of a State educational agency (SEA), local educational agency (LEA), or other recipient of funds under any program funded by the U.S. Department of Education. It governs the administration to students of a survey, analysis, or evaluation that concerns one or more of the following eight protected areas:

1. political affiliations or beliefs of the student or the student's parent;
2. mental or psychological problems of the student or the student's family;
3. sex behavior or attitudes;
4. illegal, anti-social, self-incriminating, or demeaning behavior;
5. critical appraisals of other individuals with whom respondents have close family relationships;
6. legally recognized privileged or analogous relationships, such as those of lawyers, physicians, and ministers;
7. religious practices, affiliations, or beliefs of the student or student's parent; or,
8. income (other than that required by law to determine eligibility for participation in a program or for receiving financial assistance under such program).

PPRA also concerns marketing surveys and other areas of student privacy, parental access to information, and the administration of certain physical examinations to minors. The rights under PPRA transfer from the parents to a student who is 18 years old or an emancipated minor under State law.

In accordance with the Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment, Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy will abide by the following policies:

Inspection

- Parents have the right to inspect, upon request, a survey created by a third party before the survey is administered or distributed by the school to students.
- Parents have the right to inspect, upon request, any instructional material used as part of the educational curriculum for students.
- Parents have the right to inspect, upon request, any instrument used in the collection of personal information for marketing or sales purposes before the instrument is administered or distributed to a student. Personal Information given out for these purposes is limited to Student Name, Parent Name, and Address. No telephone numbers or social security numbers will ever be given out by the school.
- The procedure for a parent making either request listed above is to contact the Principal of the school by phone, email, or in person to make the request.

Student Privacy

- In the event of the administration of a survey to students containing one or more of the eight protected items of information noted above student privacy will be protected at all costs; including but not limited to:
- No outside agency (other than the state or federal department of education will be allowed to conduct protected information surveys if the surveys are not anonymous (not identifiable to a certain child.)
- Results of surveys conducted by the state or federal department of education will only be available to administration if the results are displayed in a way that student responses are identifiable to the student.
- The school will not conduct any protected information surveys that are not anonymous (not identifiable to a certain child.)

Opportunity to Opt-Out

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy will offer an opportunity for parents to opt their child out of participating in the following activities:

- The administration of any survey concerning one or more of the eight protected areas listed above if it is not funded in whole or in part with Department funds.
- Activities involving the collection, disclosure, or use of personal information collected from students for marketing purposes, or to sell or otherwise provide the information to others for marketing purposes
- Any non-emergency, invasive physical examination or screening that is 1) required as a condition of attendance; 2) administered by the school and scheduled by the school in advance; and 3) not necessary to protect the immediate health and safety of the student, or of other students. ("Invasive Physical Examination" is defined as any medical examination

that involves the exposure of private body parts, or any act during such examination that includes incision, insertion, or injection into the body, but does not include a hearing, vision, or scoliosis screening. This law does not apply to any physical examination or screening that is permitted or required by State law, including physical examinations or screenings permitted without parental notification.)

Physical Exams or Screenings

At this time Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy do not administer or allow administration of any physical examination or screening that is not permitted or required by State law, such as hearing, vision, or scoliosis screening, or physical examinations or screenings permitted without parental notification.

Notification

- Parents will be notified of their rights under PPRA and of these policies at least annually at the beginning of the school year. Notification may be through student handbooks, handouts at Open House, and/or public notices on the school's website. Parents will also be notified within a reasonable period of time if any substantive change is made to the policies.
- Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy will directly notify, such as through U.S. Mail or email, parents of students who are scheduled to participate in the specific activities or surveys covered in this policy and provide an opportunity for parents to opt their child out of participation in the specific survey or activity. The notification will be provided at least annually at the beginning of the school year and will provide the specific or approximate dates during the school year when activities are scheduled, or expected to be scheduled. If we are unable to identify the specific or approximate dates of the activities or surveys requiring specific notification at the beginning of the school year, we will provide this notification to parents once the activity or survey is scheduled.

PPRA does not preempt applicable provisions of State law that require parental notification. Also, requirements concerning activities involving the collection and disclosure of personal information from students for marketing purposes do not apply to the collection, disclosure, or use of personal information collected from students for the exclusive purpose of developing, evaluating, or providing educational products or services for or to students or educational institutions, such as the following:

1. College or other postsecondary education recruitment, or military recruitment;
2. Book clubs, magazines, and programs providing access to low-cost literary products;
3. Curriculum and instructional materials used by elementary schools and secondary schools;
4. Tests and assessments used by elementary schools and secondary schools to provide cognitive, evaluative, diagnostic, clinical, aptitude, or achievement information about students (or to generate other statistically useful data for the purpose of securing such tests and assessments) and the subsequent analysis and public release of the aggregate data from such tests and assessments;
5. The sale by students of products or services to raise funds for school-related or education-related activities; and
6. Student recognition programs.

LEGAL REF: Statute: 20 U.S.C. § 1232h. Regulations: 34 CFR Part 98.

ADOPTED: 6/20/2016

Amended: 3-26-19

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy
Notification of Rights Under the Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment (PPRA)

PPRA affords parents certain rights regarding our conduct of surveys, collection and use of information for marketing purposes, and certain physical exams. These include the right to:

· *Consent* before students are required to submit to a survey that concerns one or more of the following protected areas (“protected information survey”) if the survey is funded in whole or in part by a program of the U.S. Department of Education (ED)–

1. Political affiliations or beliefs of the student or student’s parent;
2. Mental or psychological problems of the student or student’s family;
3. Sex behavior or attitudes;
4. Illegal, anti-social, self-incriminating, or demeaning behavior;
5. Critical appraisals of others with whom respondents have close family relationships;
6. Legally recognized privileged relationships, such as with lawyers, doctors, or ministers;
7. Religious practices, affiliations, or beliefs of the student or parents; or
8. Income, other than as required by law to determine program eligibility.

· *Receive notice and an opportunity to opt a student out of*–

1. Any other protected information survey, regardless of funding;
2. Any non-emergency, invasive physical exam or screening required as a condition of attendance, administered by the school or its agent, and not necessary to protect the immediate health and safety of a student, except for hearing, vision, or scoliosis screenings, or any physical exam or screening permitted or required under State law; and
3. Activities involving collection, disclosure, or use of personal information obtained from students for marketing or to sell or otherwise distribute the information to others.

· *Inspect*, upon request and before administration or use –

1. Protected information surveys of students;
2. Instruments used to collect personal information from students for any of the above marketing, sales, or other distribution purposes; and
3. Instructional material used as part of the educational curriculum.

These rights transfer from the parents to a student who is 18 years old or an emancipated minor under State law.

Pataula Charter Academy will develop and adopt policies, in consultation with parents, regarding these rights, as well as arrangements to protect student privacy in the administration of protected information surveys and the collection, disclosure, or use of personal information for marketing, sales, or other distribution purposes. Pataula Charter Academy will directly notify parents of these policies at least annually at the start of each school year and after any substantive changes. Pataula Charter Academy will also directly notify, such as through U.S. Mail or email, parents of students who are scheduled to participate in the specific activities or surveys noted below and will provide an opportunity for the parent to opt his or her child out of participation of the specific activity or survey. Pataula Charter Academy will make this notification to parents at the beginning of the school year if the District has identified the specific or approximate dates of the activities or surveys at that time. For surveys and activities scheduled after the school year starts, parents will be provided reasonable notification of the planned activities and surveys listed below and be provided an opportunity to opt their child out of such activities and surveys. Parents will also be provided an opportunity to review any pertinent surveys. Following is a list of the specific activities and surveys covered under this requirement:

- Collection, disclosure, or use of personal information for marketing, sales or other distribution.
- Administration of any protected information survey not funded in whole or in part by ED.
- Any non-emergency, invasive physical examination or screening as described above.

Parents who believe their rights have been violated may file a complaint with:

Family Policy Compliance Office
U.S. Department of Education
400 Maryland Avenue, SW
Washington, D.C. 20202-5901

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy

Parent and Student Complaints and Grievances Policy

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to provide guidelines for parents and students for filing complaints against the school or employee of the school on any and all matters including complaints concerning Federal Programs: Title I, Part A; Title I, Part C; Title I, Part D; Title II, Part A; Title III, Part A; Title VI, Part B; the McKinney-Vento Act; School Improvement 1003(a) and 1003(g) (SIG).

Policy Statement: Students and parents have the right and responsibility to express school related concerns and grievances to the faculty and administration. Students and parents shall be assured the opportunity for an orderly presentation and timely review of concerns which will not interfere with regular scheduled classes or school related activities.

Process for Presenting a Complaint or Grievance:

Step 1: The complaint or grievance should first be presented at the lowest level of authority as follows:

- Classroom related concerns – to the Teacher
- Extra-curricular related concerns – to the Sponsor/Coach
- All other School related concerns – to the Principal

Step 2: If the Parent, Guardian, or Student does not agree with the result the complaint or grievance should be presented to the next level of authority as follows:

- Teachers – to the Principal
- Extra-curricular Sponsors/Coaches – to the Principal
- The Principal – to the Superintendent or CFO depending on the nature of the complaint

Step 3: If the Parent, Guardian, or Student does not agree with the result, an appeal may be filed with the next level of authority as follows:

- The Principal – to the Superintendent or CFO depending on the nature of the complaint
- The Superintendent or CFO – to The Board

(All official complaints must be presented to The Board in accordance with the Public Participation at Meetings of The Governing Board or Board Committees Policy section D number 2 Formal Appeals, Complaints, and Petitions.)

Responses to a Complaint or Grievance:

1. The faculty and administration shall make an honest and forthright effort to resolve complaints or grievances as quickly as possible at the most immediate level of authority.
2. Decisions rendered by the Governing Board shall be considered final.

Decorum for Presenting a Complaint or Grievance:

1. Communication MUST be respectful and in a conversational tone at all times.
2. Presenters are cautioned that personally directed statements may be slanderous or defaming, and the individual speaker is liable for his/her statements.
3. Any teacher, staff member, or administrator shall have the authority to table any meeting considered to be unproductive, threatening, hostile, inappropriate, or lacking appropriate representation.

Amended: 7/13/15

Amended: 3/20/17

Amended: 12/10/18

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Technology Acceptable Use Policy

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to provide guidelines for students and employees on the appropriate and ethical use of telecommunications technologies at Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy. These guidelines apply to all telephone, video, radio, computer network, and internet uses.

Policy Statement: Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) recognize that providing technology resources and the internet for educational purposes can provide tremendous opportunities for student achievement. PCA/SCCA also recognizes that such resources also come with a degree of risk that the users may have exposure to certain materials that are inappropriate. As such PCA/SCCA will take all appropriate measures to provide students with the understanding and skills necessary to use the technology and internet resources appropriately and in ways that meet educational needs and personal safety.

Internet and Technology Safety

PCA/SCCA will comply with the Children's Internet Protection Act (CIPA) by installing and operating appropriate filtering software to limit access to materials that are obscene, harmful to children, or otherwise inappropriate.

Technology users must NEVER give out personal or family information such as phone numbers, credit card numbers, or home addresses.

Technology users must NEVER arrange for a face to face meeting with a stranger and NEVER respond to abusive or suggestive messages. Students must report all such instances immediately to a teacher or administrator.

No technology is guaranteed to be error free or 100% dependable, nor is it safe when used irresponsibly. Among other matters, PCA/SCCA is not liable or responsible for:

1. Any information that may be lost, damaged, or unavailable due to technical, or other, difficulties;
2. The accuracy or suitability of any information that is retrieved through technology; or
3. Breaches of confidentiality.
4. The school will implement technology protection measures to ensure all users are unable to access content unsuitable for minors. These measures will be approved by the Georgia Department of Education annually. This policy will be submitted by October 15th annually.
5. PCA and SCCA use Linewize as their technology protection measure.

General Guidelines

The use of PCA/SCCA's technological resources and internet is a privilege and not a right. Students and staff may access technology only for educational purposes, and must conduct themselves accordingly by exercising good judgment and complying with this policy. Students and staff are responsible for their behavior and communications while using PCA/SCCA's network and technology resources.

School technology users shall:

1. Use or access PCA/SCCA technology resources and internet only for the purposes of research, education, and school related business and operations. Using the PCA and SCCA networks and their content for personal, political, or in support of illegal activities is prohibited.
2. Be responsible at all times for the proper use of technology, including proper use of access privileges, complying with all required system security identification codes, and not sharing any codes or passwords.
3. Respect the privacy rights of others.
4. Use appropriate language and adhere to all standards of appropriate behavior when using PCA/SCCA technology resources. (i.e. no swearing, no using vulgarities, and no use of any other inappropriate or demeaning language.)
5. Students must properly document all materials obtained through research on the telecommunications networks and then used in academic work to ensure that there shall be NO copyright violations.
6. Understand that they are responsible for ALL actions and materials posted from their accounts including all telecommunications technologies that are made available to students from outside of the school as well as when using such technologies off-campus.
7. Comply with all software licensing agreements.
8. Make all reasonable effort to maintain the integrity of technological resources from physical abuse or viruses.
9. PCA and SCCA networks, including all voice video, and data lines are the property of the school. While the school respects the user's privacy, they also have the authority to monitor activity if necessary.
10. All users accept that certain state and federal laws also apply to certain activities involving telecommunications technologies.

Ownership and Property

All devices, accounts, and network infrastructure are the property of Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA). School administrators reserve the right to confiscate or inspect any devices used on school networks when necessary. All users are expected to follow the guidelines outlined in this policy whenever they use school-issued equipment.

Unacceptable Uses of Technology include, but are not limited to:

1. Any and all illegal purposes, including but not limited to, violating any State, Federal, or International law.
2. Any and all obscene or inappropriate purposes, including but not limited to, retrieving, viewing, or distributing explicit material.
3. Accessing, sending, receiving, viewing, or downloading obscene materials, child pornography, or material that is harmful to minors

4. Any use of profanity or language that is offensive or threatening.
5. Any and all discriminatory purposes, including harassment and bullying of individuals based on race, gender, religion, sexual orientation, or disability, among others.
6. Soliciting or distributing information with the intent to incite violence, cause personal harm, damage a person's character, or to harass another individual.
7. Plagiarism.
8. Product advertisement.
9. Political advocacy.
10. Obtaining financial gain or transacting any business or commercial activities.
11. Sending pseudonym or anonymous messages.
12. Joining Chats without a teacher's permission as part of a legitimate class activity.
13. Allowing others to use technology resources without authorization, including students whose access privileges have been suspended or revoked.
14. Engaging in hacking of any kind, including but not limited to, attempting to gain or gaining unauthorized access to the accounts or files of another user.
15. In any way harming or destroying the work of another user.
16. Disrupting the use of others by, including but not limited to, knowingly downloading, spreading, or creating computer viruses, or installing unauthorized software.
17. Knowingly wasting technology resources.
18. Physical abuse of the equipment.
19. Any and all other uses that would otherwise violate the PCA/SCCA Student Code of Conduct or Employee Code of Conduct.

Violations

All suspected violations of this policy can be reported to the school principal via email or in person. These complaints will be investigated and addressed in timely manner in writing.

Staff, students, and any individuals who intentionally violate this policy while using school-issued equipment will be subject to the disciplinary actions outlined below. Violations will occur whether or not the violation occurred on school property, on a school bus or other school vehicle, at a school related function, or elsewhere.

- Loss or restriction of technology privileges
- Disciplinary action as outlined in the staff or student handbook
 - Legal consequences for violations of state or federal law

Amended: 3/20/2017

Amended: 3/26/2019

Amended: 6/23/2025

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Social Media Restrictions Policy

This policy is established in compliance with Senate Bill 351 – The Social Media Act, to safeguard students from the risks of social media use, promote digital literacy, and ensure appropriate access to online platforms through collaboration between parents, educators, and platform providers. This policy applies to all students, staff, and faculty on school property or while participating in school-sponsored activities, whether on campus or online. It governs student interaction with social media platforms during school hours and/or using school-issued devices, networks, or accounts.

In accordance with SB 351, students under the age of 18 shall not be permitted to create or maintain personal social media accounts without verified parental consent. The school will not assist or enable students to bypass age restrictions on social media platforms. Social media use by minors must comply with platform age minimums (typically 13+) and all parental consent laws.

PCA/SCCA will provide annual instruction in digital citizenship, online safety, cyberbullying prevention, and responsible social media behavior for grades 3–12. Topics will include recognizing and avoiding online predators, privacy and data protection, mental health risks associated with excessive or harmful use, and reporting inappropriate content or interactions.

Personal social media use is prohibited during instructional time unless it is part of an approved educational activity. Students may not access social media platforms using school-issued devices or the school's internet/network without specific teacher or administrative approval. The IT Department will maintain firewalls and filters to restrict unauthorized access to social media platforms on district networks.

Employees may not connect with students on personal social media platforms. Professional school-managed accounts (e.g., clubs, athletics) must be approved by administration. Employees shall model appropriate online behavior and serve as digital citizenship mentors.

Parents will be informed of this policy during enrollment and through the annual student handbook. Resources for monitoring, limiting, and guiding social media use at home will be made available on the school's website.

Violations of this policy or any incidents of cyberbullying, inappropriate or dangerous communication, online harassment, or privacy violations must be reported to a school administrator immediately. Disciplinary actions will follow the school's Student Code of Conduct and may involve counseling or referrals to law enforcement, as warranted.

Approved: 3/16/2026

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Student Attendance Policy**

Purpose: Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) believe that regular school attendance is directly related to success in academic work, provides opportunities for important communication between teachers and students, and establishes regular habits of dependability important to the future of the student. The purpose of this policy is to encourage regular school attendance for the benefit of the student.

Policy Statement: It is the policy of PCA/SCCA to expect students to be punctual and present for the entire school day. As such PCA/SCCA, Parents, Guardians, and Students shall operate under the following:

The School Day

The official PCA and SCCA school day shall begin at 7:55 a.m. and end at 3:10 p.m.

*Students must be in their assigned classroom by the beginning of the official school day to be considered on time.

Students ARE NOT allowed to enter or be left at school before 7:30 a.m.

Tardies

A student is considered tardy when he/she fails to arrive to their assigned classroom by the start of the official school day. In the event that a student is tardy he/she:

- MUST be signed in by a parent or legal guardian at the front office, or
- If the student has driven to school he/she MUST sign themselves in at the front office.

Excused Tardies

For a tardy to be classified as Excused the reason for late arrival must be the result of any reason listed herein as an accepted excuse for absence. In the event of a doctor or dental appointment or court ordered appearance an appointment card or other form of verification should be presented to the office to be kept in your child's file. Excuses for tardies must be submitted at the time of arrival or within 3 days of the tardy.

Unexcused Tardies

Tardies due to oversleeping, missing the bus, car trouble, or any other reason not classified as an Excused Tardy shall be Unexcused.

Early Dismissals

In the event that a student leaves the school after 11:30a.m. but prior to regular dismissal time it shall be classified as an Early Dismissal. Any student leaving the campus early must sign out with the front office otherwise the student will be considered truant. Any student who leaves campus without properly checking out will receive disciplinary action.

Absences

A student shall be marked absent as follows:

1. If the student does not come to school for the day,
2. If the student is checked out of school before 11:30 a.m.,
3. If the student is checked in to school after 11:30a.m., or
4. If the student accumulates 5 unexcused tardies and/or early dismissals the time out of school due to unexcused tardies and early dismissals will be calculated and every 4 hours accumulated will be counted as one (1) unexcused absence.

Absences will be designated as Excused or Unexcused. In the event of each absence, the student must return with a written note within 3

days of the absence that is signed and dated by a parent, guardian, or doctor. Notes will not be accepted after the 3rd day the student has returned to school.

Excused Absences

State law governs Excused Absences from school therefore; absences shall be considered Excused as defined by law and in the rules of the Georgia Board of Education. A student may be excused from attending school in the following circumstances:

1. Personal Illness of the student (A parent/guardian note will be accepted for illness for up to 3 separate periods of absence, however if your child has more than 3 periods of absence for illness a doctor excuse will then be required for further “sick” absences to count as an excused absence; all notes are required within 3 days of returning to school);
2. Instances where attendance by the student would endanger the health of the student or others
3. Serious Illness or Death in the immediate family;
4. Recognized Religious Holidays observed by the faith of the student;
5. Court Order or an order by a government agency, including Pre-induction Physical Examinations for service in the Armed Forces, mandating the absence from school;
6. Voter Registration or Voting, which shall not exceed 1 day, for students eligible to vote in a public election;
7. A student whose parent or legal guardian is serving in military service in the armed forces or the United States or the National Guard, and such parent or legal guardian has been called to duty for or is on leave from overseas deployment to a combat zone or combat support posting, shall be granted excused absences, up to 5 days per school year to visit with the parent or legal guardian prior to the parent or legal guardian’s deployment or during such parent’s or legal guardian’s leave.
8. Conditions rendering attendance impossible or hazardous to student health or safety.
9. Any other absence not explicitly defined herein but deemed by the School Administration to have merit based on circumstances.

Additionally, students shall be marked present and not counted as absent in the following circumstances:

1. Students serving as pages of the Georgia General Assembly shall be counted as present for days missed from school for such service;
2. Foster Care students shall be credited as present and shall not be counted as absent for any day, portion of a day, or days missed when attending court proceedings related to the students foster care.
3. Students who successfully participate in the Student Teen Election Participant (STEP) program shall be counted as present and given full credit for the school day during which he/she served in the STEP program. No student shall be permitted to be absent from school to participate in the STEP program for more than 2 school days per year.

Unexcused Absences

Absences shall be considered Unexcused any time a student is out of school for any reason that does not qualify as an Excused Absence as defined above.

Truancy

State law requires compulsory school attendance for all students between the ages of 6 and 16 years with penalties including fines and/or prison for non-compliance. Truancy is defined as more than 5 unexcused absences in a school calendar year for a student subject to compulsory school attendance. (pursuant to SBOE 160-5-1-.10) More than 5 Unexcused Absences during the school calendar year will result in the student being classified as Truant.

*School days missed as the result of an out of school suspension shall not count as unexcused absences for the purposes of determining truancy.

Extended Excused Absences

When a student misses 10 or more days of school due to illness the absences may be classified as Extended Excused Absences. In such instances the student may qualify for Hospital/Homebound (HHB) services. For a complete description of eligibility and how to apply for HHB services, see the PCA/SCCA Hospital/Homebound Services Policy.

*Students who are absent for 10 consecutive days without a parent/guardian initiating the HHB services application process will be withdrawn from the school. A certified letter, with return receipt requested, will be sent informing the parent of the withdrawal. (pursuant to SBOE 160-5-1-.28) Students withdrawn for lack of attendance are eligible for re-enrollment in accordance with the *Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Enrollment Policy*.

Notification and Actions for Truancy

In the event of excessive tardies, early dismissals, and absences the following notifications and actions shall occur:

Unexcused Tardies and Early Dismissals

5 Total of any combination of unexcused Tardies and/or Early Dismissals – Letter of Notification to the student’s Parent/Guardian(s). Once a student accumulates 5 unexcused tardies and/or early dismissals the total time out of school due to tardies and early dismissals will be calculated and every 4 hours accumulated will be counted as one (1) absence.

Unexcused Absences

- 5 Unexcused Absences - Letter of Notification to the student’s Parent/Guardian(s) and parent conference to discuss possible supports and interventions to improve attendance and to notify of further action of unexcused absences.
- 7 Unexcused Absences - Letter of Notification to the student’s Parent/Guardian(s) that 3 more unexcused absences will result in withdrawal and referral to law enforcement for possible truancy misdemeanor.
- 10 Unexcused Absences – Withdrawal from the school, a certified letter of notification will be sent to the parent/guardian; referral to law enforcement for possible truancy misdemeanor.

*If a student is withdrawn for lack of attendance and all attempts to secure proof of transfer to another school or to receive a homeschool declaration fail within 30 days of the withdrawal, then the student/parent will be referred to the Department of Family and Children Services and the local RESA Student Affairs Officer. Students withdrawn for lack of attendance are eligible for re-enrollment in accordance with the *Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Enrollment Policy*.

Determining Whether Withdrawal was to Limit Education

State Law: OCGA §20-2-785 - HB 268

If a student fails to attend school for 30 consecutive days without notification of withdrawal, enrollment in another school, or declaration of home study, and is not 16 or older who has completed the mandatory withdrawal conference, the student will be referred to the Division of Family and Children Services (DFCS) and the RESA student affairs officer of the student’s regional educational service agency. The school will assist DFCS in assessing whether the student's withdrawal was intended to avoid education and will notify RESA to verify the student’s new enrollment and the transfer of educational records. The school will make reasonable efforts to locate such students, including contacting parents or guardians, initiating wellness checks, and involving law enforcement when appropriate. Schools will also compile and promptly release the students’ complete educational records when they meet certain criteria as outlined in the statute or provide notice of transfer to another educational program.

Chronic Absenteeism and Attendance Review Teams

Per the the Georgia Department of Education:

- “Chronically absent” means the attendance status of a student whose total number of absences, whether excused or unexcused, at any time during a school year is equal to or greater than 10 percent of the total number of school days that such student has been enrolled at the same school during the current school year.
- “School chronic absenteeism rate” means the percentage of students enrolled in the school who were chronically absent during the previous school year.
- “Attendance Review Team” means a team of individuals that may consist of school administrators, counselors, teachers, and parents/guardians of students who are chronically absent.

Schools shall establish procedures to accompany this policy which support the identification and supports/interventions for students who

are chronically absent or at risk of becoming chronically absent. If the school had a chronic absenteeism rate of 10% or higher in the previous year, the school shall establish an Attendance Review Team which shall meet monthly to review individual cases of students who are chronically absent and develop intervention plans for such students and their parents/guardians.

Grievance Process

Any grievance related to this policy may be addressed through the process outlined in the *Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Parent and Student Complaints and Grievances Policy*, which can be found on the school website, Parent/Student Handbook, or requested from the front office.

Approved: 1/27/2014

Amended: 6/21/2021

Amended: 7/17/2023

Amended: 7/21/2025

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Chaperone Duties And Responsibilities Policy**

Purpose: To provide guidelines for chaperones attending school sponsored field trips.

Policy Statement: To maximize safety for all students and any parents or guardians attending school sponsored field trips, the following duties and responsibilities are required of all parent chaperones or those who attend field trips as part of Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy:

- All chaperones are required to complete an initial background check prior to going on any overnight field trip. Background checks can be completed at any sheriff's office. Background reports are good for 365 days. Chaperones are responsible for getting the background checks to the school in a timely manner. Chaperones are required to disclose information pertaining to prior arrests or convictions, regardless of the amount of time that has passed, determination of guilt or innocence, or significance of the incident. Failure to disclose may result in restriction from attending the field trip and possible restriction from attending future school sponsored field trips. If background check reveals a criminal history the Principal and/or Superintendent will make a determination if the history will prevent the parent/guardian from attending the trip. ***NOTE – Background checks should be submitted and approved PRIOR to submitting any payment for the chaperone attending the trip. The school may not be able to reimburse payments made if a background check prevents a chaperone from attending.**
 - Possible reasons for denying a chaperone/volunteer based on a background check:
 - Any crime against or related to a child
 - Violent crimes
 - Drug violations within the past 5 years
 - Other crimes that may be deemed a concern to student safety
- All chaperones must complete the Volunteer Requirements of Mandated Reporter Training and FERPA Training and provide documentation to the school prior to chaperoning.
- All adults are to refrain from being in potentially compromising situations with students or other adults.
- All students must ride in school provided transportation both to and from the field trip and during transport during a field trip to multiple locations. If parents sign a child out of school for the day, parents may transport their own children from a field trip.
- Teachers shall maintain a list of all chaperones and the students to which they are assigned. Chaperones are responsible specifically for supervision of these students; however, they also retain responsibility for general supervision and safety of all PCA/SCCA students. Chaperones should be strategically located on buses and at venues to ensure that students are adequately supervised at all times. Chaperones should ensure that all students remain seated on the bus and strictly monitor behavior on the bus. Students are expected to be quiet while in heavy traffic, when exiting/entering roads, or when crossing a railroad track. Adults observing behavior by students or other adults that is contrary to school policy or procedure shall immediately report the incident to a PCA/SCCA staff member or administrator.
- The use of cell phones and texting should be for emergency use only when acting in a supervisory capacity.
- Chaperones may not bring siblings of their child who is attending the trip or any other children not involved in the field trip. This poses a liability for the school.
- Chaperones may not leave the group or venue at any time during the course of a field trip from departure from the school to arrival at the school after the trip.
- Chaperones must be dressed in accordance with PCA/SCCA's dress code for students.
- Chaperones may not drink alcoholic beverages, utilize illegal substances, use tobacco products of any kind, or use profanity at any time during the course of a field trip from departure from the school to arrival at the school after the trip.
- Students must be escorted into and out of public bathrooms. Chaperones must at no time leave any student, even a child of a chaperone, unattended in a public bathroom.
- Chaperones must stay with the students specifically assigned to them unless a change is authorized by a PCA/SCCA staff member.
- Chaperones should bring a student that has become ill during the course of a field trip to a PCA/SCCA staff member. Parents of the student should be promptly contacted by the PCA/SCCA staff member. The PCA/SCCA staff member and chaperone will work collaboratively to ensure the child is properly attended.
- All procedures and rules specific to a field trip shall be strictly adhered to by all parents, students, and PCA/SCCA staff. Chaperones and PCA/SCCA staff are expected to participate in all activities planned as part of a field trip itinerary. Chaperones and PCA/SCCA should strictly enforce rules or procedures established as part of the PCA/SCCA Discipline Code or those established by the venue. Chaperones and PCA/SCCA staff are expected to provide direct instruction and modeling of appropriate behavior and etiquette in certain venues (e.g., restaurants, museums, etc.)

Failure to comply with all duties and responsibilities could result in a parent violation notice and/or being prohibited from chaperoning future trips.

Amended: 5/13/2024

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Disciplinary Tribunal Policy**

A disciplinary tribunal will be held within 10 school days of any serious violation or numerous violations of the Code of Conduct in which the Principal believes that a suspension of more than ten days or an expulsion is appropriate. These violations typically fall in the Level III category in the Code of Conduct but can also include repetitive Level I and Level II behaviors.

Hearing Officer or Tribunal Panel

Disciplinary tribunals will be conducted by an independent Hearing Officer or Tribunal Panel. Hearing Officers and/or Tribunal Panel members must meet at least one of the following qualifications:

- 1) Legal counsel in good standing with the State Bar of Georgia OR
- 2) Have experience as a teacher, counselor, or administrator in a public-school system
- 3) AND has completed an approved GaDOE tribunal training course.

The Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel will serve as the presiding officer and may rule on issues of procedure and admissibility of evidence presented during the tribunal. The Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel will determine if the student violated the Code of Conduct; and if the Code was violated, imposing appropriate disciplinary action. The maximum penalty that can be imposed by a Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel is permanent expulsion. Permanent Expulsion means that the student may not attend school, a school function, or be on school property (including extensions of school property).

Notice:

The School shall provide written notice of the relevant procedures to the student's parent/guardian. The notification shall include the following:

1. A brief statement of the act(s) student is alleged to have committed, along with the portion of the Code of Conduct allegedly violated.
2. The maximum penalty which may be administered for the alleged misconduct, and a recommendation for discipline.
3. A copy of this tribunal process.
4. The date, time and place of the hearing.
5. The names of witnesses expected to be called at the hearing and a short summary of evidence that may be presented.
6. A statement that a hearing is required unless the student's parent/guardian waives the hearing.
7. A statement that at the hearing the student is entitled to be represented by an advocate (spokesperson) of his/her choice, including an attorney if so desired; and that the student may subpoena witnesses and utilize other compulsory process upon request.
8. A statement that all parties are afforded an opportunity to present and respond to evidence and to examine and cross-examine witnesses.

The notice of hearing shall be delivered to the student's parent/guardian either in person, by first class mail, certified mail return receipt requested, and/or delivery confirmation, to the last known address of the parent/guardian. If notice is delivered in person, a written confirmation of delivery should be obtained by the person delivering the notice. Service shall be deemed to be perfected when the notice is deposited in the United States mail with sufficient postage addressed to the last known address of the student/parent/guardian.

Hearing Scheduling and Continuance:

If good and sufficient cause exists, the Principal may reschedule a hearing. The hearing should be scheduled within 10 school days from the date of the suspension. The hearing may be postponed for an additional five school days by mutual consent of the parents and school if the parent requests the hearing be rescheduled. Any postponement after the 15 school days requires a written request from the parents and agreement of the school.

If the student's parent/guardian requests a continuance of the hearing the request should be made to the Principal in writing. Continuances should be requested no later than 24 hours in advance of the original scheduled hearing date and time. Extenuating circumstances should be presented for approval. If a continuance is requested or caused by the student's parent/guardian, the student will continue to serve his/her recommended School level discipline during the time of the continuance and until the hearing is conducted and the Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel has rendered a decision.

If a parent/guardian withdraws the student prior to a notice of tribunal hearing the hearing may be held at the discretion of the Principal. The hearing will be held regardless of withdrawal IF the charge poses a safety risk. Parents wishing to withdraw without a hearing, may

request, in writing, to postpone the hearing indefinitely or until such time the student wishes to re-enroll at the school. The school must also accept this request to postpone the hearing beyond the 15 school days.

Waiver of Hearing:

The formal tribunal may be bypassed if the school, the student and a parent/guardian agree that the student is guilty of the charges; that the disciplinary action proposed by the school is appropriate; and that the parent/guardian will waive the student's right to a hearing. Such agreement must be reduced to writing in a formal *Tribunal Waiver Agreement* that clearly states that the student admits guilt to the charges, that all parties agree to the consequences, and that the parent/guardian and student clearly waive the right to a hearing. A signed *Tribunal Waiver Agreement* will be presented to the Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel to determine if the Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel is willing to accept the agreement as its decision. If the tribunal adopts the agreement as its decision, the decision becomes final and cannot be appealed by the School or the student's parent/guardian. If the agreement is not adopted as the decision of the tribunal, the Tribunal Waiver Agreement will become null and void, all parental rights will be restored and a new hearing date and time will be established.

Procedural Objections:

Objection to the sufficiency of the notice and/or other procedural objections shall be waived unless written notice thereof is filed with the School no less than 24 hours prior to the time the tribunal is scheduled to begin. The tribunal may be postponed until such defects have been removed or remedied.

Hearing Process

The Hearing Officer/Tribunal panel will meet at the appointed time and place to review the case. At this time, the Principal or designee will present the facts of the case against the student as well as the reason for the recommendation. The Principal/designee, the School's attorney, the student's parent/guardian or representative, and the Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel are entitled to question witnesses about any matters which are relevant to the charges against the student or the appropriate discipline. The Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel has the authority to limit unproductively long or irrelevant questioning.

The student's parent/guardian, or other appointed representative present for the hearing, will be able to ask questions and present arguments against the recommendation. The burden of proof is a preponderance of the evidence (more likely than not) and shall be on the School. The proceedings will be tape recorded for review by the school's Governing Board in the event that the tribunal's decision is appealed.

Legal Representation at the Disciplinary Tribunal:

If the student is represented by an attorney, the School's attorney will be present. The student's parent/guardian must notify the Principal not less than 3 business days prior to the tribunal if the student may be represented by an attorney. Failure to give such notice can result in the tribunal being postponed so the School's attorney may be present.

Appeals:

A parent/guardian of the student for which the tribunal was held OR the school may appeal the tribunal decision to the school's governing board by filing a written notice of appeal within twenty (20) calendar days of the date of decision. The appeal should be addressed to the attention of the school's governing Board Chair and delivered to the Board Chair or Superintendent. Appeals via email alone may be accepted but appealing parties must confirm receipt within the 20-calendar day appeal timeline. Appeals by the school must be approved by the Superintendent and Board Chair.

The appeal hearing will only be based on prior evidence and testimony. No new evidence or testimony may be presented during the appeal. The Board will listen to the recording of the tribunal hearing or be given a summary of the hearing and review the evidence presented at the tribunal hearing. The appealing party may give a brief and succinct statement as to why the decision is being appealed and the other party may make a statement in response to that.

Upon the appeal of a decision of the Hearing Officer/Tribunal Panel, the Governing Board will render its decision within 10 days, excluding weekends and holidays, from the date the school's governing board receives notice of the appeal, unless all parties agree to a different date. The Board may affirm or deny the ruling of the tribunal hearing officer/tribunal panel AND it may make any legal change to the punishment that it deems appropriate. The Board decision shall be in writing and a copy shall be provided to the student/parent/guardian, and the Principal.

The tribunal hearing, outcome of tribunal, and any appeals will be closed and privacy protected as required by state and federal law. The parties shall have the right to be represented by legal counsel during the appeal. Notice of legal representation must be disclosed to the other party no less than 3 business days prior to the appeal hearing. Failure to give this notice may postpone the hearing.

*Amended 3/26/2019

*Amended 9/19/2022

*Amended 5/12/2023

*Amended 6/17/2024

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Bullying Policy**

Policy Statement:

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy believe that all students have a right to a safe and healthy school environment. The school has an obligation to promote mutual respect, tolerance, and acceptance among students, staff, and volunteers. Behavior that infringes on the safety of any student will not be tolerated. A student shall not bully, harass, or intimidate another student through words or actions.

The school policy prohibiting bullying is included in the student code of conduct and includes but is not limited to the following:

- Any student who engages in bullying shall be subject to disciplinary action up to and including expulsion.
- Students are expected to immediately report incidents of bullying to the principal or designee.
- Students can rely on staff to promptly investigate each complaint of bullying in a thorough and confidential manner.
- If the complainant student or the parent of the student feels that appropriate resolution of the investigation or complaint has not been reached after consulting with the Director of Discipline, the student or the parent of the student should contact the Principal.
- The school prohibits retaliatory behavior against any complainant or any participant in the complaint process.

Definition of Terms:

A. Bullying:

In accordance with O.C.G.A. § 20-2-751.4, bullying means an act that is:

- 1) Any willful attempt or threat to inflict injury on another person, when accompanied by an apparent present ability to do so;
- 2) Any intentional display of force such as would give the victim reason to fear or expect immediate bodily harm; or
- 3) Any intentional written, verbal, or physical act, which a reasonable person would perceive as being intended to threaten, harass, or intimidate, that:
 - i. Causes another person substantial physical harm within the meaning of O.C.G.A. § 16-5-23.1 or visible bodily harm as defined in O.C.G.A. § 16-5-23.1;
 - ii. Has the effect of substantially interfering with a student's education;
 - iii. Is so severe, persistent, or pervasive that it creates an intimidating or threatening education environment; or
 - iv. Has the effect of substantially disrupting the orderly operation of the school. The term applies to acts which occur on school property, on school vehicles, at designated school bus stops, or at school related functions or activities or by use of data or software that is accessed through a computer, computer system, computer network, or other electronic technology of a local school system.

The term also applies to acts of cyberbullying which occur through the use of electronic communication, whether or not such electronic act originated on school property or with school equipment, if the electronic communication

- 1) is directed specifically at students or school personnel,

- 2) is maliciously intended for the purpose of threatening the safety of those specified or substantially disrupting the orderly operation of the school, and
- 3) creates a reasonable fear of harm to the students' or school personnel's person or property or has a high likelihood of succeeding in that purpose.

For purposes of this Code Section, electronic communication includes but is not limited to any transfer of signs, signals, writings, images, sounds, data or intelligence of any nature transmitted in whole or in part by a wire, radio, electromagnetic, photo electronic or photo optical system.

B. Harassment and Intimidation:

Harassment and intimidation means any gesture or written, verbal, or physical act, or any electronic communication that is reasonably perceived as being motivated either by any actual or perceived characteristic including race, color, ethnicity, religion, gender, sexual orientation, ancestry, national origin, physical attributes, socioeconomic status, physical or mental ability or disability, or by any other distinguishing characteristic, that takes place on school property, at any school-related functions or activities, on a school bus, or acts of cyberbullying which occur through the use of electronic communication, whether or not such electronic act originated on school property or with school equipment, if the electronic equipment:

- 1) is directed specifically at students or school personnel,
- 2) is maliciously intended for the purpose of threatening the safety of those specified or substantially disrupting the orderly operation of the school, and
- 3) creates a reasonable fear of harm to the students' or school personnel's person or property or has a high likelihood of succeeding in that purpose.

C. Visible Bodily Harm

In accordance with O.C.G.A. § 16-5-23.1, *visible bodily harm* is defined as bodily harm capable of being perceived by a person other than the victim and may include, but is not limited to, substantially blackened eyes, substantially swollen lips or other facial or body parts, or substantial bruises to body parts.

Prohibited Behaviors:

Bullying, cyberbullying, harassment and intimidation may include many different behaviors which ridicule, humiliate, or intimidate another student or school employee. Disciplinary action may also be necessary if off-campus behavior results in a disruption to the school environment. Examples of prohibited behaviors include but are not limited to:

- Threats, taunts and intimidation through words and/or gestures
- Physical violence and/or attacks
- Extortion
- Destruction of school or personal property
- Theft of money and/or personal possessions
- Sexual, religious, or racial harassment
- Public humiliation
- Social exclusion, including incitement and/or coercion
- Rumors or spreading of falsehoods
- Stalking
- Cyberstalking or engaging in conduct to communicate, or to cause to be communicated, words, images, or language by or through the use of electronic mail or electronic communication, directed at or about a specific person, causing substantial emotional distress to the victim
- Cyberbullying or the willful, hostile and repeated harassment and intimidation of a person through the use of digital technologies, including, but not limited to, email, blogs, social

networking websites (e.g. Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, etc.) chat rooms, texts, and instant messaging

- The use of cameras or camera phones to take embarrassing photographs of students or school employees and posting them online
- Sending abusive or threatening text messages or instant messages
- Using websites to circulate gossip and rumors to other students

Procedures for Reporting, Investigating and Discipline of Incidents of Bullying:

The procedures for intervening in bullying behavior include, but are not limited, to the following:

- All staff, students and their parents will receive a summary of this policy prohibiting bullying at the beginning of the school year as part of the student code of conduct.
- The school shall keep a report of bullying and the results of an investigation confidential.
- Staff are expected to immediately intervene when they see a bullying incident occur or upon receipt of any report of bullying.
- People witnessing or experiencing bullying are encouraged to report the incident to the school principal designee.

All students and/or staff shall immediately report incidents of bullying, harassment and intimidation to the Director of Discipline, Counselor, Principal, or designee. School staff members are expected to immediately intervene when they see a bullying incident occur. Each complaint of bullying shall be promptly investigated. This policy applies to students on school grounds, while traveling on a school bus to and from school or a school-sponsored activity and during a school-sponsored activity, by use of data or software that is accessed through a computer, computer system, computer network, or other electronic technology of a local school system or acts of cyberbullying which occur through the use of electronic communication, whether or not such electronic act originated on school property or with school equipment, if the electronic equipment

1. is directed specifically at students or school personnel,
2. is maliciously intended for the purpose of threatening the safety of those specified or substantially disrupting the orderly operation of the school, and
3. creates a reasonable fear of harm to the students' or school personnel's person or property or has a high likelihood of succeeding in that purpose.

Students, parents/guardians and other stakeholders may report incidents of bullying to an administrator, teacher, counselor or other staff member by using the school's complaint procedures or by calling the Georgia Department of Education's 1-877 SAY-STOP (1-877-729-7867) School Safety Hotline. Please note: Any form of electronic bullying (cyberbullying) using school equipment, school networks, e-mail systems or committed at school is strictly prohibited.

*Retaliation following a report of bullying is strictly prohibited and may result in strong disciplinary action.

The following actions will be taken when bullying is reported:

1. Investigate

Upon receipt of any report of bullying, schools will direct an immediate investigation involving appropriate personnel. The investigation will begin no later than the following school day. The investigation shall include interviewing the alleged perpetrator(s) and victim(s), identified witnesses, teacher(s) and staff members and reviewing video surveillance if available.

2. Notify

At an appropriate time during or after the investigation, parents/guardians of the accused and the victim must

be notified. If the incident involves an injury or similar situation, appropriate medical attention will be provided and the parent/guardian will be notified immediately.

3. Discipline

Bullying, harassment or intimidation will not be tolerated. Disciplinary action will be taken after each incident of bullying and upon a finding of guilt. Upon confirming that bullying has occurred, the accused student will be charged with bullying and given an age-appropriate consequence which shall include, at minimum and without limitation, disciplinary action or counseling as appropriate under the circumstances. Disciplinary action after being found guilty of an incident of bullying may include but is not limited to the following:

- Loss of a privilege
- Reassignment of seats in the classroom, cafeteria or school bus
- Reassignment of classes
- Detention
- In-school suspension
- Out-of-school suspension
- A combination of the above consequences
- Expulsion (through appropriate due process hearing)

Upon a finding by a tribunal hearing officer that a student in grades six through 12 has committed the offense of bullying for the third time in a school year, such student shall be assigned to an alternative school.

4. Follow Up

Follow up is important to the accused and the victim. After-care and follow up will be provided to all parties involved. If necessary, counseling and other interventions will also be provided to address the social-emotional, behavioral, and academic needs of students who are victims of bullying and students who commit an offense of bullying.

Bullying: OCGA 20-2-751.4

Amended: 3-26-19

Amended: 7-20-20

Amended: 6-21-2021

Amended: 3-21-2022

Amended: 5/20/2024

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy

Disruption of Operations of the School Policy

Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) enforce the provisions of state law as related to disruptions of operations on the school's main campus as well as any other property that counts as an extension of the campus such as bus stops and other places where school sponsored events are being hosted.

Definitions:

The School – For the purposes of this policy “The School” shall include the main campus or any property that is considered an extension of the grounds of the school including bus stops and other places where school sponsored or school related activities or events are being hosted.

Policy Statement:

PCA/SCCA will take every step appropriate to ensure the safety of its students, teachers, staff, and school administration. As such, PCA/SCCA shall enforce the following regarding disruptions of operations of the school:

In accordance with state law O.C.G.A. 20-2-1181 no individual may knowingly, intentionally, or recklessly disrupt or interfere with the operation of any the school, the school buses, or designated school bus stops. Any individual causing such disruption or interference may be ordered to stop such behavior or to leave the premises by school personnel. If the individual fails to willingly discontinue his or her behavior and/or leave the premises, school personnel should notify the appropriate law enforcement agency, and such individuals may have their visitation privileges restricted and/or may be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.

Approved: January 22, 2018

Amended: 3-26-19

PATAULA CHARTER ACADEMY/SPRING CREEK CHARTER ACADEMY

SCHOOL VISITOR AND VOLUNTEER POLICY

PCA/SCCA students, teachers and school administration have the right to expect that the school environment will be safe and free from unnecessary distractions from learning. While parents/guardians are encouraged to visit and/or volunteer PCA/SCCA, when possible, visits should be scheduled in advance. Visitors/Volunteers should check in with front office personnel upon entering the school and obtain a visitors badge. The purpose of visiting the school may include observing or volunteering in classrooms, extracurricular activities, student assemblies, and lunchroom operations. Scheduled visits shall not interfere with the instructional or non-instructional operations or the safe environment of the school.

All school volunteers, including field work chaperones, must complete Mandated Reporter Training and FERPA Privacy Training. The information for these training can be found on the school website, or you may request information in the front office. Documentation of the training should be submitted to the front office to be kept on file.

Any problems or concerns of visitors shall be discussed initially only with the Principal. Visitors shall be encouraged to refrain from reporting evaluations of personnel or operating procedures except to the Principal.

O.C.G.A. § 20-2-1181 prohibits conduct which disrupts a school. O.C.G.A. § 20-2-1182 prohibits parents from upbraiding, insulting or abusing public school employees in the presence of pupils. Disruptive individuals may be immediately removed from the school grounds and restrictions may be placed on their presence on school grounds or at school related functions in the future. The School reserves the right to refer the situation to the appropriate law enforcement authorities and the student may lose priority enrollment for the following school year.

Visitors who fail to adhere to this policy, whose visit interferes with the educational process or whose actions compromise the safety of students and school administration may have their visitation privileges restricted and/or may be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.

This policy applies to all school-related activities, on and off-campus.

Amended: 8/22/22

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Unlawful Conduct toward School Personnel Policy**

Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) enforce the provisions of state law as related to unlawful conduct toward school personnel on the school's main campus as well as any other property that counts as an extension of the campus such as bus stops and other places where school sponsored events are being hosted.

Definitions:

The School – For the purposes of this policy “The School” shall include the main campus or any property that is considered an extension of the grounds of the school including bus stops and other places where school sponsored or school related activities or events are being hosted.

Policy Statement:

PCA/SCCA will take every step appropriate to ensure the safety of its students, teachers, staff, and school administration. As such, PCA/SCCA shall enforce the following regarding unlawful conduct toward school personnel:

In accordance with state law O.C.G.A 20-2-1182 any individual at the school who has been advised that minors are present and who continues to upbraid, insult, or abuse any staff member, teacher, or administrator in the presence of and hearing of a student while on the premises of the school, may be ordered to stop such behavior or to leave the premises by the school personnel. If the individual fails to willingly discontinue his or her behavior and/or leave the premises, a school administrator should notify the appropriate law enforcement agency, and such individuals may have their visitation privileges restricted and/or may be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.

Approved: January 22, 2018

Amended: 3-26-19

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Tobacco-Free Campus Policy

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to protect the health and safety of the Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) school leaders, administration, staff, students, guests, and visitors to the campus and create a healthier and cleaner campus environment.

Definitions: For the purposes of this policy...

Smoking - is defined as the use of smoke-producing tobacco products, such as cigarettes, cigars, cigarillos, mini-cigars, and hookah.

Tobacco Use – is defined as the use of any tobacco products including, but not limited to cigarettes, cigars, cigarillos, mini-cigars, hookah, spit tobacco, snuff, and other smokeless tobacco.

E-cigarette use or Vaping – is defined as the use of electronic smoking devices or electronic nicotine delivery systems. FDA-approved cessation aids, such as nicotine patches and gum, are not included in this category.

Policy Statement: The use of tobacco (including cigarettes, cigars, pipes, smokeless tobacco, e-cigarettes, vapes, and all other tobacco products) by PCA/SCCA school leaders, administration, staff, students, guests, visitors, and contractors is prohibited on all properties owned or leased by PCA/SCCA including, but not limited to, the following:

- all interior space on the PCA/SCCA campus as well as property leased by PCA/SCCA, including any remote sites;
- all outside property or grounds on the PCA/SCCA campus, including areas such as walkways, breezeways, parking lots, and patios;
- all outside property leased by PCA/SCCA;
- all vehicles owned or leased by PCA/SCCA;
- all indoor or outdoor athletic facilities owned or leased by PCA/SCCA.

Compliance: All PCA/SCCA leaders, administration, staff, students, visitors, guests, and contractors are required to comply with this policy, which shall remain in effect at all times. Refusal to comply with this policy may be cause for disciplinary action in accordance with employee and student conduct policies. Refusal to comply with the policy by visitors, guests, and contractors may be grounds for removal from campus.

Exemptions:

1. The use of tobacco products in laboratory and classroom instruction/experiments, or for artistic purposes. All research, educational, and/or artistic purposes that involve the use of tobacco on campus must be approved in advance by the Principal.
2. Specific activities used in connection with the practice of cultural activities by American Indians that are in accordance with the American Indian Religious Freedoms Act, 42 U.S.C. sections 1996 and 1996a allow for the use of ceremonial tobacco. All ceremonial use exceptions must be approved in advance by the Principal.

Approved: 3/20/2017

Amended: 6-21-21

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy Alcohol and Drug Free School Policy

Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that Pataula Charter Academy (PCA) and Spring Creek Charter Academy (SCCA) enforce the provisions of state law and the requirements for the Drug-Free Schools and Communities Act of 1989 as related to Alcohol and Drugs on the school's main campus as well as any other property that counts as an extension of the campus such as bus stops and other places where school sponsored or school related activities or events are being hosted.

Definitions:

The School – For the purposes of this policy “The School” shall include the main campus or any property that is considered an extension of the grounds of the school including bus stops and other places where school sponsored or school related activities or events are being hosted.

Policy Statement:

PCA/SCCA will take every step appropriate to ensure the safety of its students, teachers, staff, and school administration. As such, PCA/SCCA shall enforce the following regarding Alcoholic Beverages and Drugs:

Alcoholic Beverages, Narcotics, and Stimulants:

A. Alcohol - In accordance with state law O.C.G.A. 3-3-21.1 no individual may possess any alcoholic beverage on the grounds of the school.

B. Narcotics and Stimulants - In accordance with the Drug-Free Schools and Communities Act of 1989 no individual shall possess, sell, use, transmit, or be under the influence of any narcotic drugs, hallucinogenic drugs, amphetamines, barbiturates, cocaine, marijuana, controlled substances, anabolic steroids, look-alike drugs, or intoxicants of any kind on the school grounds.

Use of a drug authorized by a medical prescription from a registered physician, and handled in accordance with the proper administrative procedures should not be considered a violation of this policy.

Incidents involving the possession, sale, and/or use of (including being under the influence of) alcoholic beverages, drugs, or any other behavior affecting substances while at, in, or in route to the school, shall be handled in accordance with appropriate administrative procedures.

School personnel should notify the appropriate law enforcement agency in the event that any individual is in violation of the law with regard to any illegal substance as previously described, and such individuals may have their visitation privileges restricted and/or may be prosecuted to the full extent of the law.

Approved: January 22, 2018

Amended: 3-26-19

Pataula Charter Academy Inc.
Parents' Bill of Rights Policy and Procedure

Purpose: To provide for the protection of the fundamental rights of parents to direct the upbringing and education of their minor children from undue infringement

Policy Statement: It is the policy of Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy to protect parents' rights to be involved and engaged in the education of their children enrolled in our schools.

Definitions:

- 'Instructional material' means instructional materials and content, as defined by the State Board of Education pursuant to Code Section 20-2-1010, and locally approved instructional materials and content
- 'Minor child' means a person who is less than 18 years of age and who has not been emancipated by operation of law or by court order pursuant to Code Section 15-11-727 or as otherwise provided by law.
- 'Parent' means a person who has legal authority to act on behalf of a minor child as a natural or adoptive parent or a legal guardian.
- 'Review period' means the first two weeks of each nine-week grading period of the school year.

Regulations and Procedures:

The Governing Board shall consult with parents, teachers, and administrators to develop and adopt this policy to promote parental involvement. Such policy shall be updated each year by June 1. This policy shall be posted on the schools' websites and is available on site at each school upon parent request.

1. Procedures for a parent to review records relating to his or her minor child – Any parent of a student enrolled or previously enrolled at Pataula Charter Academy or Spring Creek Charter Academy has the right to access and review all records relating to his or her minor child, including, but not limited to, current grade reports and attendance records, unless otherwise prohibited by law. Parents or eligible students should submit to the School Principal a written request to review their student's complete educational record or that identifies the record(s) they wish to inspect. The School will provide an electronic copy of the requested records by 5 PM on the 3rd business day following the date of the request. For new students enrolling the school must notify the parent in writing within 5 business days after receiving the records from prior school(s). Within 5 days after notice, the parent may request a copy of the records received.
2. Procedures for requesting a transfer for education records to another school or a person or entity authorized to receive such records – Parents wishing to withdraw their student to attend another school must complete and sign the Student Withdrawal form and/or have the new school request records. Once the request is made records will be sent to the new school by 5PM on the 3rd business day following the date of the request. If a parent wishes to authorize release of their student's education record to another agency other than for school enrollment, they must make the request in writing to the Principal. Once the request is made records will be sent to the new school by 5PM on the 3rd business day following the date of the request.
3. Parents also have the right to access information relating to promotion and retention policies and high school graduation requirements. Promotion and Retention policies and graduation requirements can be found in the Parent/Student Handbook which can be found on the school website. These can also be requested in the main office at the school.

4. Procedures for a parent to learn about his or her minor child's courses of study, including, but not limited to, parental access to instructional materials intended for use in the classroom. - Instructional materials intended for use in his or her minor child's classroom shall be made available for parental review during the review period upon request by a parent. The request should be made in writing (email or letter) to the school's Principal. The Principal shall produce such information for inspection within a reasonable amount of time not to exceed three business days of receipt of the request. In those instances where some, but not all, information requested is available for inspection within three business days, the Principal shall make available within that period such information that is available for inspection. In any instance where some or all of such information is unavailable within three business days of receipt of the request, and such information exists, the Principal shall, within such time period, provide the requester with a description of such information and a timeline for when the information will be available for inspection and shall provide the information or access thereto as soon as practicable but in no case later than 30 days of receipt of the request. If the Principal denies the request or fails to provide the information within 30 days, the parent may appeal to the Governing Board pursuant to the Pataula Charter Academy Inc. Parent and Student Complaints and Grievances Policy. A parent aggrieved by the decision of the Governing Board may appeal such decision to the State Board of Education.

5. Procedures for a parent to object to instructional materials intended for use in his or her minor child's classroom or recommended by his or her minor child's teacher – Parents who object to instructional materials intended for the use in his/her minor child's classroom shall make a written (email or letter) objection to the school's Principal. The objection must include the following:

- a. Student's name
- b. Student's grade level
- c. Subject/Course of the objectionable instructional materials
- d. Name of the teacher who teaches the subject/course
- e. Description of the instructional material which is being objected
- f. Reason for the objection

The Principal shall give a response to the objection and possible alternative instructional materials within 5 business days. Parents who are aggrieved by the Principal's response may appeal to the Governing Board pursuant to the Pataula Charter Academy Inc. Parent and Student Complaints and Grievances Policy.

6. Procedures for a parent to withdraw his or her minor child from the school's prescribed course of study in sex education if the parent provides a written objection to his or her minor child's participation.

- a. Parents will be notified in advance of such course content so that he or she may withdraw his or her minor child from the course
- b. Parents may request in writing (email or letter) that his/her child not participate in the course. The request should be addressed to the Principal.

7. Procedures for a parent to provide written notice that photographs or video or voice recordings of his or her child are not permitted, subject to applicable public safety and security exceptions – The Enrollment form upon entering school requires parents to choose if they allow or do not allow photographs or recordings of his/her child. If at any time a parent chooses to change their selection on this matter, he/she must request in writing (email or letter) to have this changed in the student's file. The request should be made to the Principal.

Amended 7/21/2025

POLICY FOR THE "PROTECT STUDENTS FIRST ACT"

A. Definitions:

1. "Divisive Concepts" means any of the following concepts, including views espousing such concepts:
 - a. One race is superior to another race;
 - b. The United States of America is fundamentally racist;
 - c. An individual, by virtue of his or her race, is inherently or consciously racist or oppressive toward individuals of other races;
 - d. An individual should be discriminated against or receive adverse treatment solely or partly because of his or her race;
 - e. An individual's moral character is inherently determined by his or her race;
 - f. An individual, solely by virtue of his or her race, bears individual responsibility for actions committed in the past by other individuals of the same race;
 - g. An individual, solely by virtue of his or her race, should feel anguish, guilt or any other form of psychological distress;
 - h. Performance-based advancement or the recognition and appreciation of character traits such as hard work ethic are racist or have been advocated for by individuals of a particular race to oppress individuals of another race; or
 - i. Any other form of race scapegoating or race stereotyping.
2. "Espousing personal political beliefs" means an individual, while performing official duties as part of his or her employment or engagement with a school or local school system, intentionally encouraging or attempting to persuade or indoctrinate a student, school community member, or other school personnel to agree with or advocate for such individual's personal beliefs concerning divisive concepts.
3. "Race scapegoating" means assigning fault or blame to a race, or to an individual of a particular race because of his or her race. Such term includes, but is not limited to, any claim that an individual of a particular race, consciously and by virtue of his or her race, is inherently racist or is inherently inclined to oppress individuals of other races.
4. "Race stereotyping" means ascribing character traits, values, moral or ethical codes, status, or beliefs to an individual because of his or her race.

B. Requirements:

1. Employees are prohibited from discriminating against students and other employees based on race.
2. Curricula and training programs encourage employees and students to practice tolerance and mutual respect and to refrain from judging others based on race.
3. Schools may provide curricula or training programs that foster learning and workplace environments where all students, employees, and school community members are respected; provided, however, that any curriculum, classroom instruction, or mandatory training program, whether delivered or facilitated by school personnel or a third party engaged by a school or local school system, shall not advocate for divisive concepts.
4. Nothing in this policy shall be construed or applied to:
 - a. Inhibit or violate the rights protected by the Constitutions of Georgia and the United States of America or undermine intellectual freedom and free expression;
 - b. Infringe upon the intellectual vitality of students and employees schools;
 - c. Prohibit schools from promoting concepts such as tolerance, mutual respect, cultural sensitivity, or cultural competency; provided, however, that such efforts do not conflict with the requirements of Code section 20-1-11 and other applicable laws;
 - d. Prohibit a school administrator, teacher or other school personnel, or an individual facilitating a training program from responding in a professionally and academically appropriate manner and without espousing personal political beliefs to questions regarding specific divisive concepts raised by students, school community members or participants in a training program;
 - e. Prohibit the discussion of divisive concepts, as part of a larger course of instruction, in a professionally and academically appropriate manner and without espousing personal political beliefs;
 - f. Prohibit the full and rigorous implementation of locally approved curriculum linked to Georgia Standards of Excellence, Advanced Placement, International Baccalaureate Diploma Program, dual enrollment coursework, or elements of such curricula; provided, however, that such implementation is done in a professionally and academically appropriate manner and without espousing personal political beliefs;
 - g. Prohibit the use of curricula that addresses the topics of slavery, racial oppression, racial segregation, or racial discrimination, including topics relating to the enactment and enforcement of laws resulting in racial

oppression, segregation, and discrimination in a professionally and academically appropriate manner and without espousing personal political beliefs;

- h. Create any right or benefit, substantive or procedural, enforceable at law or in equity, by any party against a local board of education, local school system, or other school, or the departments, agencies, entities, officers, employees, agents, or any other personnel affiliated with such local board of education, local school system, or other school; or
- i. Prohibit a state or federal court or agency of competent jurisdiction from ordering training or other remedial action that discusses divisive concepts due to a finding of discrimination, including discrimination based on race.

C. Complaint Resolution:

1. The school shall not be required to respond to a complaint made pursuant to this policy unless it is made by:
 - a. A parent or legal guardian of a student enrolled at the school where the alleged violation occurred;
 - b. A student who has reached the age of majority or is a lawfully emancipated minor who is enrolled at the school where the alleged violation occurred; or
 - c. An individual employed as a school administrator, teacher, or other personnel at the school where the alleged violation occurred;
2. The complaint shall first be submitted in writing to the principal of the school where the alleged violation occurred;
3. The complaint shall provide a reasonably detailed description of the alleged violation;
4. Within five (5) school days of receiving the complaint; the school principal or designee shall review the complaint and take reasonable steps to investigate the allegations contained in the complaint;
5. Within ten (10) school days of receiving the complaint, the school principal or designee shall confer with the complainant;
 - a. The school principal or designee shall inform the complainant whether a violation occurred, in whole or in part;
 - b. If a violation occurred, in whole or in part, the school principal or designee shall inform the complainant of what remedial steps have been taken or will be taken; provided that the confidentiality of student or personnel information shall not be violated;
 - c. Another schedule may be mutually agreed upon by the complainant and the school principal or designee regarding this ten (10) days response limit.
6. Following such conference, within three (3) school days of a request by the complainant, the school principal or designee of the school shall provide to the complainant
 - a. A written summary of the findings of the investigation, and
 - b. A statement of remedial measures, if any, provided, however, that such written response shall not disclose any confidential student or personnel information.
7. The determinations provided above shall be reviewed by the superintendent within ten (10) school days of receiving a written request for such review by the complainant addressed to the superintendent; provided, however, that confidential student or personnel information shall not be subject to review pursuant to this paragraph;
 - a. The decision of the superintendent following the review provided for in the subparagraph above shall be subject, within a reasonable length of time, to review by the Governing Board as provided for in Code Section 20-2-1160; provided, however, that confidential student or personnel information shall not be subject to review pursuant to this subparagraph.
 - b. The decision of the governing board following the review provided for in the paragraph above shall be subject to review within in a reasonable length of time by the State Charter Schools Commission, whereupon the State Charter Schools Commission shall take appropriate remedial measures, including, but not limited to, revocation of a state charter school's charter; provided, however that confidential student or personnel information shall not be subject to review pursuant to this subparagraph.
8. Nothing in this policy shall be construed to prohibit any cause of action available at law or in equity to a complainant who is aggrieved by a decision of the governing body or the State Charter Schools Commission.

D. Records Request

1. Any individual described in this policy shall have the right at any time, including prior to filing a complaint, to request, in writing, from superintendent or school principal non confidential records which he or she reasonably believes may substantiate a complaint under this policy. The superintendent or school principal shall produce such records for inspection within a reasonable amount of time not to exceed three business days of receipt of a request.

2. In those instances where some, but not all, of the records requested are available for inspection within three business days, the superintendent or school principal shall make available within that period such records that are available for inspection.
3. In any instance where some or all of such records are unavailable within three business days of receipt of the request, and such information exists, the superintendent or school principal shall, within such time period, provide the requester with a description of such records and a timeline for when the records will be available for inspection and shall provide the records or access thereto as soon as practicable but in no case later than 30 days after receipt of the request.
4. If the superintendent or school principal denies a parent's request for records or does not provide existing responsive records within 30 days, the parent may appeal such denial or failure to respond to the governing board. The governing board must place such appeal on the agenda for its next public meeting. If it is too late for such appeal to appear on the next meeting's agenda, the appeal must be included on the agenda for the subsequent meeting.
5. Nothing in this subsection shall be construed to prohibit any cause of action available at law or in equity to a parent who is aggrieved by a decision of a local board of education or the governing body of a charter school made pursuant to this policy.

Approved: 7/18/2022

PATAULA CHARTER ACADEMY, INC.
HIGH SCHOOL GRADUATION REQUIREMENTS

Pataula Charter Academy and Spring Creek Charter Academy comply with minimum Georgia State Board of Education rules and policies regarding high school graduation requirements, credit transfers, and awarding of credit to students as found in State Board Rule 160-4-2-.48.

I. PURPOSE. This Rule specifies programs of study that shall be offered by local boards of education for students enrolling in the ninth grade for the first time in the 2008-2009 school year and for subsequent years.

II. DEFINITIONS.

- (a) Academic, Career and Essential Skills (“ACES”) Diploma – the document awarded to students with the most significant cognitive disabilities who were assessed using the alternate assessment aligned to alternate academic achievement standards. While this diploma is standards-based and aligned with the state requirements for the regular high school diploma, it is not a regular high school diploma. Therefore, the provision of an ACES diploma in itself does not terminate Free and Appropriate Public Education (FAPE) for students with an Individualized Education Program (IEP).
- (b) Career, Technical and Agricultural Education (CTAE) Pathways – Three elective units in a coherent sequence that includes rigorous content aligned with industry-related standards leading to college and work readiness in a focused area of student interest.
- (c) Core Courses - courses identified as “c” or “r” in Rule 160-4-2-.20 List of State-Funded K-8 Subjects and 9-12 Courses.
- (d) Elective Courses – any courses identified as “e” in Rule 160-4-2-.20 List of State-Funded K-8 Subjects and 9-12 Courses that a student may select beyond the core requirements to fulfill the unit requirements for graduation.
- (e) Georgia Alternate Assessment (GAA) – an alternate assessment based on alternate academic achievement standards. The GAA is a standardized, task-based assessment with multiple access points designed for students with significant cognitive disabilities under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) whose Individualized Education Program (IEP) team has determined they are unable to meaningfully access the regular assessment program, even with maximum appropriate accommodations. The purpose of the GAA is to ensure that students with significant cognitive disabilities are provided access to the state academic content standards and given the opportunity to demonstrate achievement of the knowledge, concepts, and skills inherent in the standards.
- (f) Required courses - specific courses identified as “r” in Rule 160-4-2-.20 List of State-Funded K-8 Subjects and 9-12 Courses that each student in a program of study shall pass to graduate from high school.
- (g) Secondary School Credential - a document awarded to students at the completion of the high school experience. See Types of Credentials at Section III below.
- (h) Significant Cognitive Disabilities - to students with significant intellectual disabilities or intellectual disabilities concurrent with motor, sensory or emotional/behavioral disabilities who require substantial adaptations and support to access the general curriculum and require additional instruction focused on relevant life skills and participate in the Georgia Alternate Assessment (GAA).

- (i) Unit of Credit – one unit of credit awarded for completing two consecutive semester courses or one year-long course with a passing grade AND completing the corresponding EOC (if applicable); ½ credits awarded by a single semester
- (j) Unit of Credit, Credit Recovery – one unit of credit awarded for completing a Credit Recovery course with a passing grade; ½ unit of credit awarded for only completing an A or B section of a Credit Recovery course.

III. TYPES OF CREDENTIALS

(a) High School Diploma (a/k/a Regular Education Diploma)- the document awarded to students certifying that they have satisfied attendance requirements, unit requirements and the state assessment requirements as referenced in Rule 160-3-1-.07 Testing Programs - Student Assessment. Types of High School Diplomas Seals at PCA/SCCA:

i. *Dual Enrollment Seal – Completed all regular graduation requirements AND completed at least 4 Dual Enrollment credits.*

ii. *CTAE Pathway Seal - Completed all regular graduation requirements AND meets requirements for CTAE Pathway Completer*

**Students may earn both seals.*

(b) High School Certificate (a/k/a Certificate of Attendance)- the document awarded to pupils who do not complete all of the criteria for a high school diploma or who have not passed the state assessment requirements as referenced in Rule 160-3-1-.07 Testing Programs – Student Assessment, but who have earned 23 units.

(c) ACES Diploma – the document awarded to students with the most significant cognitive disabilities who were assessed using the alternate assessment aligned to alternate academic achievement standards.

IV. GRADUATION REQUIREMENTS

(a) Units of Credit and Course Requirements for Graduation. A student shall become eligible for graduation upon meeting the minimum units of credits required for their diploma type.

- i. High School Diploma- A student shall become eligible for graduation upon meeting the State Board of Education minimum of 23 completed units of credit as detailed in the following chart.

Areas of Study	Units of Credit
English Language Arts One English class in each year of high school, including Literature and Composition I and Literature and Composition II, and 2 additional units of ELA	4
Mathematics Algebra Concepts and Connections, Geometry Concepts and Connections, Advanced Algebra Concepts and Connections, and a 4th Math Unit	4

Science Biology, Physical Science or Physics, Environmental Science or Chemistry, and a 4th Science Unit	4
Social Studies World History, United States History, United States Government, Civics (1 semester), and Economics (1 semester)	3
Career, Technical and Agricultural Education, Fine Arts, Modern Language Students must earn 3 credits, in any combination, from these three curriculum areas.	3
Health and Physical Education ½ credit for Health and ½ credit for PE. Each course is one semester in length	1
Electives Electives can be taken in any curriculum area.	4
Total Credits Required to Graduate	23

*Students planning to attend a 4-year college or university immediately after high school must earn a minimum of 2 credits in a modern language.

Students with Significant Cognitive Disabilities who entered the ninth grade for the first time prior to the 2020-2021 school year may graduate and receive a regular high school diploma when the student's IEP team determines that the student has:

- i. completed an integrated curriculum based on the Georgia Performance Standards (GPS) that includes instruction in Mathematics, English/Language Arts, Science and Social Studies as well as career preparation, self-determination, independent living and personal care to equal a minimum of 23 units of instruction, and
- ii. participated in the GAA during middle school and high school, and
- iii. reached the 22nd birthday OR has transitioned to an employment/education/training setting in which the supports needed are provided by an entity other than the local school system.

- ii. ACES Diploma - Students with Significant Cognitive Disabilities who entered the ninth grade for the first time on or after the 2020-2021 school year may graduate and receive an ACES Diploma when the student's IEP team determines that the student has:

- i. completed an integrated curriculum based on the GPS that includes instruction in Mathematics, English/Language Arts, Science and Social Studies as well as career preparation, self-determination, independent living and personal care to equal a minimum of 23 units of instruction, and
- ii. participated in the GAA during middle school and high school, and
- iii. reached the 22nd birthday OR has transitioned to an employment/education/training setting in which the supports needed are provided by an entity other than the local school system.

(b) Course Credit.

- i. Courses that shall earn unit credit are listed in Rule 160-4-2-.20 List of State-Funded K-8 Subjects and 9-12 Courses for Students Entering Ninth Grade in 2008 and Subsequent Years.
- ii. Unit credit shall be awarded only for courses that include concepts and skills based on the GPS or Common Core Georgia Performance Standards (CCGPS) for grades 9-12 or

those approved by the State Board of Education. Unit credit may be awarded for courses offered in the middle grades that meet 9-12 GPS or CCGPS requirements. The IEP, if applicable, shall specify whether core courses taken as part of an IEP shall receive core unit credit.

iii. No course credit may be awarded for courses in which instruction is based on the GPS for grades K-8.

iv. Credits earned at another accredited school will automatically transfer to our schools. For information on awarding credits from a home school or a non-accredited school, see the *Pataula Charter Academy Inc. Policy for Grade Placement and Acceptance of Transfer Credit/Grades from Home Study or Non-Accredited Programs of Study*.

V. AREAS OF STUDY

(a) English Language Arts: Four units of credit in English language arts shall be required of all students. A full unit of credit in Literature and Composition I and a full unit of credit in Literature and Composition II, and two additional units shall be required.

(b) Mathematics: Four units of core credit in mathematics shall be required of all students, including Mathematics I or GPS Algebra, or its equivalent; AND Mathematics II or GPS Geometry, or its equivalent; AND Mathematics III or GPS Advanced Algebra or its equivalent; AND one additional math course.

i. The mathematics requirements above apply to each student with a disability, consistent with his or her IEP. Students with disabilities who earn credit in Mathematics I or GPS Algebra and the associated mathematics support course, and Mathematics II or GPS Geometry and the associated mathematics support course, may upon determination through the IEP Team meet mathematics diploma requirements by completing Mathematics III or GPS Advanced Algebra for a total of 3 mathematics core credits. Successful completion of 3 core units of mathematics may not meet the mathematics admission requirements for entrance into a University System of Georgia institution or other post-secondary institution without additional coursework.

(c) Science: Four units of credit in science shall be required of all students, including one full unit of Biology; one unit of either Physical Science or Physics; one unit of either Chemistry, Earth Systems, Environmental Science or an AP/IB course; and one additional science unit.

(d) Social Sciences: Three units of credit shall be required in social studies. One unit of credit shall be required in United States History. One unit of credit shall be required in World History. One-half unit of American Government/Civics shall be required. One-half unit of Economics shall be required.

(e) CTAE/Modern Language/Latin/Fine Arts: A total of three units of credit shall be required from the following areas: CTAE and/or Modern Language/Latin and/or Fine Arts. Students are encouraged to select courses in a focused area of interest.

i. Career, Technical and Agricultural Education (CTAE) Pathways: Students may earn three units of credit in a coherent sequence of CTAE courses through a self-selected pathway leading to college readiness and a career readiness certificate endorsed by related industries.

ii. Modern Language/Latin: All students are encouraged to earn two units of credit in the same modern language/Latin. Students planning to enter or transfer into a University System of Georgia institution or other post-secondary institution must take two units of the same modern language/Latin. Technical College System of Georgia institutions do not require modern language/Latin for admissions.

1. Students whose native language is not English may be considered to have met the foreign language expectation by exercising the credit in lieu of enrollment option if they are proficient in their native language. A formal examination is not necessary if other evidence of proficiency is available.
2. American Sign Language may be taken to fulfill the modern language requirements.

iii. Fine Arts: Electives may be selected from courses in fine arts, if offered.

(f) Health and Physical Education: One unit of credit in health and physical education is required. Students shall combine one-half units of credit of Health (17.011), Health and Personal Fitness (36.051), or Advanced Personal Fitness (36.061) to satisfy this requirement.

VI. GRADUATION EXERCISES

(a) Only students who have met all graduation requirements will be allowed to participate in the graduation ceremony and other graduation-related events. Summer graduates may participate in the following year's ceremony if they so choose.

(b) Students who are assigned to Alternative School may not participate in graduation ceremonies or events.

VII. RESPONSIBILITY FOR ADMINISTERING GRADUATION REQUIREMENTS

It is the responsibility of the School Counselor and/or the Principal to ensure that students have been given information on graduation requirements; making every attempt to ensure students are on track to graduate in 4 years, have the courses they need to be eligible for college admission and HOPE scholarship if the student expresses interest in college, AND making every attempt to ensure all students complete a Pathway.

It is also the responsibility of the School Counselor AND the Principal to ensure that students have met all graduation requirements prior to graduation ceremonies and graduation reports are sent to the state.

Approved: 06/16/2025

**Pataula Charter Academy and
Spring Creek Charter Academy
Cell Phone/Electronic Devices Policy**

Purpose: The purpose of this policy is to abide by the Georgia “Distraction-Free Education Act” related to the use of cell phones and other personal electronic devices during school hours.

Definitions:

1. 'Access' means viewing, holding, wearing, or otherwise using a device for the purpose of communication, internet access, gaming, recording, listening to music, or any other function commonly associated with personal electronic devices.
2. 'Bell-to-bell' means the period beginning with the first bell signaling the start of instructional time and ending with the final bell signaling the conclusion of the school day and shall include all scheduled instructional time, breaks, transitions, assemblies, and other school related activities occurring between the start and end of the school day.
3. 'Distraction-free education' means a learning environment where access to personal electronic devices is restricted to minimize distractions, improve academic outcomes, and increase meaningful interactions and focused learning experiences.
4. 'Personal electronic device' means any portable electronic device capable of transmitting, receiving, or accessing communications, data, or media. Such term includes, but is not limited to, smartphones, smartwatches, tablets, e-readers, headphones, and other devices with functionalities such as wireless communication, internet access, messaging, video recording, gaming, social media access, or data transmission.
5. 'School day' means the bell-to-bell period for students receiving instruction on a school campus. Such term shall not apply to students receiving virtual or remote instruction away from a school campus.
6. 'School equipment' means any computer or computer networking equipment, technology or technology related device or service, or communication system or service that is operated, owned, leased, and made available to students by a local board of education, local school system, or public school and that is used for transmitting, receiving, or accessing communications, data, or media.

Policy Statements:

1. Students are prohibited to access personal electronic devices during school hours while on school campus.
2. The teacher/coach in charge of a school-sponsored off-campus event/activity may allow electronic device use, upon his/her discretion, during non-instructional times. The teacher/coach must make the expectation clear at the beginning of the event/activity.
3. It is recommended that personal electronic devices not be brought into the school building at all, but if they are they should be stored in a locker, purse, backpack, or secure location in the classroom. They may not be kept on the student's person (in hand, in pockets, etc.) or be visible.
4. All communication between parents and students during the school day will go through the front-office. The school will communicate with parents directly in the event of an emergency, and parents may contact the school directly if they need to communicate with their child.
5. Students found in violation of the policies and procedures set forth in this policy and the Student Handbook will be subject to progressive consequences in accordance with the Code of Conduct.
6. A student whose IEP, 504 Plan, or medical plan explicitly mandates the use of personal electronic device for medical or educational purposes shall be permitted to access the device as necessary to

fulfill the requirements of the respective program or plan.

7. The Principal, or designee, is responsible for appropriate monitoring and enforcement mechanisms to ensure compliance with this policy and related procedures, as well as reviewing the effectiveness of the policy/procedures to adjust as necessary to ensure its continued alignment with educational goals and student well-being.
8. Parents, guardians, and students will be informed of this policy and related procedures through the Student/Parent Handbook, which included the Code of Conduct, and on the school website.
9. Nothing in this policy shall be construed or applied to prohibit or limit the use of school issued technology used for educational purposes.

Approved: 6/23/2025

Edna Mae McGovern Act

Water Safety Information

The Edna Mae McGovern Act was enacted in an attempt to reduce/eliminate drowning deaths in children. Water safety education is the first step. Below are websites with water safety education information:

Red Cross -

<https://www.redcross.org/get-help/how-to-prepare-for-emergencies/types-of-emergencies/water-safety.html>

CDC - <https://www.cdc.gov/healthyschools/bam/safety/water-safety.htm>

National Drowning Prevention Alliance - <https://ndpa.org/10-open-water-safety-tips/>

The ability to swim is another important step in reducing drowning. You can use the link below to find swimming lessons near you:

Find Swimming Lessons near you - <https://www.redcross.org/take-a-class/swimming/swim-lessons>

*We are not aware of any specific free or reduced-priced courses or lessons in our attendance area.

Special Assistance Alternative Community Eligibility Provision

PUBLIC MEDIA RELEASE

NATIONAL SCHOOL LUNCH/SCHOOL BREAKFAST PROGRAMS

By participating in the Community Eligibility Provision (CEP) and eliminating the need for meal applications, **Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy** will reduce administrative and printing costs. Families also benefit from the elimination of completing and submitting meal applications.

Children need healthy meals to learn. **Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy** offers healthy meals every school day at no charge to your child(ren). Our food service receives support from the U.S. Department of Agriculture through the National School Lunch and School Breakfast Programs.

The following schools will be participating in this alternative provision and provide meals at no charge to children during School Year 2026-2027:

Pataula Charter Academy/Spring Creek Charter Academy

Nondiscrimination Statement: This explains what to do if you believe you have been treated unfairly.

In accordance with Federal civil rights law and U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) civil rights regulations and policies, the USDA, its Agencies, offices, and employees, and institutions participating in or administering USDA programs are prohibited from discriminating based on race, color, national origin, religion, sex, disability, age, marital status, family/parental status, income derived from a public assistance program, political beliefs, or reprisal or retaliation for prior civil rights activity, in any program or activity conducted or funded by USDA (not all bases apply to all programs). Remedies and complaint filing deadlines vary by program or incident.

Persons with disabilities who require alternative means of communication for program information (e.g., Braille, large print, audiotape, American Sign Language, etc.) should contact the State or local Agency that administers the program or contact USDA through the Telecommunications Relay Service at 711 (voice and TTY). Additionally, program information may be made available in languages other than English.

To file a program discrimination complaint, complete the USDA Program Discrimination Complaint Form, AD-3027, found online at [How to File a Program Discrimination Complaint](#) and at any USDA office or write a letter addressed to USDA and provide in the letter all of the information requested in the form. To request a copy of the complaint form, call (866) 632-9992. Submit your completed form or letter to USDA by: (1) mail: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Office of the Assistant Secretary for Civil Rights, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Mail Stop 9410, Washington, D.C. 20250-9410; (2) fax: (202) 690-7442; or (3) email: program.intake@usda.gov.

USDA is an equal opportunity provider, employer, and lender.

Updated: April 02, 2026

DIABETES

A guide for parents

86 percent
OF CHILDREN WITH
DIABETES HAVE
TYPE 1
DIABETES



WHAT IS DIABETES?

Diabetes is a **chronic condition** that affects how the body processes **blood sugar** (glucose). With proper care and treatment, diabetes can be managed and children can live healthy and active lives.

IMPORTANCE OF GLUCOSE

Glucose is the **primary energy source** for the body's cells.

ROLE OF INSULIN

Insulin is a natural hormone that **turns food into energy** and manages your blood sugar level.

DIABETES

TYPE

1

is an autoimmune condition where **the body attacks insulin-producing cells in the pancreas**. Insulin is vital for regulating blood sugar level.

RISK FACTORS

- Family history of type 1 diabetes
- Genetic make-up

SCREENING PROCESS

BLOOD TESTS:

Checking blood sugar levels through random blood sugar tests or fasting blood sugar tests.

A1C TEST: EARLY DETECTION SCREENING

A screening test may be ordered by your child's doctor if a family member has type 1 diabetes. The test can detect type 1 diabetes before symptoms occur.

STAGES OF DIABETES

- 1** Normal blood glucose without symptoms.
- 2** Elevated blood glucose without symptoms.
- 3** Significant loss of insulin-producing cells and symptoms appear.

DIABETES

TYPE

2

is when the body becomes resistant to insulin or the pancreas **doesn't produce enough insulin**.

RISK FACTORS

- Family history of type 2 diabetes
- Obesity or overweight
- Low level of physical activity
- Unbalanced diet high in sugars, fats + starch
- Certain ethnic backgrounds (eg., African American, Hispanic, Native American)

SCREENING PROCESS

BLOOD TESTS:

Checking blood sugar levels through random blood sugar tests or fasting blood sugar tests.

GLUCOSE TOLERANCE TESTS:

Measures blood sugar before and after consuming a sugary drink.

A1C TEST:

Measures average blood sugar levels over the past 2-3 months.



Healthy eating + Physical activity

CAN HELP PREVENT
TYPE 2
DIABETES

COMMON SYMPTOMS (TYPE 1 & TYPE 2)

- Urinating often
- Feeling very thirsty
- Feeling very hungry
- Extreme fatigue
- Blurry vision
- Cuts/bruises that are slow to heal
- Weight loss – even though you are eating more (TYPE 1)
- Tingling, pain, or numbness in the hands (TYPE 2)

If your child exhibits any of these symptoms, ask your healthcare provider about screening for diabetes.



If your child is diagnosed with diabetes, **talk to their healthcare provider** about an appropriate **diabetes management plan**.

For more information or support, visit dph.georgia.gov/diabetes



Pataula Charter Academy

Administrative Roles and Responsibilities (Problem Resolution Chain of Command for PARENTS)

Please use this chart to determine to which administrative staff you should address questions and/or concerns as well as for chain of command for complaints. For complaints, you should always begin with the person responsible for the area of your complaint. (This also applies to classroom issues. If you have a concern with your child and/or his/her teacher, please contact the teacher first.) If no resolution is reached, you should contact that person's direct supervisor until the issue is resolved satisfactorily. (example – teacher, Principal, Superintendent, Governing Board)

Responsibilities	Person Responsible (1st line of Contact)	Direct Supervisor (2nd line of contact)
All general questions should be directed to the Secretary. She can answer questions about the school calendar, class schedules, school events, etc.	Secretary – Nikki McCarter	Christina Boyd
Responsible for all student records. She handles student enrollment, withdrawal, attendance, etc.	Data Clerk – Lyn Adkinson/Amanda Fryer	Christina Boyd
Handles the school nutrition applications and fees.	SNP Director/Office Clerk - Polly Chapman	Christina Boyd
Oversees all GHSA Student Eligibility, Coaches, Athletics, and Athletic Events.	Athletic Director -Brian Barnhill	Linda Miller (District AD)
Handles athletic and fundraising finances, coordinates all school/sports pictures, and other school/sports related paperwork.	Athletic Coordinator and Administrative Assistant - Julie Richey	Christina Boyd
Handles state testing, Pre-K, and oversees implementation of academic curriculum and school model.	Assistant Principal – Fallyn Riles	Christina Boyd
Handles school discipline, oversees school safety procedures and transportation, and basic day-to-day operations	Assistant Principal - Brian Barnhill	Christina Boyd
Handles intervention, and oversees implementation of academic curriculum and school model.	Assistant Principal - Casey Cleveland	Christina Boyd
Handles discipline appeals; oversees all teachers, instructional paras, school events; handles high school college/career planning, and oversees implementation of academic curriculum and school model.	Principal – Christina Boyd	Kylie Holley
MTSS Coordinator-Oversees SST/MTSS Process	Elizabeth Knox	Casey Cleveland
Student Advocacy Specialist-Coordinates behavior and mental health interventions.	Angel Benton	Christina Boyd
Oversees the Special Education Program including all Special Ed teachers/paras, and 504 Plans.	Jodi Collins	Casey Cleveland
Oversees Financials, School Safety, Facility Maintenance, School Nutrition, and Transportation. *According to the Complaints Policy, if the chain of command has been followed, she will handle complaints or appeals in these areas AFTER the school Principal has been contacted.	CFO/Business Director - Cheryl Weathersby	PCA Governing Board
Oversees all aspects of the school, other than those areas for which the CFO/Business Director is responsible. * According to the Complaints Policy, if the chain of command has been followed, she will handle complaints or appeals in these areas AFTER the school Principal has been contacted.	Superintendent – Kylie Holley	PCA Governing Board

Principal - Christina Boyd –cboyd@pataula.net

Superintendent - Kylie Holley – kholley@pataula.net

Board Chair - Lindsey Hixon - lhixon@pataula.net

Spring Creek Charter Academy
Administrative Roles and Responsibilities
(Problem Resolution Chain of Command for PARENTS)

Please use this chart to determine to which administrative staff you should address questions and/or concerns as well as for chain of command for complaints. For complaints, you should always begin with the person responsible for the area of your complaint. (This also applies to classroom issues. If you have a concern with your child and/or his/her teacher, please contact the teacher first.) If no resolution is reached, you should contact that person's direct supervisor until the issue is resolved satisfactorily. (example – teacher, Principal, Superintendent, Governing Board)

Responsibilities	Person Responsible (1st line of Contact)	Direct Supervisor (2nd line of contact)
All general questions should be directed to the Secretary. She can answer questions about the school calendar, class schedules, school events, etc.	Secretary – Jacqueline Gilbert	Heather Worsley
Responsible for all student records. She handles student enrollment, withdrawal, attendance, etc.	Data Clerk –Keri McLane	Heather Worsley
Handles the school nutrition applications and lunch fees.	SNP Director - Polly Chapman	Cheryl Weathersby
Oversees all GHSA Student Eligibility, Coaches, Athletics, and Athletic Events.	Athletic Director - Alan Beckett	Linda Miller (District AD)
Handles school discipline, oversees school safety procedures and transportation, and basic day-to-day operations	Assistant Principal – Becca Sawyer	Heather Worsley
Handles school discipline, oversees implementation of academic curricula, school events, and school model implementation.	Assistant Principal - Samantha Leverette	Heather Worsley
Handles all counseling, school and career guidance, state testing, implementation of academic curricula, and high school programs.	Assistant Principal/Counselor- Julie Bellflower	Heather Worsley
Handles discipline appeals, oversees all teachers, instructional paras, and oversees all areas of instruction.	Principal – Heather Worsley	Kylie Holley
Oversees all Special Ed teachers and paras and oversees the SST/MTSS process and 504 Plans.	Special Education and MTSS - Brandi Adams	Heather Worsley
Oversees Financials, School Safety, Facility Maintenance, School Nutrition, and Transportation. *According to the Complaints Policy, if the chain of command has been followed, she will handle complaints or appeals in these areas AFTER the school Principal has been contacted.	CFO/Business Director - Cheryl Weathersby	PCA Governing Board
Oversees all aspects of the school, other than those areas for which the CFO/Business Director is responsible. * According to the Complaints Policy, if the chain of command has been followed, she will handle complaints or appeals in these areas AFTER the school Principal has been contacted.	Superintendent – Kylie Holley	PCA Governing Board

Heather Worsley– hworsley@sccak12.net
Kylie Holley – kholley@sccak12.net
Lindsey Hixon, Board Chair - lhixon@pataula.net